

The fifth Hour

*The Moment You
Can't Escape*



Mind bending thriller
of the year that will leave
you breathless

-Times of India

RAHUL JAIN



The Fifth Hour

Rahul Jain

Paper Towns



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Praise for Rahul's writing

“Rahul's writing is original, and his characters are boldly built.”

“The presentation is widely imaginative with beautiful settings.”

“The plot is realistic and portrays a deep understanding of human emotions.”

“Narration is crisp and engaging.”

“Use of words is simple yet engaging.”

“Rahul's stories are filled with different emotions, including grief, that force a reader to think deeply.”

Prelude

God must have been in high spirits when He decided to create a human — and must have been startled by the most fascinating outcome of His effort. Then, He infused the body with a soul, bringing the human to life.

The result was a single body that could comprehend various things at once through its five senses and then, through its unconscious state, absorb and express different feelings.

The human, one of the most complex creatures, capable of anything, is unaware of its prowess. Its goodness and its fallacies.

The light tries to bring forth the real face of this human, but a part remains. The leftover is called a shadow. Even the light cannot diminish the shadow's existence.

These shadows represent the dark side of the human, and they follow humans wherever they go. These shadows talk amongst each other. When the light disappears, the shadows merge with the dark, bouncing from one object to another. They hold vicious secrets of your being, which they pass in the dark with other shadows, whispering words as the air ceases to stir and time stands still. They instil a feeling the human is most afraid of — fear.

The shadow is nothing but a side of you that you are unaware of—dark, vicious, shape-shifting, and oblivious of its existence.

Look around yourself. Are you afraid of your shadow?

You should be.

Love

RJ

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And last but not least, thank you, the world of fiction, for making me feel like your own, for allowing me to choose you as the purpose of my life.

Missing

*The muffled cries of the wounded spread through the unholy night
As the once pristine valley was marred with the blood
of the wandering souls
The moon cried, the clouds hid their distress
And the leaves rustled in a discordant symphony*

Day 1

Hungover

Rati

That morning, the rain tried to wash away most of the sins committed the night before. The valley shook in distress, and the trees uprooted themselves in response to the horror they had witnessed. The breeze stopped blowing in accord with the melancholy, and the birds took to their nests to shelter their young ones from the damp. The animals retreated to safety under boulders and inside dilapidated houses, and the humans covered themselves with blankets as they waited out the storm.

The lightning bolt woke me up. The flash was so bright, and my sleep so fitful, that my eyes opened before the sound of the thunder reached my ears. As I sat upright, legs still under the blanket, I noticed that I was drenched in sweat. The kind that stains pillows yellow. I was reminded of when Ayaan bugged me to buy a dryer at home.

Ayaan was not on his side of the bed. He was probably washing down the tequila we had last evening, always ready to win the competition for the last human standing. He was one of those who were always prepared with cut lemon and salt on the brim of the shot glass. The ones with loud laughter, stumbling steps, and no thought of whether the floor was beneath them. The one who ensures two love birds spend the night drinking and call it 'one hell' of a party.

I checked the time — 6:30 a.m. In the hilly boonies, the skies lie. Unlike in cities where you can look up at the skies and guess what time of the day it might be, here the sky keeps you wondering, almost saying: "Oh, you naive tourist! Guess where the needles of the clock are pointing right now?" Only the locals could keep up with the ambiguity of the various shades of the sky and the darkness of the clouds, with the weather it entailed and the time it told.

I decided to stay longer in bed as my head continued to throb. I reminded myself never to drink so much again, especially since we planned to have a baby. We thought alcohol in our blood would help us make

passionate love. I do not remember if we even touched each other, let alone create a new life. Tequila, never again. I needed a cup of extra strong coffee to overcome this babalaas.

I called Ayaan's name loudly to check if he was in the bathroom but heard nothing back. I guessed he might have passed out on the couch or stepped outside to get me a cappuccino.

After a few months of trying to conceive, the gynaecologist advised us to cut off from work and discover each other again in a far-off place, away from humanity. "Go to those not-so-reachable areas, those mountains which do not have a mobile network. Explore, get passionate, and forget the world. Conceiving is as much an act of mind as it is of the flesh."

We loved her advice. More than anything, it had come at the right time, as we both needed a break. Even though I had left my job a few months back, my mind was anxious about getting pregnant and how our lives would change after the baby was born. Ayaan had recently joined a start-up and was putting all his energy into ensuring that the equity he received during the offer would be vested based on his superlative performance. He aspired to make it the 'college fund' for our kids. He was busier than usual, but given that it was for the baby and our future, I did not mind.

I kept myself busy with short projects back home—remodelling our kitchen to have an Italian breakfast counter, changing the wallpaper of the bar wall, making the baby nursery, and making the home baby-proof. My exactingness with worldly things was back, and Ayaan reminded me that I needed a distraction before I went doolally.

So here we were, in the northern part of Sikkim, in this beautiful village called Dzongu, in Mr Fernandez's Shine Resort. This was a homestay with independent luxury cottages, advertised as a resort, probably to attract opulence-loving cohorts who did not mind the harmless skulduggery, as the hosts were hospitable. The cottage where we were staying was luxurious yet homely—much better than our penthouse back in Gurgaon.

The double-storied cottages at the resort were mostly wood. The ground floor had a large living room, an open kitchen on one corner, a media area in another corner, the fireplace in the middle of one side, one corner marking the entrance, and the last corner vacant, in case the guests wanted to have a workout on that thick carpet. One could do yoga or have a

passionate quickie by the fireplace. The top floor had a restroom with a shower, a bathtub, a small bar, and a lavish master bedroom, which opened to a large balcony, with a view of the Himalayas.

The view from the balcony started with a green pasture, merging into dense forests, ending with a range of low hills bordered by snow-packed mountains on the horizon. It was an artist's paradise, and Mother Nature stimulated my innate desire to paint at Dzongu. This cottage could have been my very own atelier. As a miniaturist, I could bring life to multiple canvases and highlight details that would have bedazzled any viewer. I resolved to paint something before leaving Dzongu.

I looked at my wristwatch — the time was 6:52 a.m. Ayaan would return soon, and I thought of returning to sleep. I switched my pillow with his. His pillow was dry and cold like he had never slept on it.

I caught hold of the copper bottle beside the bed and drank the last remaining sip of water. Still feeling parched, I rolled my tongue over my parched lips, once, twice, and then one more time till they became moist, and I tasted a bit of blood, probably from the cracks that must have developed on the side of my lips. I also tasted salt, which was obviously from last night's tequila.

I lay down and slowly closed my eyes, and heard the sound of rain beating against our room's glass windows.

I returned to my slumber, wondering how Ayaan would have managed to go out in this weather.

As my eyes closed, the raindrops seemed to convey what the water-laden clouds were trying to abrase at that very moment— the blood, the prints, the memories, and the sounds of the last breaths taken by helpless souls.

Nausea

Rati

He ran behind me in the scary night, his hands raised as if to stifle my neck. His body seemed more like a ghastly shadow in the pale moonlight. My screams never left my mouth as I ran past the Eucalyptus trees, and the only sounds in the dark were of the dead leaves crepitating under my scared steps. Even the animals of the forest did not come to my rescue. They were equally petrified of the monster.

I looked back, and my eyes searched for the shadow – it was nowhere to be seen. As I turned forward again to continue running, a hand abruptly extended from behind a tree trunk, grabbing my neck and lifting me off my feet. I tried to breathe but couldn't. My eyes were drawn to what was scribbled on the trunk of that tree – “Ayaan loves Rati.” I searched for my attacker's face, which was covered with a muffler, and as my fingernails tried to scratch this beast's hand, I saw him waving an axe in my direction. Panic hit me, and my eyes opened before the axe could assail me.

The sun's rays coaxed the birds into thinking everything was normal and last night was an aberration in the otherwise dry season. After much convincing, they chirped, and the leaves shed the last drops of water onto the damp grass.

I had woken up gasping for air; the dream felt too real. It was 9:12 a.m. when my eyes opened again, and the sun shone brightly. We had forgotten to draw the curtains last night, and the sun wasted no opportunity to peer in through the glass. The rain had restricted its damage to the balcony. Petrichor filled the air. Water from a tot brook made its way through the edges of the balcony's slider door entrance, defying the rules and daring to enter the room.

I thought about the nightmare that had alarmed me and the others that had haunted me for the last few years. At Ayaan's vehement insistence, I started seeing a therapist. Still, even with the therapist's help, I had not yet figured out who the people in my recurring nightmares could be. Or what my nightmares represented.

Ayaan wasn't back in the room yet. He must probably be downstairs, sipping his coffee or enjoying some of the bread omelettes Ms Fernandez would have served us. Or cereal, as he had told me he was craving last night.

I lazily removed the duvet and left the bed, my head still spinning. My throat was parched, and I rolled to Ayaan's side to grab hold of his bottle. He still had the half-filled Bisleri by his side, something we had taken from the city market last morning. This was weird. Did he not drink any water at all last night?

I gulped the water down, all too hastily, and while my head stopped spinning for a bit, the acid reflux from my stomach returned as if it was angry that I subdued it with mineral water.

I rushed to the washroom, plodding over the carpeted wooden floor, and chucked up all the nachos and tequila from the previous night. It went on for a few seconds till my stomach cramped. I stood up, holding the wall for support, and managed to flush. My thoughts went haywire, and I could feel the delirium kicking in. I could see black spots before my eyes, and the tiny stars from last night were now twinkling in front of the bathroom mirror.

I put my palms on the granite countertop and turned on the Jaquar water faucet. I brushed my teeth in an attempt to overcome the nausea from before. I splashed water on my face before looking at myself in the mirror.

My face looked like hell, and I noticed a slight bruise. The dark circles had returned, and I cursed myself for forgetting to pack the concealer.

"You look beautiful with or without makeup, Rati." Ayaan was back in my thoughts. He used to smile reassuringly, look into my eyes, and give me that fervent look that always mesmerised me. His words always cast a spell on me, and even though I am a self-assured woman, I relished his affectionate validation. I hated giving anyone that power—the power to manipulate me because of my naivety. It was tough for me to trust even my closest friends.

As I dried my face with the hand towel, I switched on the geyser to take a much-needed shower. The water would take time to warm up, but a hot shower would help my soul return to this world, which was now traversing the world of hangovers. The nightmare from earlier lingered in my mind.

I peeked from the door before stepping out of the bathroom, hoping that the man from the dream had not teleported into reality. Or was that world real, and the current moment but a dream? It was hard to tell, as I was still in a state of trepidation. The alcohol flowing in my veins added fuel to the fire.

I visualised the attacker sitting on the bed, ready with an axe. I came out of the bathroom, treading lightly so the trespasser would not know of my entry into the room. I now had a full view of the room — the attacker wasn't there, and so wasn't Ayaan.

I was relieved about the attacker but concerned about Ayaan. Where the hell was he? I checked my mobile, but there was no network. This was even more frustrating—it meant I could do nothing but sit around and wait for him to show up.

The bitter taste in my mouth returned. I thought it would be better to go down and grab a bite before my nausea worsened. Perhaps my handbag had an antacid or two. I remembered keeping them in anticipation of all the intoxication and irregular meal routines we would go through on that trip.

I sauntered down the carpeted stairs. The silence in the cottage felt eerie, and the only saving grace was the bright, sunny weather outside. The sun tried its best to brighten the cottage, peeking through all the glass walls and windows, and even making it through the keyhole adorning the cottage door.

I called out Ayaan's name again as I reached the ground floor. There was a vast open area at the bottom of the stairs. I could see every corner, but still, I hoped that Ayaan would pop in from somewhere, telling me that he had been hiding just to hear me scream. He would tell me that it was a cheap prank he had been plotting all along, which involved jumping from behind the breakfast counter.

He wasn't in the cottage, though. It was odd. Was he taking one of those official calls from his start-up at this hour? Maybe he had stepped out to search for a mobile network outside the cottage. Only he could do an abysmal deed like that on vacation – waking up early after a night of heavy drinking. Sneaking out to get his office work done, as I lazed under the comforter. Finishing his Tabata before I woke up so that he would not have to give me any explanations. It was typical Ayaan.

I wouldn't be surprised if he brought office work to Dzongu, where we were supposed to cut off from the real world and get lost in each other.

Whenever I caught him in the act on such occasions, he would tease me with a pinch on my love handles and top it with a tight hug. Ayaan was capable of all this and much more. I had the urge to see him then, and I looked outside the window to check if he was rambling barefoot on the lawn outside the cottage. It is beneficial for the heart, he would say.

My nose caught a whiff of coffee and omelette, and I thought I'd grab a bite before stepping out to look for Ayaan. The geyser would anyway take about twenty more minutes to do its job.

Ms Fernandez, referred to as *Aunty* by the guests and staff, may have come inside sometime back — Ayaan would have let her in, as the breakfast was still hot. If he was in, he would have come upstairs and kissed me good morning, but he did not, which was odd. Did I do something to upset him?

The breakfast was delicious; Aunty stuffed the double omelette inside the bread with love and expertise. The bread was toasted with the right amount of butter. The eggs had been beaten thoroughly, the onion and chillies were fried to the same colour, and the tomatoes and capsicum sauteed to bring out the perfect smoky flavour. Her food tasted so delicious that Ayaan and I concluded that our limited good karma had given us the opportunity to devour those dishes — even if it was only for a few days.

A sip of the piping hot coffee rich with sugar and cream opened my eyes. The vapours from the cup brought hope in the icy cold stillness in the room. It felt like the numb parts of my body had returned to life after that caffeine kick. I smiled as I finished my last sip, leaving the rest in the thermos for my love.

“Be right back.”

I saw the note under the fruit basket and immediately felt relieved that he had left some sort of message, and I finished my breakfast peacefully.

I let more light in, drawing back those heavy blackout curtains from the two windows. The light instantly made its way in, brightening the room and changing my mood. I opened the door and took a deep breath, absorbing the view and the warmth of the sun. I tied my hair in a bun and thought of getting dressed before Ayaan returned. Maybe he was already ready? That could not be, as the bathroom floor was all dry. This could be one of those rare opportunities when I'd be decked up to go out before him. Relationships and their cute battles.

I removed my Crocs and walked over to the lawn, wet from the rain earlier. The grass hid the puddles, and my feet felt tingly. A bird chirped

somewhere in the vicinity, and the leaves on the trees fluttered in the breeze, welcoming my presence. The soil felt mushy, and I loved it. With the sun shining and the ground that cold, I felt upbeat, and the hangover seemed to be subsiding.

I looked at our beautiful cottage. Lawns abutted two sides of the cottage — one led to an orchard and further to Ms Fernandez's home, with more cottages hidden between the trees. Those were probably reserved for families, each with an extra room in the vacant corner of the ground floor.

The cottages were the best examples of beautiful and sturdy stilt houses. Mr and Ms Fernandez must have given a lot of thought before deciding to raise the houses to protect them from vermin, floods, or landslide debris. It made the cottages look like they were floating in the air. Almost.

The cottage we were staying in was towards the end of the resort and secluded, as if it was a couple's paradise, hiding the revelry that went on inside it. The right side of the cottage, where the balcony was on the upper floor, overlooked a pasture, the forest, and the mountains. The left side was a sparsely spotted tea plantation in this area, existing in harmony with the rest of the flora, respecting the boundaries that confined them. The back of the cottage was just a few feet from the cliff's precipice, which dropped five hundred feet to a copse of trees. Even though the trees were not eucalyptus, like the ones in my dream, the resemblance to that setting was uncanny. I wondered what would happen if someone slipped and fell to their death. Only those trees and the stream of water beside them would bear witness to their inevitable end. I shuddered at that thought; it felt all too real.

The sun reminded me of the good times, and the hope that we would conceive on this trip was still alive. We would return as three lives, and just not two consenting adults in a live-in relationship. Our choice to not get married but still have a kid would be too difficult for society to digest, but we did not need a piece of paper to celebrate our love for each other and the bond it signified. A baby could do that, and Ayaan was on board, as always.

I went upstairs and got out of my dirty clothes — a pair of shorts and a T-shirt I had arrogated from Ayaan. I stepped inside the bathroom and turned on the shower. As the space filled with steam, I scrubbed myself clean, removing all traces of vomit and sweat. I applied the cheap menthol conditioner from Shine Resort on my hair. I enjoyed the hot water playing

with my skin. As the water got more alluring, it felt like every drop would burn through my skin and reach my bones. Somehow, I felt aroused.

I opened my eyes, returning to the real world — the steam had filled the bathroom, and my breathing had become laboured. I turned off the shower immediately, gasping for oxygen. I felt nauseated again. It took a few seconds for the steam to dissipate, leaving the walls and mirror wet. Drops of water trickled down to the bottom, finding their way to the drain.

As my eyes followed one such water drop, I spotted blood in the drain. It wasn't much, and I could have been wrong, but I wondered where the red hue would otherwise come from. It struck me suddenly that because of my PCOS, my periods might have come early. I checked myself; it did not seem like I had gotten them, but still, it might have explained continued nausea, pain, irritability, and blood.

I dried myself, and there was no trace of blood anywhere anymore. I returned to recheck the drain cap, and except for a strand of hair or two, it was spotlessly clean. I wondered if I was hallucinating.

I put on a co-ord set and thanked God that my period had not come early. Today was the 15th day after my last period, which should have meant that I was ovulating. Ayaan and I were sure that this trip had the blessings of *Goddess Kamakhya* and that getting pregnant was in our destiny. Everything was just meant to be, and my periods coming now would have been a dampener.

Or was I already pregnant? We had sex twice since my last period, including one awkward attempt the previous morning, which was purely mechanical. Pregnancy might explain the nausea and spotting. I decided to take a pregnancy test later in the evening. I made a mental note to remind Ayaan about it.

I started drying my hair. The watch displayed 11:05 a.m. Ayaan should have been back by now.

I went to the balcony to see if I could spot Ayaan on the path connecting our cottage to Aunty's house. I could not see him but noticed the odd railings — the small equidistant pillars that supported a parapet wall. I felt like they were staring at me. Those once white walls, now marred by algae, rain, and years of decay, were crying for a quick makeover.

I recalled my conversation with Ayaan from the previous day. A butterfly had been sitting at one end of the parapet wall since we checked in. I was sure it was a Monarch. "Interesting story behind it, babes," he

paused and continued, “---- it is the common Tiger Butterfly, found in India. However, until a few decades ago, it was mistaken to be a Monarch exclusively found in the US. But let’s call it a Monarch. What do you say?” I nodded, as I was not interested in naming that weird creature. Today, once again resting at the same place, it seemed like it wanted to tell me a story, and I suddenly felt nauseous again.

When I entered the room, it felt odd. The air was heavier than usual, and the calm was eerie. I felt the presence of another person in the room, and my nose picked up an unfamiliar odour. I could tell it wasn’t Ayaan. I felt scared, as if this presence would choke me, too.

I heard footsteps behind me, and without delay, my body jettisoned itself outside the room as though it had a mind of its own.

I ran down the steps to the main door of our cottage, unable to scream, just like in the dream last night.

Absence

Rati

The sun's rays and the butterflies seemed to block my escape. The slippery rocks looked unconcerned about my plight, and the trees seemed to close in on me as I ran for my life toward Ms Fernandez's cottage. My nightmare was coming true, and I could feel the presence of the sinister stranger somewhere nearby. I could not wait any longer, hoping Ayaan would come and save me. I had to get out of here.

The two-hundred-foot distance seemed like a marathon. Looking back in dread, I couldn't see anything human-like following me. I was now convinced it was a ghoul after me, camouflaging itself in the resort's vast expanse. I reached Aunt's door and knocked hard like all hell had broken loose. A clap of thunder startled me, and I looked up at the clouds. The sun hid behind them, making everything dark and gloomy.

Aunt opened the door with deep concern, and I saw her young nephew standing beside her with a bat in his hand. Her eyes kept searching mine for an answer, eager to understand what had made me bang on her door hysterically in the middle of the day.

"What happened, Ma'am?" She asked, her eyes looking through me as if the answer to her question hid behind me.

"That..." I was still catching my breath. "That man in the room..." I blurt out the incoherent words, still panting from the effort. Her nephew would not hear anything more. He clasped the bat tightly and signalled to his aunt that he would investigate who the miscreant could possibly be. Aunt and I followed him, with me walking behind Aunt like a scared puppy.

In their company, the walk back to my cottage seemed normal. Birds chirped. Wind swooshed. And the sun shone again. The butterflies did not follow me; they searched for nectar instead. The rocks weren't slippery anymore but felt solid against the soles of our shoes. The world had changed in the last few seconds.

The three of us entered my cottage, one step at a time, forming something like a Cantabrian circle to alert each other of ‘danger’ if the intruder attacked from any direction. We searched the house, starting from the ground floor, climbing one step at a time to the top floor, searching the bedroom, the bathroom, and finally, the balcony. None of us spoke a word during this hunt.

Shyam, Aunt’s nephew, finally broke the circle and looked at Aunt and me. “Whoever it was is not here anymore. I will look around the house again and around the periphery, too. I want to see if I can trace something.” He continued the search as Aunt looked at me empathetically.

“My poor kid, you must be so scared.”

I was shivering with fear, and Aunt rubbed my palms in hers, blowing hot air into them to warm me further. Maybe it was not only her actions but her intentions, too, that helped. I shivered less and could finally speak.

“I don’t know where Ayaan has gone. I am so worried.” I started crying, tears flowing down my face as if walls of vulnerability were broken. I told her he had left a note on the countertop stating he was gone, but his being out for so long was unusual.

Aunt looked around with concern. She breathed deeply and reassured me, “He will be here soon. If he has left a note, then yes, he will come back soon. And if he doesn’t return in a few hours, Shyam can always go looking for him.”

Shyam was back at our balcony door, his look making it clear that he could not find anyone. He looked at me with doubt, as if his adrenaline rush had been wasted on a hoax call and I was responsible for it. He judged me with his weird squint, patchy beard, and skeleton arms.

“I am going back to the cottage, Aunt,” he said, slowly turning his head back while staring at me; his passive aggression made me uncomfortable. His look reminded me of the puberty-struck fellows who lustily ogle a woman, and when the woman’s partner is around, these predators feign naivete — a jackal pretending to be a fawn.

“Do you want to come and sit with us for a little while, dear?” Aunt asked, her hands now rubbing my back gently.

I thought of Shyam being at the cottage with his uncomfortable stares and compared it to the possibility of someone jumping on me from a corner when I was alone at my cottage. I chose the former.

“Once Ayaan is back, I will come back to the cottage. But for now, I can’t stay alone. Too scared,” I whimpered, and Aunty nodded in response.

Our slow and heavy steps were noisy against the dead leaves. Our movements from earlier had left faint footprints on the wet soil, which remained damp after the morning shower.

Two families came in as I reached the reception at the main cottage. Their toddlers and hyperactive kids increased the decibel levels of the otherwise serene surroundings. The energy among the group members was infectious, including those of the men who looked at me as if I were a damsel in distress and turned to their wives, who looked at me as a broken piece, alone, probably stranded, and let out sympathetic ‘tsk tsk’ from their mouths at my plight. I almost wanted to laugh but stopped myself, continuing my nonchalant stance. Let them have their moment. Let them feel their lives are better than mine. Let them judge me if that helps them sleep peacefully at night. They can go fuck in peace for all I cared.

I stood up and noticed Shyam leaving the house, the keys of his Moped hanging out of his fist. He saw me, paused momentarily, and then thought otherwise, leaving the premises in his Moped.

I went up to Aunty, who was back after telling those happy families about touristy spots where they could click beautiful social media-worthy family pictures.

“Ayaan and I need to go shopping today – lots of good stuff in the market,” I said, looking at Aunty. She looked at me blankly, her face devoid of expression.

“Why don’t you call him?” She asked me, and I knew this wasn’t the question she had initially wanted to ask.

“I don’t have a mobile network — do you?” She paused for a moment and then nodded in the affirmative. She handed me her mobile — it was not a smartphone. I wondered how old the piece might be.

I tried calling Ayaan’s number through her mobile, but the voice on the other side said the number was unreachable. He had lost his old mobile back in Gurgaon and had come to Dzongu with a new sim and a cheap smartphone.

“If he has gone towards the market, then he is bound to have some network,” she said after noticing my frustration with Ayaan’s callous behaviour. He usually was not irresponsible, and fear suddenly engulfed me. I prayed for his safety and well-being.

I returned the mobile phone to her, still deep in my thoughts.

“Can you ask Shyam to check if Ayaan is in the market?” I continued expectantly, “I believe there is only one big one — MG Market, or the other one, Magaan Shopping Complex. He must be buying something for me in one of these places.”

“I can ask him, but how would he recognise Ayaan? You don’t have a mobile network, either. Otherwise, you could have WhatsApped his photo to Shyam,” Aunty explained.

I nodded. There was no mobile network, but what she said later in the sentence surprised me, so I continued: “Come on, Aunty. I don’t think Shyam’s memory is so bad that he would forget the 6-foot-tall gentleman who had given him Rs 500 the other day as a tip, just for getting him cigarettes from the shop nearby.” I laughed, trying my best not to sound condescending at all.

It was Aunty’s turn to act perplexed. Unexpectedly, she was the one who looked stupefied.

“I don’t think so, my dear; he hasn’t met Ayaan yet...”

I interrupted her before she could say anything else, “This is right after we checked in... remember? Shyam had carried our luggage to our cottage?”

“That is what I am trying to tell you, my dear. We have never met Ayaan. You keep mentioning him, but we haven’t seen him in person.” She continued, “You checked in alone.”

Illusion

Rati

Aunty looked serious, and it made me wonder whether I had misheard her.

“What do you mean I checked in alone, Aunty?”

She looked back, her eyes wide in astonishment.

“He was right there. He admired your artefact collection behind this reception table. He talked about the valleys and the streams. Are you telling me he was invisible to you? Is this some joke?” I asked, still in denial.

“Why would I joke? I do not see his name in the booking — you showed up as a single guest. When we received your request, only one guest was mentioned.” She was as insistent as I was.

I remembered that Ayaan had made me make the reservations, and I had blindly followed his instructions when he recommended that only my name be mentioned in the booking. But there would have been many instances where people had seen us together. More importantly, why would I imagine him with me when he wasn’t?

I started recalling the instances when he had spoken to Aunty or other staff here at Shine Resort. Even if he hadn’t spoken to anyone, he surely would have been seen by many. And I was sure that he had talked to Shyam. I remembered him asking for cigarettes. I didn’t remember who took the delivery when Shyam brought the pack of cigarettes, even though I recalled we gave him a tip.

“You should call Shyam; he will validate that Ayaan is here,” I said, sounding defensive now.

Aunty behaved as if she had already anticipated this question. “We spoke about this already. Mr Fernandez is travelling, so he has no clue, but I checked with a few staff members here. They said it felt like someone was staying with you, but they hadn’t seen anyone.”

“What? How did they get the ‘feeling’ that someone was staying with me?” I asked, thinking I had found that loose thread in this poorly woven gimmick.

“Because you kept talking about it, dear. Ayaan wants this in the room; get me an extra towel for Ayaan; Ayaan is not in the room for hours; Ayaan liked the dish last night... And many other statements like this. Everything you ordered — in-room meals, toiletries, towels, coffee was good enough for two people. Last night, we heard a lot of noise from your cottage, mostly music, so we thought, yes, you had company. But none of us have ever seen Ayaan,” she continued. “We assumed he was there. And I was going to ask you for his ID today so that we can maintain records. The cost for the cottage would not change,” she clarified, “but we need to maintain documentation. And there you are, telling us today that he is missing.”

“What the fuck!” I murmured.

“Excuse me, Ma’am?” She asked, suddenly being formal.

“CCTV, CCTV? Would you have that on the property? Check those!” I exclaimed.

Aunty made a guilty face. “Unfortunately, no. There is no point in having one, as we don’t have Wi-Fi to make it function. There has never been a reason to have one either.”

I thought of screaming, but I knew it would only further establish me as someone who ‘hallucinated’ her partner’s presence.

So, I just stormed out of the reception. I now knew what they were thinking and why they were looking at me curiously. I was a deranged soul in their eyes. First, a man called Ayaan, and then some petrifying stranger who attacked her in the morning. I was a bloody joke to them.

I reached the cottage and sat beside the fireplace. Vertigo was kicking in. I looked at the shoe rack; no shoes belonging to Ayaan were there. But then, he had not brought three pairs like me, so it was not surprising.

I went to our room on the top floor and looked around; Ayaan had not returned. I opened the cupboard to validate the clothing we brought; no clothes belonging to Ayaan were in the cupboard.

I searched further. The suitcase Ayaan had brought his clothes in was also missing. I felt as if somebody had swept the whole place clean, ensuring no traces of Ayaan remained. It was like he was gone—or, as they were saying, almost as if he never came—almost as if he never existed.

I ran downstairs to check. His note was still under the fruit basket on the breakfast counter. I went to the fireplace and sat down again to understand what was happening. Was I really under an illusion?

I noticed the tequila on the counter and remembered we had shared a shot glass for that one. What else did we have last night? I jogged my memory and faintly recalled we had something else apart from Tequila. I looked around and found it — there were two glasses under the sofa. One smelled like orange vodka, which was my drink. The second one was half-filled, and yes, it was whisky sour. Ayaan's favourite drink.

So, while everyone may have claimed otherwise, I knew my Ayaan was there. He might not be there at that moment, but he certainly accompanied me to this place.

I decided to go to the police station in the evening if Ayaan did not return by then.

I was sure I was not hallucinating.

Police Station Vipin

He kept shouting, asking me to save him. The kidnapper had a cleaver in his hand and warned me to back off; otherwise, he'd cut off the fingers of this teenager he'd kidnapped for a ransom. The kid's parents had done the right thing by involving the police; I thought as I pointed my gun at this kidnapper.

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I almost fell off the chair as I woke up from my untimely nap. I rubbed my palms together to let the blood flow to my fingertips. If someone had cut them right then, I wouldn't have felt a thing. I needed to move on from the last case I was assigned in Thekkady.

I saved the boy and his hand but shot (and killed) the kidnapper. His accomplice had run off. My superiors weren't happy, and in any case, my relocation was due. And from Thekkady, I was then posted in Dzongu. From Kerala to Sikkim. From appams to momo. From sleeping in mundus at night to wrapping myself in comforters. From working with my people to this vapid job in a police station obscured in the mountains. This was the pinnacle of punishment postings.

I was surprised how things could be so different even though the cities were in the same country. That is not a politically correct statement. We Indians embraced diversity – bullshit. I may have appreciated the sentiment if Dzongu could offer me some good mutton curry cooked in coconut milk.

I checked my watch. It was 6 p.m. The other officer on duty would take another hour to come. My shift was from 10 a.m. to 7 p.m. Overtime included. A Sub-Inspector took charge after my shift and finished early in the morning, while two Assistant Sub-Inspectors would usually be present with either of us, with coinciding shift timings. The station always had someone senior apart from a Head Constable.

I hoped no new case would come then. It was frustrating to extend your duty beyond regular working hours. The cases were always similar — a tourist found with dope, somebody supplying it, an illicit affair, or a few stall owners fighting amongst themselves about encroachments. I had never heard of violent crimes like murders, rapes, or kidnappings in the last three months I had been at Dzongu; I had two years and nine more months to go.

I looked around the room. Checkered tiles, as if police officers played chess in their free time, using human bodies as the pawns. I imagined how that would look. While I would be the king, I loved the queen's liberty of movement. She could move wherever she wanted, while the king could take only one step at a time. An ironic inversion of the privilege that society provided us men in real life. Humankind had decided, "Hey, at least in games like chess, a female can do whatever she wants. But remember, only when the king dies is the game lost." While the queen may have all the powers, her life was no more valuable than the other pawns in the game, barring the king. Just like in real life.

My thoughts were interrupted by some unnecessary chatter in the next room. Apart from cells in the basement to house the inmates, we also had a temporary lock-up on the ground floor. This one was for the folks who would spend less than 24 hours with us. The ones who had to spend less than 50 days were given the basement. The ones who were to spend more than 50 days in jail were sent to Gangtok.

The fear of leaving Dzongu and spending time at Gangtok also demotivated people from committing major crimes. The locals wanted to be born, live their lives, and be buried in the hills of Dzongu. When alive, they might venture out for a few days, but I'd rarely heard of people going any further than Gangtok, even for studies.

What a complacent lot! Were they not ambitious? Was this all that they wanted? Too hard to say, but a good point to ponder, especially if you have nothing better to do.

My forlorn thoughts did not always wander down that road. Now, for instance, they were occupied by the pile of documentation before me — files over files, adorned with a heavy paperweight on the top. The glass paperweight had a yacht inside it, which looked puny as it secured that huge pile, and I laughed at its plight. I hated the smell of paper; some were damp, some were dry, some were stained by the tears of the complainants, and some by the malice of the victims. No, they were not always the same. I

kept my legs on the shaky wooden table again, moving the pile of files to the side.

I looked towards the right and saw the genius typing on the keyboard. His table was hinged to the wall, making it look like an unfinished lab. The rusting steel chair and the small red pillow this nerd used to rest his buttocks on completed the tableau.

There was only one computer in the police station, something we, as the station heads, had entrusted to this recruit. He had done some computer certification but wanted to stay in Dzongu like every other local. He said this was the closest to a computer job that he could get. He used to design websites for clients across India, sitting here in this station whenever he had free time—which was almost always.

Well, we were not complaining. I had heard that as and when government audits would happen, the genius used to help us. He might have been young, but he was intelligent and resourceful — and that was all that was needed to thrive under any government roof. The age might add wisdom, but lately, all government enforcement needed agility, which was where people like him came in handy. People called him Jimmy.

The chatter outside had now turned into a commotion. I started getting fidgety, shaking my legs. The Ajanta clock with Gandhiji's photo on the top told me that half an hour stood between me and my whiskey. Antiquity Blue was my brand, but I wanted to go wild with Royal Challenge today.

The steel almirah vibrated as a heavily loaded truck traversed the highway beside the police station, and I clenched my teeth. The files on the top of the almirah were about to fall at any time, but my subordinates were too busy to sort them out.

I shouted at the top of my lungs, “Do I need to hire another person to sort out these files, you lazy, good-for-nothing fellows? You all should have been fired years ago!”

Two constables came rushing in, one running towards the pile of files, the other reaching towards me, his eyes trained down towards his feet. He was twenty years older than me, but as frightened as a puppy.

“Sir...” he blurted.

“What?” I kept my pitch high, determined not to give up until they got down to the task.

“There is a ‘ladies’ outside.”

“Not ‘ladies,’ you idiot. It’s ‘lady.’” I snapped.

“Sorry, sir, there is a lady outside. She has come to file a missing person’s report. Crying that her boyfriend is missing.” He managed to say this in one breath.

“How long ago was he seen?” I asked, irritated. If only she had come thirty minutes later. I was waiting for my crushed peanuts, a bag of chips, and the starters that the guest house cook would have made. Not to forget the shopkeeper of the ‘Spirits’ shop, whom I had asked to procure Royal Challenge from Gangtok.

“She says she woke up in the morning, and her boyfriend was gone. We asked her to come tomorrow morning, but she is adamant about seeing you.” After he spoke, he stepped back as if he feared I would throw the paperweight at him. I would never do so, but I was glad that people thought I could lose my shit.

I stood up from my seat, murmuring curses, and thinking of excuses to shoo the ‘ladies’ away.

As I stepped outside my room into the larger hall area where everyone sat, I saw myself in the mirror on the almirah. I tucked in my belly before I stepped out and noticed her sitting in a corner.

She was wearing a grey co-ord set. She had an expensive watch on her, and had large hoop earrings. She, however, wore casual sneakers, which meant she left for the station in a hurry. Her hair was tied back in a thick bun, and strands of hair fell over her glowing cheeks playfully. Her redolent body awoke the hopeless romantic in me, and I gave her an encouraging smile.

As she spoke, I got lost in her hazel eyes and couldn’t take my eyes off her lips, which were coated with a soft shade of dewy lipstick. A small mole on her nose had me transfixed for the remainder of the conversation.

Investigation

Rati

Someone came out, visibly irritated with my presence, as though he was one of those older teenagers constantly disturbed by the boisterous younger kids in the house. For a moment, I thought he would pounce on me in anger, but then he mellowed down to the point where he would not say anything. He kept looking at me as if he was at a loss for words.

He was not a local. With a receding hairline, thick moustache, and a once-muscular body now marred with a slight belly and love handles, Mr Vipin Nair, Inspector, stood before me. Unlike my Ayaan, he did not care about his physique much – this was quite evident.

When you travel, you instantly trust the non-locals more than the locals, as though, somehow, they would get your pain better. I got the same feeling from the Inspector, instantly feeling safe in his presence. The others in the police station were trying to evade my request: ‘Search for my boyfriend.’

“My staff briefed me about your request. I recommend you return in the morning if your husband has not returned,” he finally said with a stolid face. A truck passed by in the vicinity, the whole station shook again, and everyone grimaced.

“Boyfriend, not husband,” I corrected. Everyone grimaced again.

“The recommendation would not change,” he said, dismissing my correction. Typical.

“But you haven’t even heard me yet,” I confronted him.

“I don’t have to. I trust my staff and their competence.” He sounded like someone who did not believe his words but wanted the last one. My fear for my safety returned in full force.

“Well then, I have nowhere to go. Folks in the resort are telling me Ayaan did not come to Dzongu in the first place, and no one has seen him. I don’t have a network on my mobile phone in most places in Dzongu, except for this police station. I should probably sit here and call every damn place

on Earth until I find out where Ayaan is. Your police station is blessed with a room heater, mobile network range, and abundant snacks, as I see it, so this is the best place to conduct my investigation.” I asserted and sat on one of the benches, crossing my legs. My stoic expression perturbed everyone, and they clacked like headless chickens.

Mr Vipin kept looking at me for a while and then went inside his cabin. Still visible through the swinging half doors, he picked up his cap, walked past me, and went outside.

The staff kept looking at him as if he were a ship’s captain who had threatened to leave them in the middle of the sea in rough weather, and now the rest of the team would have to take over and face the danger.

I saw him sitting in his jeep, but just before the driver switched on the ignition, he jumped out, abusing his luck loudly, and looked me straight in the eyes as he entered the station again.

“This better be good,” he said. I smiled.

Vipin didn’t know what he was getting into.

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I explained what had happened, and the young chap near Vipin took copious notes. Once I was done, Vipin nodded at him and returned to the nearby wall table. Two ASIs stood near him, and Vipin tapped his pen on the wooden top. Dust glazed the hidden corners, and the room reeked of pungent air mixed with human sweat, old files, and the damp floor. A geek at the back started typing noisily on the keyboard. Vipin started playing with the paperweight, and I wasn’t sure if he was wasting time or figuring me out.

After a while, he stood up, asking the ASIs to accompany us to Shine Resort.

“Call me when you find something, Jimmy,” he spoke. Jimmy the geek nodded. Vipin did not wait to see his nod.

Vipin and the driver sat in the front seat. I sat in the middle. The other two took the back row with their dour faces, lugging along, hoping that Ayaan would have come back by the time we reached Shine Resort.

I hoped so, too.

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It was dark when we reached the resort, and everyone was ensconced in the safety of the thick cottage walls. The mountains are dangerous during the night. And while they blame it on animals, I think what creates mayhem among those lost travellers is neither human nor animal; it's a species yet to be discovered. The sinister ambience is the perfect setting for the baiting of innocent prey. The tintinnabulating wind chiming from afar, the tyres crackling over the broken gravel, and the chirping crickets all warned me of this truth.

Ms Fernandez greeted Vipin. She said she had heard of him and seen him at a public function a couple of weeks ago but hadn't met him one-on-one until now. Mr Fernandez had not returned from Gangtok yet.

She was warm to Vipin and served the famous Temi tea to his entourage. Her cottage opened to a large hall; on one side was the reception, and on the other was the waiting area, where these gentlemen waited, slowly sipping tea and wondering how long this investigation would drag on before they could return to the solace of their abodes.

After a few pleasantries, Vipin got to work. He looked carefully at Ms Fernandez. She understood his look, too.

She asked, "How can I help, sir?"

"Please give me details of all the guests who have stayed in the resort in the last week and those currently staying here," Vipin demanded, but not without courtesy.

She went behind the desk to give him the records. She pretended to be confident, but it was obvious that she was nervous.

I noticed Shyam lurking in the background, almost like a house lizard that is always around, but no one bothers or cares after a point. His gaze bored through the cracks of the door curtains and settled on Vipin, and his face revealed a twinge of something unidentifiable.

I sensed that the presence of the police unsettled him.

Versions

Vipin

The atmosphere at the resort was like that of a theatre desperately trying to get back into business. The cast of fading bad actors had their reasons for being ready to perform in a poor script. The director was missing, and everyone was doing their own thing. It was chaos. No one was thinking straight.

I first wanted to find out whether Ayaan existed. The second objective was to ascertain if he came here. The third was to determine if he was actually missing.

I informed my team about this game plan, and they concurred. They stopped tapping their feet, and they narrowed their lips as they intently listened to the tasks I assigned to each of them. Jimmy was back at the station and was tasked to find out whatever he could about Ayaan and the woman who started it all – Rati. The other two who came to the resort with me had to start interviewing people and collecting evidence.

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The network remained an issue. We got signals only intermittently, and I often had to send one of my men down the hill on which Shine Resort was located so that he could call the police station and come back with an update.

On one such trip downhill towards more habitation and possibly a mobile tower, Dipen, one of the ASIs, came back and validated the information Rati had proffered. He was a thin chap, eager to please in an ill-fitting uniform. The smiles were intermittent but never suited his face, the eeriness surrounding them was ironic.

“Yes, her name is Rati. She lives with a boy called Ayaan in a plush penthouse society in Sec 19, Gurgaon. Although they are unmarried, they visited a famous maternity hospital a few weeks back. The gynaecologist

they met is well-known for family planning. Ayaan works with a start-up that specialises in digital books. His role varies from being a literary agent scouting fresh talent to raising funds when the investors are around.” Dipen took a deep breath and continued. “Rati is an artist; she paints. She used to work with an art gallery but had quit recently.”

“That is good to know,” I acknowledged. Ayaan was not a figure of her imagination – he was real. I was relieved in a way. The enchantress wasn’t a cuckoo.

“There are two more interesting pieces of information Jimmy was able to find out, sir. First, Rati is the sole heiress of a property of over ten acres near Sonapat. It must be worth 40-odd crores. Also, she is rumoured to have been seeking mental health professionals throughout her life. She is a psycho!” Dipen exclaimed at the last phrase, going ahead with the taboo that had ensnared millions of others on the planet as well: Consulting a mental health professional meant that you are bonkers. I pitied these dimwits who wanted to change their parochial outlook but did nothing about it.

Dipen was also excited because of another insecurity: Men who are aware that they don’t even deserve a glance from a woman like Rati are quick to dismiss their indifference as the result of a probable emotional imbalance in the girl’s brain.

“Seems like an open-and-shut case to me.” Sami, our second ASI, said, pulling me out of my thoughts. “The asshole caught her in his love web, must have done some money transaction, and now has run away. I bet this is what it is.” Sami had a balding head and a short height, and he had wrinkles on his face. He looked like someone who had a peaceful run at his work and had hit the glass ceiling, awaiting his retirement.

I looked at Sami. He may have been right. Given the facts of the case so far, that looked like a possibility.

I was determined to unravel this conundrum. “Find out more about Ayaan and Rati’s travel history. They must have taken a cab from the airport – either Bagdogra or Pakyong. Find any CCTV footage of the airport where they were. Pass on their contact details and pictures to our friends in the airlines, airports, and cab companies,” I gave instructions as my team nodded.

However, myriad questions still cluttered my mind. Why would Ms Fernandez not agree to this Ayaan guy being present? Why would Rati say

he was present if he was not?

Since Dipen was busy coordinating with Jimmy, I decided to conduct interviews with Sami — the preliminary ones before we determine whether the subject is worth interrogating at the police station. I knew I had to start with the easy ones — the resort staff, the owners, and Rati.

Before I could start with the housekeeping staff, I noticed Rati was sitting at the reception, glancing through magazines and reading with rapt attention. She did not look like a psycho, as Dipen had judged earlier. She looked like a vulnerable woman who desperately needed a saviour, probably someone like me. She caught my stare and smiled back at me. I might have been imagining it, but her smile seemed different. Just knowing that she was noticing me was a real thrill; I felt electrified. I pulled myself together and walked towards the housekeeping room, aware that Rati's eyes were following me. She did justice to the name her parents had chosen for her. She was the goddess of passion, and she enamoured me.

Something about her engulfed me, and my soul surrendered itself to her smile.

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“No sir, we had not seen anyone with that madam,” said one of the housekeeping ladies. “We were told there was someone, as she had requested a pair of everything — bath towel, hand towel, room slippers, toiletries, etc.”

“When you guys used to clean their room, what else did you see? Clothes? Suitcases? Sneakers?” I asked.

“Well, the closets were locked, and they had kept their suitcases inside the closets, which is unusual. We have rarely seen guests doing that unless they think we will steal or if they want to hide something,” the staff continued. “Just once, sir, we saw a man's vest behind the bed as if someone had left it there by mistake. We cannot surely say if it belonged to the couple staying before or this one. We do deep cleaning only once a week, so we sometimes discover such remnants later. One day after Rati Ma'am arrived, a cleaning brush slipped from our hands and tumbled behind the bedrest. That's when we discovered the vest tucked away back there.”

“What did you do with it?” I asked.

“We left it beside the bed, sir. We thought it might belong to that guy Ma’am kept mentioning.”

“Understood. If you remember anything, please let us know. We are here for a few more hours,” I said as the scared housekeeping staff left the room. I closed my palm notebook, which I had kept reserved for my first exciting case at Dzongu. I scribbled some quick notes with my Jetter and summoned the in-room dining staff. Apparently, she, or they, never ate out at the small restaurant in Shine Resort.

The in-room dining staff had the same story to tell. They never saw the guy; only Rati ordered food – enough for two people every time.

Just like the housekeeping staff had found a vest, these guys mentioned that one time, two glasses had come back from Rati’s room after dinner. Both had different drinks: one with tomato and the other with orange, a Bloody Mary and a Whiskey Sour. Different people prefer different combinations, I guess.

I asked them about the glasses, which had been washed already. How could they have known that it would be taken as evidence?

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“She seems off,” Ms Fernandez continued, “Whether Ayaan is in Dzongu or not, I find her weird. As if she is lost and not from this world. She also panics about little things. Like the other day, she called the plumber at 2 a.m. Luckily, our electricians and plumber stayed in the servant rooms and were awake then.”

“And? Did they see anything?” I asked.

“You can talk to them,” she smirked. “I remember Mr Fernandez eavesdropping on their conversation earlier. They talked about the woman being in a robe and someone else being in the room but hiding, maybe because he was naked. They laughed about it, and my husband grinned while narrating the incident to me.”

“So, they did not see him either?” I asked, exasperated by then.

“No, sir,” she confirmed.

It was clear that the guy did not want to be seen. What if it was not Ayaan? What if it was some other guy — or a girl?

“Why is there no CCTV on this property?” I was angry at their laxity regarding safety. I could extend this anger to the entire city, but the locals

were not to blame. There were no crimes to be worried about in the first place.

“Only one or two places have CCTVs in Dzongu, sir. We are peace-loving people, and you would have understood that by now. The government has put it at important places like government properties or highways, but private properties are yet to embrace this technology, not to mention the investment.” Ms Fernandez got defensive.

“Yes, but you are deceiving the customers. You are saying it’s a resort — but you neither have a pool, a gym, or safety. None of the resort-like amenities are here. Even Wi-Fi is not there! Guess I should report this to Booking.com and ensure this place is advertised correctly for what it is: a lavish homestay with scattered cottages!” I declared.

“But we have 24*7 service and in-room dining, sir.” Ms Fernandez was not ready to give up.

I was about to, though. She was not giving me any valuable information. “Where is Mr Fernandez?”

“He went to Gangtok last night and was supposed to return this afternoon. He is not back yet; maybe he is still drinking with some friends. He will be back in a few hours, I guess.”

Perhaps this was not the first time her husband had been out longer than he had committed. She was chill about the exception, as it had now become the routine. Or perhaps she did not care.

He might have been more helpful with the case, though. Guys at the far end of the fifties, like Mr Fernandez, were more observant of voluptuous women like Rati and judged men making love to these women.

“We will cover the guests now, as the staff interviews are done. Also, where is your nephew, Shyam?” I asked.

“What about him? He just came this morning!” She was indignant.

“We need to interview everyone, Ma’am.” I was surprised by her reaction. I had noticed Shyam earlier, and the boy looked cagey.

I sighed and looked over the guest list. Two families had checked in the previous day, but their cottages were far from Rati’s. It wouldn’t have helped at all, but still, I had to question them.

There was also a lone traveller — Shikha. She had checked out a few hours ago. I scribbled in my palm notebook that I needed to speak to her later. A single guy and a few other families had checked in last weekend.

There were no additional guests throughout the week. Thin business at Shine Resort.

I looked around. The resort was on a hill, with trees and other vegetation around. During the day, I imagined one would be regaled with varying shades of green. It changed to black at night, with varying levels of melancholy and nothingness. Apart from the staff, no other human would be coming near that isolated retreat. It could also have been a good spot for haunted sightings. I was sure I'd hear many tales if I went around the corner. Was Ayaan a victim of some eerie cult practice? The case just got more interesting.

The families visiting the resort had no connections with Rati and her boyfriend. The husbands remembered her, of course, from that morning. The wives were not happy at the mention of her description. During the interviews, the wives ogled me, and I blushed. The attention directed at me felt more like vengeance against their husbands. I felt pity for these desperate souls. They were pretending to be happy in a claustrophobic relationship.

I met everyone except Shikha and reminded myself to call her after my mobile got network range. Who knows? Maybe she would have spotted Ayaan.

Rati was the only one remaining, and I started walking to her cottage. She had left the reception earlier, stating that she was exasperated and wanted to rest for a bit. I asked Sami to join me as I did not want to be alone in the room with her. The presence of another person would keep me away from distractions. Dipen could stay at the reception to alert us if Mr Fernandez showed up or if the man of the hour, Ayaan, returned.

We started on the trail toward the cottage. The unkempt pine trees looked like monster shadows in that dim moonlight, ready to gobble you. The path to the cottage was illuminated with side lights under the bushes, but the fog obscured them. The setting was perfect for someone to die of a heart attack, just from all the spookiness.

As we were walking down the stone pathway, Dipen ran from behind, shouting, "Sir!" His sudden arrival startled us.

"Where did you just drop in from?" Sami asked him, and he smiled sheepishly.

"Yes?" I asked.

“This case is not simple, sir. We traced the couple’s movements. Yes, she took a flight from Delhi to Bagdogra. But only she flew out. We could see them going together to the airport and then to the lounge. But he never boarded the flight. We have the video of her boarding the flight alone, and he was seen coming out of the Delhi airport an hour later,” Dipen said in an unabated breath.

“So, it is clear, right? That means he never came in?” Sami said.

“No sir, it does not stop at that. We saw him in another video right outside the airport. He stopped the cab and threw something out, halting for a few seconds. I had a suspicion and checked with the telephone company — that was the last place we could trace his mobile number.” He spoke.

So, three of us, on that night, replete with a bit of moonlight, foggy lamps, cold weather, and monster-like pine trees, were now trying to figure out the motive of someone who deliberately destroyed his sim card in Delhi right after his live-in girlfriend boarded a flight for their ‘together’ vacation in Sikkim.

“No kidding!” I desperately needed a smoke. I lit a cigarette, hoping that the nicotine would help me think clearly.

“Why would someone do that?” Sami asked.

“When they want to build a case of disappearance by running away,” I said. “Maybe Rati will be able to throw some light. I don’t want to sound presumptuous, but I don’t think she is lying.”

— —

We knocked on Rati’s door. She opened it — in a bathrobe.

“Oh, I am so sorry; I thought it was Ayaan, so I just jumped out. Can you give me a second? I will be right back.” she said, her hair dripping wet. Drops of water trickled towards her cleavage.

If only I could be one of those drops that reach under her robe.

She caught my gaze again and banged the door shut.

After a few minutes, she opened it, wearing a full-sleeved sweater with leggings that told me her legs were slender. I had never objectified women, and I wasn’t sure why I was being that way then.

Sami sensed the aberration in my behaviour. The ‘I am better than my boss’ attitude took over, and he said, “Ma’am, if you don’t mind, we would like to ask you some questions.”

She nodded. We sat on the two-seater sofa. She sat on the bed and kept running her fingers on the folded white blankets. My eyes couldn't stop following them. My mouth was open. My mind was fighting a losing battle as it told my body and soul to get their acts together. Sami looked at me with enlarged eyes as though asking me to stop behaving like a testosterone-hit, sex-deprived, 35-year-old virgin.

“Can you please tell us about your journey, starting from the time you guys planned this trip? We need minute-by-minute details, especially when you both leave home to board the flight to Bagdogra.” Sami asserted. He was a good guy. The perfect successor to me.

My legs were shaking from all the sexual tension. I did not have the guts to look at Rati. I took out my palm notebook while she kept staring at me.

Somehow, I got the impression that instead of worrying about her boyfriend, she was enjoying my suffering — My inability to hold her tight in my arms.

Sadist.

**Before
Dzongu**

Three years ago

Meeting Him

Rati

Meeting Ayaan three years ago was fate; whatever transpired later was our destiny.

Every human believes that they have had the most difficult life. Their challenges are unique, and no one else could have come out so well had someone else been in their place. If we poke their inflated ego, they will swish around like a balloon releasing air, hurtling across space for one last time before falling to the ground, spent and diminished. When you see another human shed tears while pouring their heart out to you, you reminisce about your own journey and sigh.

It took me some time to accept my life growing up. A seven-year-old girl was thrown into a boarding school, so she is somebody else's problem, and needs to figure out a way to live by herself.

Starting from tremors in the night to seizures to hallucinations, I had been on medical help ever since I could remember. The hostel wardens treated me with pity, my teachers treated me with empathy, and my school friends and batch mates treated me with caution.

I grew up being 'acquainted' with everyone. My only 'relationship' was with my parents, who avoided meeting me even on planned school vacations. As I grew older, I stopped going home for vacations altogether. Pocket money would come in any case, and in greater amounts each year — my parents figured out that as long as their troubled kid was spending all that money alone, and was far from their eyes, they were happy this way.

I started travelling alone at the age of 15. I discovered many places, mainly in the Indian subcontinent. Only a few places had 'adults only' policies, so I was able to manage without chaperones. During one of my trips to Sri Lanka, I discovered my love for art.

Art sucked me in and gave me a medium to express myself. I went on to complete my graduation from NID Bangalore, and later, I took up a job in an art gallery in Gurgaon that exhibited famous paintings of mini celebrities. I wanted to understand how an art gallery operates as well. This gave me a lot of free time during the day, and I used that to hone my sketching skills. Nights were depressing, and I lost myself to the world of books.

‘Significa’, the art gallery where I joined as the Display Expert and rose to be accepted in the Artist category, gave me a chance after three years to display three of my works.

The owner, who ran the place using his left brain alone, thought about commercialisation more than the executives of big conglomerates. It was all about revenue and margins.

Our calendars were blocked in advance based on a recurring routine. One big art show event in a year, one small event six months after the big art event, and three more forgetful display events in the year. We would plan for each event throughout the year and search for paintings, artists, and sponsors. Apart from this, every day from 10.30 a.m. to 1.30 p.m. and 4.00 p.m. to 6 p.m., we would charge a minimal entry fee to explore our expansive 5000 square feet display, which had frequent visitors. We also earned hefty commissions on sales as and when they happened.

The gallery was short-staffed most of the time, and I took that as a challenge to learn new things. There was always much to do to quench an artist’s thirst.

I was where I wanted to be — surrounded by paintings, a few interactions with like-minded people, and enough time to immerse in my passion. At the same time, I was earning money for the first time — my own hard-earned money.

Mentally, I had never been better. Physically, I was doing great.

And then I met Ayaan, and my body started craving the human touch.

I remember the day he walked into our gallery. All I can say is my oestrogen got the better of me.

— —

Amidst all the tension of ensuring my artwork was appreciated and picked up for sale that day, I taught the new receptionist-intern how to send

RSVPs for next month's gala event. He was also to confirm the attendee list for today. When a stranger walked in, we were looking intently at the computer at the reception desk.

"Hi, till what time is the gallery open?" The stranger asked.

My intern immediately stood up and recited the sentence he had memorised a few minutes ago. "Apologies, sir, we are closed today. However, if you are kind enough to drop your visiting card in this bowl, we will send out invites and registration links for our upcoming events."

The stranger looked at the intern and started laughing loudly. His boisterous laugh rang through the serene gallery like a jet flying through the clear blue sky. The stranger reminded me of an excited kid in the playground.

"Excuse me, this is an art gallery, not the laughter club," I said. Instead of shushing himself, though, he started laughing even harder. The only effect of my remark was that he kept his hand over his mouth and turned away.

He returned after regaining his composure and started talking to me.

"Hi, I am Ayaan, and we work out of this co-working space around three miles away. We run a digital start-up and have a big event planned tomorrow to launch our new segment on Fiction Writing, the thriller flash fiction category," said the stranger, his musk-scented perfume dissipating across the room along with his words. He shared his visiting card.

"Flash fiction what...?" I asked. He smiled as he got my attention.

"...Like, Very Short Stories. Here is where I need your help." He explained, "Some speakers and authors are flying in today. And I oversee their 'entertainment.' Most of them will be in by five or, max, by 6 p.m., and I cannot take them to a pub straightaway. We must also show them that we can offer them intellectual stimulation and ensure that we do not come across as frivolous."

I still could not make sense of why he was there at Significa.

"...so, I googled for creative places to be in Gurgaon within five miles and am here. I will bring them around 6 p.m. Can you guys make some quick arrangements for me, please?" His 'please' seemed a bit forced if you asked me.

I stood up, hoping to show the yob his place. His height was just a little over mine, and now, face-to-face, he seemed like the incorrigible joker

whose ambition was to reach the moon but didn't even know how to travel from Gurgaon to Noida.

"So cute!" I spoke. "So basically, we are expected to drop everything and help you, isn't it?"

"It's just a request!" he said, mellowing down.

"So sorry, but since we have an art display event this evening, we cannot accommodate your 'request.' Also, places like these are not for entertaining clients. You have pubs or clubs for that. These places are meant for people who appreciate art. So, if your clients are connoisseurs with great taste, they can be brought to the art display between 6 p.m. to 8 p.m. tonight. Tickets are available online, but I guess we are already sold out," I said, sitting back in my seat. My voice conveyed subdued aggression as he nodded timidly and left.

We typically had these events as invite-only, but since the gallery owner was promoting newbies like me amongst a few other not-so-very-well-known artists, we had also opened the display on tickets.

After he left, I went inside the gallery and looked at the corner where my paintings would be displayed. I checked the small spotlights below and above the paintings. I hoped the display lights would draw the attention of someone who would understand what I was trying to communicate through my paintings.

Ayaan's face suddenly flashed in my mind, and I restrained myself from stooping so low in my standards.

— —

Significa had its fan following. The entrance was grand, making one feel as if they were entering a palace. The white pillars were carved with nymphs diving into the water, and little waterfall-like structures abutted the door on each side. The water flowed into small channels on either side of the walkway, and koi fish swam elegantly in them. The door, made of African Sandalwood, definitely made a statement. It was one of those places where you must feel worthy to enter.

Beyond the reception and a few basic conference rooms, there was a large hall with a few partitions forming a maze. The novice artists were inside the maze while the wizards adorned the maze's outer walls. The maximum number of folks stood in front of the work of the master artisans,

and a few forayed inside the maze as well, trying to interpret the mind of a smaller artist.

My paintings were placed in a corner section towards the end of the maze. Three of them were assembled in a row, and the owner had been kind enough to give it a dedicated wall. During the last-minute check, he commented on my paintings and said I deserved every bit of that area on the wall. I knew that was a place most people might not visit, but I had to pretend I was full of gratitude. I mustered a ‘thank you’ with a smile, and he happily took it before moving on to the other arrangements.

The evening began, and we got busy attending to the guests. The team had much to coordinate because the sales happened through multiple channels. While inside, clinking champagne glasses, I heard an infectious laugh near one of the famous artists and saw two foreigners admiring a piece painted by the famous Negi. The painting depicted a kid picking up rags near a road, and on the other side of the road, an IB school bus picked up a kid from a well-to-do family.

The tourists admired the dichotomy and started discussing how India represents irony in the truest sense.

It was my turn to laugh boisterously at the clichéd discussion. That moment culminated in my champagne glass accidentally toppling over the person who came over to restrain me from offending the tourists.

I looked up at the person, opening my mouth to apologise, when I realised it was a well-groomed, smartly dressed, clean-shaven Ayaan.

“What... What are you even doing? These are my clients! And what is it with you spilling champagne all over me?” He yelled.

“Oops,” I said, rushing out of the gathering towards our office, where I thought I could escape the withering looks.

I sat there for two hours, occasionally stepping out when the gallery owner called me to handle some escalations. When everyone left around 8:30 p.m., we were asked to reconcile the data on the number of paintings sold and the details of people who had purchased them. We had to ship them in the next two days.

I noticed one of my paintings was among the list of paintings sold and rushed toward the part of the maze where my work was displayed. It was true, though I still could not believe a painting of mine had been sold.

I rushed back to the data entry details to see who had purchased my painting. It said the buyer’s name was Ayaan.

I was back home, feeling a little drunk on the champagne and full on the starters but exhilarated about my first sale. I tucked myself in after a hot shower, and as my night robe satin touched my skin, my thoughts went to Ayaan.

I wondered what would have made him buy my painting in the first place.

I had his number from the visiting card he had left me. I decided to call him then and there to apologise and to express my gratitude for being my first buyer.

I dialled his digits. My heart was racing, and I wasn't sure why.

He picked up after three rings.

"Hello, Rati," he said. His voice was soothing, as if he knew me before and expected my call. I wondered how he sourced my number.

"You have my number?" I asked.

"Truecaller," he replied. "Also, I had memorised your name when I saw you for the first time in the gallery today. It was on the ID card you were wearing."

I did not know what to say next. I was not used to dapper jocks telling me they had noticed my presence. And even if they did, not everyone dared to come and speak to me directly about it.

I fumbled for words, and he sensed the awkwardness. "If I had your number, I would have called you already. I wanted to apologise to you for being rude earlier in the day. I behaved like my problem was yours and that you and the team should drop everything and focus on saving my ass." After this, he took a deep breath, waiting for me to respond.

I smiled and could imagine him smiling on the other side, too.

"Oh, okay!" is all I said before facepalming myself.

"So, what were you calling for?" He wanted to have a longer conversation. Maybe he was the talkative type.

I gathered my thoughts. "It's funny, actually. I, too, wanted to apologise to you. I shouldn't have offended your clients and ruined what seemed like a newly purchased suit."

"So, you noticed what I was wearing?" He was smirking at the other end.

"Is that what you take out of my apology?" I asked.

“Well, that, and that you are a kind person. Loved our tryst in the afternoon.” Smarty pants. What an outrageous flirt! I ignored his comment and waited for him to go on.

“Hey, did I mention that my clients bought that Negi painting?” He exclaimed.

“Oh, is it? Yes, we had good sales this evening. Good for the gallery.” I added.

“I contributed a bit to that, too.” God, he was smug.

“Yes, I noticed. Thank you.” I decided to reciprocate with gratitude.

“I honestly don’t understand art that much. But this painting intrigued me, and I bought it on the spur of the moment,” he explained.

I realised he had no clue about the artist of that painting. “What drew you towards it?” I inquired.

“I am sure you are aware of all the ones on display. This one was at the corner maze, and I stumbled upon it as only a few people were in that section. I felt drawn towards that girl in the painting.” He continued, “No artist’s details were shared with anyone.”

“What about that painting --- the girl in the golden hour? She was staring at the sun!” I tried to make the conversation more frivolous to make my curiosity less obvious.

“I don’t know.” He then tried to explain himself, though, “Somehow, I felt that painting signified hope. She was looking at the sun meeting the horizon, the reflection of which left a long streak on that calm water.”

“The painting could also display loneliness. Maybe she was planning to go into the sea and end her life,” I said as if the girl was me. I became overwhelmed, hoping he did not sense my emotions.

“A lonely girl would look down. This girl seemed to be looking up, ready to embrace what the sun would bring her tomorrow. Her choice of attire was casual, and it seemed she was relaxed or on vacation. That can happen to a person who has achieved something in life. Hence, I said it felt like hope to me. I loved that painting,” he responded with warmth and feeling.

I was taken aback. He appreciated and loved my work and immaculately described what was going on in my mind when I painted myself in that painting. I *was* looking forward to what life had to offer me. I was surprised by his interpretation, even though he had mentioned he did not like art very much.

“I am impressed!” I couldn’t help complimenting him.

“Thank you, mademoiselle. Can you let me know who this artist was? She or he, whoever it is, has converted this novice into an art enthusiast!”

“The works you saw, all three, were painted by me,” I replied.

Growing up Ayaan

An innocent fawn grazed the lush green grass as I watched from the dense forest of my ambitions, licking my claws, and anticipating fresh blood. My ruffs juddered, and my eyes gleamed at the thought of my new mission to savour the soft flesh of prey, still ignorant of the hunter's presence.

I craved more. A 'little too easy' could be for the desert, but never for the main course. I was exasperated by making love to ever-ready cougars who had become my constant source of income and lavish gifts. Girls my age were sceptical and cautious, and they could read through my feigned affection for them. I would express my undying love on the fourth date and then get them into a financial scam — some got in, some wanted out. Everyone feared that Ayaan would let the world know they were honey-trapped by a 25-year-old suave charmer who rocked their world in bed while extracting money from them on an ongoing basis.

I contemplated becoming an escort once, but there is not as much fun there when compared to the thrill of scamming someone. Being a sex robot in bed is just too mechanical for me.

I was, however, keen to broaden my 'sexacapades,' and wanted a woman with a deeper pocket and a broken family record, along with a substantial inheritance that would let me pursue my dreams without inhibitions.

In the wild jungle of opportunities, all I had to do then was to wait. Wait for a damsel to cross paths with me, get lost in my extensively designed maze, fumble in my chaos, and be the elixir of my penance.

— —

Why was I like this? A question I asked myself every day till denial rushed out and acceptance kicked in. I pondered the infinite possibilities of who I

could have been or become, but the answer was always the same — this was who I was. A misogynist who loved money and sex.

My parents had a great marriage. They lost their lives in an accident a few years back, a truck rummaging their *Chetak*. I loved the family time, the New Year with the TV shows and the blankets, the celebrations and the high spirits, the relatives and the chutzpah, even though we were penniless.

If the upper-lower class or the lower-middle class was a term, we were the epitome of irony. The TV shows we watched were courtesy of our neighbour's cable intertwined with our antenna, the celebrations were large courtesy of my mother's parents who visited, and the chutzpah in front of relatives was a result of the need for validation that it was all worth it.

The government job funded my government education and also clipped our wings. Our vacations were at public parks on a battered mat. I had a bicycle that I rode from age nine to nineteen—the cacophony of monotony and the bondage of paucity.

I wondered if my hatred towards girls would have been lesser had I managed to date one over the years while I was growing up. In the higher secondary school, boys flashed their bikes, and girls wore their skirts higher to be the pillion. Their laughs were fake when the imposters circled outside the school gate, and my unrequited love for the numerous crushes maintained the status quo.

I detested the banality of my life's mediocrity. I hated the conversations my parents had about money for an expense that would happen six months down the line. I abhorred the rejection of countless girls waiting to escape from their reality into the arms of a pretentious rich brat.

I worked on myself—on my looks, on my physique, on what the world runs after success. I studied hard to safeguard my day job, but I knew I needed to work during the night, too, to make money through a side hustle.

While I ended up with a chiselled body and impeccable taste in clothing, doing very well in the start-up world professionally, I knew I deserved more. And I chose the two apparent choices the world runs after.

Money, and sex.

The Moonlight Tryst

Ayaan

Bumping into Rati in an art gallery was a happy coincidence.

I saw Rati as that naïve fawn since I first laid my eyes on her. I initially looked at her only as a pawn in my erotic fantasies, a couple of moves on the chessboard called desire. But her troubled past and wealthy background motivated me to pursue my favourite avocation.

I learned later that she was a jackpot. If that was not enough, her looks made her irresistible.

The hunter leapt on its prey one night beneath the moon, the silence of the shadows creating an aura of romanticism, which my fawn never imagined experiencing in this life.

— —

It took me a while to gain Rati's trust. She was reserved, had no friends, and limited her world to her team from Significa. The artist in her came to life once in a while, and for days, she would be lost in her own world, confining herself to the world of colours and canvas and the bland walls of her room. I understood the reason she was still single. No guy could handle such erratic behaviour.

The nightmares where she would wake up on her bed, drenched in sweat and shivering, got me concerned. I wondered if she would end up in an asylum before she could come of use to me. My cuddles helped her, and my patience towards all her fallacies lured her towards falling for me, deep into the abyss of betrayal.

Only if all women in the world were as gullible and needy, I pitied her as I slowly inched towards my plan to succeed.

Numerous dates, late-night chats, and passionate sessions in bed led to that fateful night a couple of months after our first meeting.

Unlike all the other concealed, blushed, highlighted, contoured, and eyelined girls, she came raw-faced that night to our date. She probably put on kajal and lip gloss and wore a beige jumpsuit. Her face glowed like the moon peeking through the dark clouds. Her hair was in a bun, with a few strands curling against her beautiful cheeks.

She cleared her throat as she sat in the car, expecting us to go to that fancy restaurant we had booked for our date night a few weeks before. I smiled as I pressed the accelerator, taking my eyes off her.

The dinner went in a haze, and her cleavage was to blame. The mole on her nose added to her beauty and my distraction. I found myself waiting for the right moment to delve into her trusting soul.

I had arranged for a setting under the moon, candlelight lighting the face of my fawn as the wind played with the strands of hair that had escaped her bun.

She looked into my eyes, and I understood that her vulnerability had peaked at that moment, ready to satiate all my thirst. Her look told me she wanted to feel wanted, and perhaps I wanted to feel wanted, too, but emotions couldn't win me that game. The world was pragmatic, and I was ambitious, and Rati was just another stop in this journey.

"I love you, Rati," I blurted just as she finished dinner and took the first bite of her cheesecake. She looked at me blankly, returning to the cheesecake after a brief awkward pause.

"I said something..." I confirmed, just in case.

"I heard," was her reply.

The rest of the time – savouring the desert and then the smooth ride home – we were silent. The thoughts in my mind were in their own *mélange* of insecurities, and I was sure after an hour that she had somehow sensed my intentions with her.

We opened the door of her dark house; the only light coming in was from the fateful moon through the windows, adorning the walls. The keys still jingled in my hand, and I felt her near me. I asked her to switch on the light, but she pushed her lips into mine instead, biting my tongue.

After a few minutes, as I set her lips away from mine, she brought her mouth closer to my ears and whispered, "I love you, too."

Oh, Rati! If only your pupils did not dilate at my sight, if only I could feel the same way you did. You are adorable, and I would not have done what I was about to.

But as they say — the heart wants what it wants.

Moving In Rati

We had been in the high summer of love for almost a year. Dates, movies, staycations, and numerous other impromptu magical rendezvous have happened. On multiple occasions, he has expressed in so many words that he wants to move ahead in the relationship. He has been patient, and I knew this bonhomie would not have lasted long if I did not stop being a recluse.

My restraint from giving in entirely to the relationship happened one night when he invited me to the most happening pub in the city. I stepped into the blue lights and the thumping beats of the pub. I was immediately surrounded by the raised hands and incessant gyrations of people trying to simultaneously make sense of their lives and forget all that might have hurt them over the week. The air reeked of an overpriced medley of drinks, even as the smell of freshly made food tried to carve its own territory near the table. My anxious eyes searched for Ayaan; I saw him sipping a drink in the corner of the bar and conversing deeply with the bartender.

I smiled at my precious, my knight in shining armour, standing apart from the crowd. He was still in his office attire, his tie loose and his blazer on the side, his sleeves rolled up. Later in the night, we would become one again on the dance floor, as he would look into my eyes, his palms above my hips, pressing his body close to mine.

As my steps took me towards him, I wondered why we had not started living together yet. He was perfect, almost too good to be true. We had arguments, of course, but he always apologised first. I tried my best to push him away, but he would reassure me every time that there was no stepping back for him. It was as if he knew what he wanted and was waiting for me to slowly realise the same and have our own happily ever after.

I always believed that anything that happens in life, even the luckiest coincidences, should be evaluated sceptically, whether it's a coupon in the lucky draw, appreciation by a connoisseur in the art gallery, or finding love after 25 years of existence.

I came from an unstable family, which, needless to say, impacted my perspective on life. I never had a stable relationship that lasted beyond a month. It would always be the same: the guy would want a commitment or talk about the future, but I was never ready.

Ayaan understood this right from the beginning of our relationship; hence, our association was going strong. His equanimity and patience surprised me, and my admission to being in love with him was quite a revelation, even for me. I never thought I was capable of being loved after being treated like a burden by my parents.

My nightmares had become infrequent, and the line between reality and illusion seemed more evident. In the last counselling session, my therapist told me how Ayaan had miraculously and positively influenced me.

“Are you okay?” Ayaan tapped me on my shoulder as ‘Insane’ played in the background.

“Yes, I am fine. I have never been better,” I replied with a smile, and we both knew what that meant.

My tongue tasted lemon and salt on his lips, and my nostrils filled with the smell of alcohol mixed with his Burberry perfume. His palms pressed my bottom closer to his crotch, and I knew we were due for a wild session that night.

As we rode in the silence of our Uber that night, our palms clasped together, he asked me if he could sleep at my place through the night and leave after breakfast the following day.

“Why would you want to leave?” I asked him.

— —

I hid in the corner, aware that the monster was after me. I could spot his shadow searching for me, and I tried to escape by hiding my human self in the shadows of other objects. I tried not to breathe lest he sensed my presence.

Someone screamed in the background, and the shadow stopped for a moment. I tried to see its face, and my eyes tried to look up from the corner of the bed.

I noticed my hands. They seemed like that of a toddler, and I remember being surprised. As I tried to make sense of my transformation, I felt the

earth shake, and the shadow hurried towards me. As the hands came to grab my soul, I tried to scream, but no sound came out.

— —

I woke up to a hassled Ayaan sitting beside me. He looked worried, and I found him patting me slowly, saying, “It’s okay, shhh... it was just a bad dream.”

I returned to reality, shaken up from the recurrent nightmare that had troubled me since childhood.

I felt relieved in Ayaan’s embrace, laying my head on his bare chest. He kept patting my shoulders until my heartbeat calmed down.

I looked into his eyes, and he asked me if something was on my mind.

It had been two years since we had started living together, and I had never been happier. The last time I had woken up from this nightmare was six months back, which meant that I was feeling secure and my condition was improving.

I wanted to take the next step, and I knew this guy was the perfect one to take it with.

“I want to have a baby,” I said, looking into his eyes. “... I am not sure about getting married, though.” He looked surprised, and even though we had talked about having kids, having one without getting married took him off guard.

After a while, he smiled, and I knew what that meant.

The Fling and The Restive Baggage

Ayaan

My charm had cast an intense spell on Rati. She considered me her anchor, albeit the process of enjoying the results of this jackpot seemed distant and excruciating.

I restrained my unfulfilled lust for a long time, but as soon the sexual passion between her and me subsided after a couple of months of dating, I became active on Tinder and Bumble again. With these apps' growing popularity and the increased levels of verification and transparency, it became difficult for me to be discreet. Still, I managed to wiggle my way through. Her trust was so blind after a couple of months that even when I had to go for a quickie with a stranger, I would mention that I was stuck in a client meeting, and she would not ask anything further, apart from whether she should keep my dinner aside for me.

I did not even feel guilty about what I was doing. Rati, for me, was a way to achieve something higher—and I did not love her. I liked her enough to associate with her for the next few years of our lives until she somehow included me in her will or put me down as a nominee on her life insurance.

She had been naive enough to tell me she had many properties to her name and businesses where her parents had made her the sole proprietor, to be capitalised later in life when she got married or decided to have kids. Rati and I were planning for neither in the initial months of our togetherness, so I had carefully crafted a plan to make her believe I would never leave her. I would stay with her, even if she didn't want to get married. If she wanted to get pregnant first and continue to be my live-in partner, I would agree to that, too. It did not matter to me. I was going to wait for that perfect opportunity to claim my prize. Who would otherwise like to stay with a cuckoo like her forever? She was a troubled case, and I could not wait to wash my hands off her after securing my future and a phenomenal account balance.

One of the girls I met through Bumble was Shikha. It started with a quickie, no strings attached, but then when we met for the 11th time in two months and still had passionate orgasms with each other, we realised that this was not any other we-got-lucky-on-Bumble coincidence. We were growing close, and the chemistry between us was undeniably hot.

On one of the nights, I landed back in Delhi from Mumbai—my start-up role now required me to travel more frequently than ever before. Shikha picked me up from the airport; she said that her lips were craving to taste me. We got into the car, and she gave me the steering wheel, not allowing me to restrain what her mouth did next.

She bent down, tying her hair in a ponytail. She unzipped my jeans, making me wonder what had got into her. Impromptu manoeuvres excited me further as my wood throbbed in her hands. She licked the whole of it, from top to bottom and then bottom to top.

The light from the moon and streetlamps formed a yellowish glow inside the car, and her hair looked like a halo as my eyes marvelled at the adventure she had just begun. I pressed the accelerator, and the metro pillars raced past faster, causing the yellow light inside the car to flicker every fraction of a second. I lowered the window slightly, and the wind played with my hair.

There was no traffic on the road, and the to-and-fro motion of her head between my legs, with our sounds of pleasure, got etched in my memory. I steered right and left on our way through the national highway on Gurugram, inching closer to my home as Shikha kept tasting me. I climaxed twice in twenty-seven minutes.

Afterwards, she washed her face with water and then looked at me with content in her eyes.

“Can we stay together tonight?” Shikha asked.

“I am sorry, people are waiting for me at home,” I said.

“Oh...” she replied.

“Are you disappointed that I have people waiting for me?” I asked, following her sigh.

“We never discussed it... But things have been going so well between us, and a part of me wants more. And when you said people, I understood it’s not your parents or roommates... Probably your girlfriend, or your...

wife and kids?” There were more questions in her eyes, and she was anticipating an answer.

I was dating someone I met on Bumble. She wanted to be serious, and I immediately questioned where I would see my association with her going. Would I want to take this further? Or does this end here? Now was the time to decide.

It was too early to onboard her on my life-saver plan with Rati. However, I realised she could be the perfect accomplice, gullible as she was. And something about her made me want to continue our fling or at least try to start a relationship with this bundle of mystery, surprise, and adventure. A stray dog suddenly barked at our vehicle, taking me out of my thoughts.

“You with me?” Shikha’s eyes were now insisting on an answer.

“Do I look so old that you thought I have kids?” I asked, trying to change the subject.

“Well, given your libido, I wouldn’t be surprised if you had sex with a debutante during your teenage years,” She answered and bent her lips, her eyes asking me not to act smart and come to the point.

I laughed for a second but started speaking as I saw her vexed. “It is not easy; it’s a little complicated. I have lived with a girl for the last 24 months, and she has severe psychological issues. I am too young to handle her issues — especially when she gets violent towards me. We have been consulting a psychiatrist, and given her childhood traumas, I have been advised by her parents and therapist to hold on to her for a few more months. They fear she will commit suicide, and I don’t want blood on my hands.” I lied with utmost sincerity, hoping she missed my glibness.

She rolled her eyes, a little with compassion, a little in sarcasm, and a lot out of disappointment. “I thought you were way smarter than that,” she said.

“What do you mean?” I asked, putting on an innocent face.

“Did you not see any signs before? I mean, here you are on Bumble being discreet, but then, there you are, as you are saying, caught in the quagmire of a complex relationship,” she wondered out loud.

“It is not that I wanted to start a relationship with a cuckoo. Things happen, and it’s difficult to predict sometimes. I did not know what I was getting into. There were flashes, but I thought maybe that was ephemeral. There were no red signals initially. And when I was finally able to identify

any, it was too late. Also, I cannot leave someone midway, someone I loved so much at one time,” I spoke.

“Either you are stupid or a very nice person,” she said.

I had chosen the right words. My plan was working.

“Hopeless romantic, as some may put it.” I laughed, a little relieved, to be honest. I opened the car’s door to step down, but she pulled me back and bit my lip; I tasted blood. I wiped my face and kept looking at her in sheer disbelief. She was completely under my spell.

“Douchebag!” She said as I stepped down from the car to walk the last few meters to her apartment complex. My heart was still racing, and I kept thinking of what may happen next between Shikha and me.

My mind was still afresh from our adventure in the car, and I felt a tickling on my dick’s tip again. As I opened the penthouse door, I saw Rati on the lounge sofa, jazz music in the background, with a glass of red wine in her hand and a satin maxie adoring her curves. She dimmed the lights as she walked towards me, slowly, the walk of a cat, and whispered in my ear — “I have been starving for you.”

As she undressed me and I slid her gown down her slender calves, I smiled. I was living my best life.

Flashes

Rati

I was unsure why I felt extremely drowsy, like I had woken from a deep slumber. I felt drugged, unaware of anyone else's presence in the room. I heard water from the shower tip-tapping against the floor, and as it stopped, I tried to comprehend whether someone had stepped out of the bathroom or if I had imagined things again.

I looked around, trying to make sense of the surroundings. I did not particularly remember living there, but it seemed like a familiar room where I may have lived once. The minimalist furniture, the mauve walls, and the lamps on the bedside table felt like things I owned.

The water dripped in the bathroom, on the floor, and under the sink. I could hear a roach on the basin and a rodent in the pipes. I covered my ears, blocking them with my wrists. As I removed my wrists, I felt creepy in the heavy silence. I had the hotel room's card in my hand and wondered what that meant. It had a name written on it, but my fingers trembled, making reading the proper nouns difficult.

Someone did step out, almost rushing in. The person was in a towel, still dripping water from the shower. I did not remember the face, but the eyes were red with blood, and his fingers went up to his lips, asking me to shush. I understood. I was not to tell anyone about the card. I was supposed to forget it. I nodded in terror, trying to figure out what this was about.

The semi-naked man's hand raised, almost to hit me, and my eyes opened, drenched in sweat again, struggling to breathe.

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The needles of the large wall clock at Ms Taneja's clinic moved ahead. The tick-tock filled the otherwise still room, creating an ambience that this was part of a parallel world. I wondered if the room was soundproofed so that the ones who unbottle their emotions in this room were assured that their

secrets were safe within the four walls. Perhaps the goldfish in the bowl wanted to break the silence, but a stare at me was the only thing it could manage.

Ms Taneja, my therapist, asked me to recall if I have had any real-life experiences similar to my nightmares. I shrugged. If I couldn't live them in my dreams, these incidents, even if they happened, would have been erased from my memories.

"What do these dreams mean?" I asked, curious to unravel what went on inside my chaotic mind.

"More often than not, they are flashes of memories from some trauma you may have experienced. Something that may have been wiped out of your episodic memory but is still locked within those grey cells." Ms Taneja looked intently into my eyes.

She continued, "You mentioned from day one that your parents have been warm but detached, so it is possible that your subconscious is insecure and hence draws negative energy and then builds upon it to manifest it in your nightmares. For example, your recurring dream of a person running behind you in the forest, or even the one where you are hiding in a corner trying to escape an abusive presence in your life, must be remnants of a movie or a story shared by your co-worker or an acquaintance, but it deeply affected you. It affected you so much that you lived it in a nightmare, but you don't recall it in real life since it never actually happened to you."

Possible. Even though I was an introvert, I drew my energy from external sources. I nodded.

Ms Taneja folded her legs on top of each other. Unlike any other psychiatrist, she dressed up very formally, but her presence always calmed me. I tried multiple counsellors for therapy. Ms Taneja was the only one I trusted from day one, which was a pleasant surprise.

I leaned further as I crisscrossed my legs on her leather lounge, and she smiled. She knew I had more questions to ask.

"But what about this dream of me finding a hotel card? The semi-naked man in my room?" I asked.

She acknowledged this was new and very different from my other nightmares, one which seemed more violent. Also, this one had a context – I had found a hotel card, which led my abuser to rush towards me.

"Do you remember if you ever caught your father, any relative or friend, or a boyfriend cheating on you?" She asked, the Parker pen in her

hands scratching the notepad as she made notes.

“I would remember it, of course. It has never happened,” I concurred.

“Hmmm... In that case, are you insecure about Ayaan leaving you or cheating on you? You are an intuitive person, Rati, so I am assuming that you suspect something or are worried about something with Ayaan in this case.” She asked, her eyes enlarged now.

“He has been busy lately, but when he is with me, he is with me. I wonder how I managed to land the man of my dreams, someone who has stayed with me despite my being broken.” I tried to dissipate my self-doubt with a nervous laugh.

“Because he loves you,” she reassured me.

“We, even though a part of the society, are mavericks. A live-in couple planning for kids is not common, and sometimes I wonder if Ayaan will wake up one day and realise he deserves a saner and more sorted person than this broken mantelpiece and wants to marry a conventional girl, and hence will leave me. He has always concurred with everything I asked, and while I am with him, I pinch myself occasionally to check if I am living in a dream.”

“Do you think him being busy and you guys not being able to get pregnant has somehow drawn up this feeling of insecurity that he may be cheating on you? Or do you have actual pieces of evidence to support your claims?” She asked, presenting me with varied perspectives, as always.

“No evidence, just insecurity because this is the best phase of my life. Sometimes I wonder if I am about to pull out the worst block from this game of Jenga, and my whole world will come crashing down,” I confessed.

“Do you think you deserve this life you are living today?”

“Yes, I deserve every bit of it, after all the detachment I have lived with. I finally have people around me who care and love me for who I am,” I asserted.

“Great, then believe it, and live it. You need to remind yourself of this simple thought occasionally.” She smiled.

She stood up to shake hands, and I hugged her awkwardly. She was taken aback, but she went with the flow. Her warm embrace made me realise why I liked her so much. She wore the same perfume as my mother.

However, unlike my mother, she gave me her full attention, even if it was only for an hour. She was genuinely interested in my well-being, even

though she charged me for it.

As I was leaving the room, Ms Taneja called out to me. “If you guys are having trouble getting pregnant, you can consult this gynaecologist friend of mine. She has helped countless clients over the last two decades by giving them effective solutions. She performs miracles, and maybe she can guide you to live that ‘happily-ever-after’?”

I nodded. As I took the card, I made plans to visit the doctor along with Ayaan.

The Plans And The Place

Ayaan

The gynaecologist advised us to go on a couple's trip to a remote place with limited technological interventions. I agreed with whatever was being proposed. After all, I was so close to my goals that I would have agreed to any shit to make money out of this lunatic.

After much coercion, she agreed to take term insurance. I was sure of the nominee she would put in; I was all set to make some money from her impending death.

I also brought up the topic of will, but she said it was too soon to discuss it.

"Maybe once we have kids, we could draft one," she said. "At least let's start working on it," I suggested. "If something happens to me or you during our pregnancy or childbirth, we should not be bringing the kid of a single parent into this world devoid of any money just because its parents did not carve out a will." She had reluctantly agreed to see a lawyer, and the work on the will had started.

I wasn't getting impatient; there was no timeline I was chasing. However, Shikha's presence in my life and the thought of starting a real relationship with her were killing me inside. I needed to get rid of Rati, and soon, just as soon as she made me filthy rich.

I was planning to trick her into signing the will in Dzongu. I was planning to get rid of her after that. The fall from a gorge, the pine needles in her body, the stones squishing her complex thoughts, the blood that would get splattered. All of it made me smile, and the thought of lying down on a bed full of money afterwards gave me a hard-on.

Meanwhile, Shikha and I were getting closer day by day. We were falling in love, moment by moment. Both of us were desperate to be together; the only way it could happen was if my plan was successful.

The execution would be simple. I would let Rati go to Dzongu ahead of me. I had studied the landscape of Dzongu, and I would have to find a way to push her into a ravine. I would never be seen with her in public. I found a glorified homestay called Shine Resort that was categorised as a resort and had no CCTV cameras on its premises. The whole of Dzongu had only a few CCTV cameras, perfect for my plan.

If someone spotted me, I decided to use Shikha as a pawn. I would go over there with her to make her feel I would be spending time with her, but instead, she would be my alibi for whatever may happen next if it came to that.

Both Shikha and Rati trusted me to make the bookings. I made the bookings the way I wanted. I would pretend to fly out with Rati but make an excuse at the last moment to make Rati go ahead of me at the airport. I would then go to Dzongu along with Shikha. However, they both would check in at the Shine Resort alone. I would tell both of them that I would join them eventually.

I had planned my three days at Shine Resort by the minute. Time was of the essence here, and a careful execution of my plan would determine my future.

I tricked the lawyer into making a final will for Rati. The naive human did not know what I had in store for her. All I had to do was to get Rati's signature on it.

It was as if God was on my side, helping me fulfil my wildest dreams. Finally, my hard work would pay off.

I couldn't wait to pack my bags and go to Dzongu.

Dzongu Again

Maze

Vipin

Rati took us through a week-by-week version of her first few encounters with Ayaan. She genuinely loved him, and I instantly felt pity for her. She seemed vulnerable, even though my libido kept increasing even in this situation for her. She seemed the perfect damsel to stoke my man ego.

She corroborated Ayaan missing the flight. She, however, also told us that he joined her back in Gangtok after she waited for him at a hotel near the airport. She and Ayaan had checked in together, she said.

Her belief was so firm that I did not feel like doubting her. Sami had a look of disapproval in his eyes, Rati had that of hope, and I that of enchantment.

“Do you have some water?” I asked her.

She stood up and suddenly came close to me. I could smell her redolent skin, and her dress was too revealing. Every pore of my body tickled as she bent to pick up a Bisleri beside me. She could have asked me to pick it up but chose to seduce me instead. Or was she just being nice, and I was thinking from my manhood?

“Here, hope this satiates your thirst,” she said; her fingers lingered a little longer as she handed me the Bisleri.

My eyes locked with hers as Sami cleared his throat loudly to take me out of her spell.

“Do you guys have any enemies? Anybody who would deliberately try to harm you or your husband?” Sami asked.

“He is not my husband – I told you earlier. And no, we do not have any enemies.” She answered him nonchalantly while staring at me, almost making me feel objectified. I was unsure if she did all this deliberately or had no sense of personal boundaries.

“Sir, we should better get started and examine the cottage.” Sami looked at me, and I agreed.

“Let’s look around once and call Dipen as well. Let us thoroughly search this cottage to prove once and for all whether he was here or not. Also, let us ask Jimmy to search for other videos at Gangtok airport to spot Ayaan. She says she met him near the airport, so in all probability, he came here on a later flight,” I instructed Sami, aware that Rati’s gaze was still on me.

We left the ground floor room, albeit slowly.

“Let me know if you need anything. Absolutely anything,” Rati said as she smiled, handing me a paper napkin with her number.

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“Sir, that woman is a weirdo. She is hiding something. This case is fishy, and I sense everyone is hiding a secret,” Sami continued, his eyes judging me. “Also, sir, don’t fall into her trap. Isn’t it strange that a woman missing her boyfriend is making eyes at a stranger policeman?”

“You are just jealous,” I said as I instinctively pushed out my chest a little. My wood refused to turn soft as her smell lingered around me, and I adjusted my inseams.

Sami looked at me in disbelief and opened multiple cabinets in the upper room as Rati waited downstairs. Most of the clothes were those of a woman planning to stay at a hill station, but my eyes rested on her satin lingerie. I took one of them in my hand as I smelled it, hiding my face in the cupboard, imagining Rati close to me.

By then, Dipen had also entered the cottage. “Sir, I found something,” Dipen shouted from downstairs. I asked Sami to continue searching the upper floor and the bathroom while I rushed down to check what Dipen had found.

There was this note from Ayaan, saying he would be back soon. It was not impressive, but it was at least something. We could send this to our contacts in NCR, and they could validate it with Ayaan’s handwriting. But how would that help? What if Rati carried this over from NCR itself? This was not a clue worth chasing.

Dipen read my thoughts.

“The tissue has a stamp of the resort, sir.” I smiled and patted Dipen’s back. I loved my time in Dzongu that day. My staff surprised me with their intelligence; the case was mysterious, and the complainant was a seraph.

“There was his undergarment as well, and yes, a glass he was drinking his whiskey in earlier. Can you also think through this? Why would I fake the presence of my boyfriend at this resort? What could come out of this? I think we are wasting time while he may be in trouble. Please, Inspector, the search should be outside, not inside.” Rati came, almost pleading, and held my hand.

Electricity ran through my body again, and I wanted to believe her.

I asked Sami to continue searching for more clues about how Ayaan had come to the cottage while I took Dipen outside to check if Jimmy had a clue for us.

I told Rati that I would be back and left the cottage. We went to the reception and saw Ms Fernandez pacing up and down. That teenage boy Shyam was not to be seen, and the only staff remaining was probably waiting to serve dinner to Rati.

The other guests had retired to their rooms, and I asked Dipen to call Jimmy as I turned toward Ms Fernandez to converse with her.

“Would you like to have some dinner, Sir? I know it’s late, but it’s best to have something from here and then go,” she said. Her voice did not suggest that she wanted me to accept the invitation, but it was still nice that she was extending the courtesy.

“Yes, we can have some kinema and momos if you have them ready.” I had developed a taste for them and was not letting my staff and myself go hungry during this ordeal.

She looked at her staff, who immediately rushed to the kitchen, which I believe was closed for the day. I saw some lights getting switched on and a few people cursing a bunch of other people in the background.

They may not be happy, but my stomach growled.

Day 2

Waiting Rati

The axe had not hit me, and the monster was a human, sending shivers down my spine. A beast may spare you. A human won't. There was an eerie silence after my attacker got his axe stuck in the bark. I had ducked, and I could still feel my heart pumping blood into my troubled veins.

I turned back to escape, but I realised my calves were locked in the palms of my attacker. My eyes enlarged as I realised with horror that the human had not given up. I tried to see his face again, still covered in the mask, but he wouldn't let go.

I kicked hard to get free, and fate sided with me and one of my boots. I managed to hit the groin of the puny human, leaving him bawling in pain. I jumped on top of him, and my other boot found a spot of luck, too, connecting with his monstrous face. He whimpered, and I removed the mask, which was now stained with blood.

The fog was coming in stronger now, and even though the face was less than two feet away from me, it was tough to make sense of his features because of the broken nose. The moonlight would have helped, but the swaying leaves cast dark shadows, making it even more difficult to see clearly.

As the wind settled and the leaves became still, I could finally get a clear view of the human's face as the fog dissipated. The disfigured face looked like a million broken skulls had formed a collage. Satan bled, and I tried hard to identify him. Before I could, though, I felt his hand on my head, pulling my ponytail.

I screamed now, a shriek that rang through the godforsaken forest. My eyes closed. A moth fluttered in the background, and pine cones crackled as the human loomed over me.

I woke up drenched in sweat again – panting, thirsty, and panicked. The dream felt real, and my heartbeat thumped loudly between my lungs like before. I looked at the pillow and saw yellow marks on it again. I removed the pillow cover as it smelled weird, and to my horror, the pillow under the cover was spotted, too. The remnants of sweat after a feverish sleep, The remnants of semen after passionate sex, the remnants of saliva when one has slept like a baby, and the remnants of blood, hopefully, because the pillow comforted a menstruating woman and not because of anything more violent. I threw the pillow on the floor.

My thoughts returned to my dream – the nightmares seemed to expand in their scope, getting more convoluted by night. I had not brought along my prescribed pills, foolishly entrusting my sanity to Dzongu. I hadn't taken them for over a few months. I could not get hold of my therapist; she only met me in person. Could the nightmares be a result of the state of mind I was in? Alone and scared?

Ayaan had not returned, and one could claim he was missing. It had been more than 30 hours since I last saw him.

I had no hope from the lecherous Inspector and his two dumb wits. I could have hired a private investigating agency in Gurgaon if the government officials had not displayed urgency with their investigation. I had no such options here, yet I could not complacently go along with the pace of those three who spent too much time at the cottage last night only to leave with fake promises of getting back sooner rather than later.

The sun had just broken through the skies, and the dawn encouraged me to believe that today would be better. I needed to manifest better thoughts in life. Even positive energy would yield better results than the investigation by the local officials.

After a quick shower, I dried myself, knowing fully well that the answers only lay outside the cottage. I put on my sneakers and stepped out of the room swiftly. The sun welcomed me outside, and the dew drops on the leaves shone happily with my presence.

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“Where is Shyam?” I asked. Ms Fernandez, a.k.a aunty, now seemed visibly irritated with the services she offered this undesired guest. She had trudged

outside her door, wrapping herself in the shawl. Either I had woken her up, or she had slept lightly.

“What?” She asked, yawning.

I repeated my question, and her expressions were indifferent. “He is back at his home in Lingdong. He has college to attend. He only comes here when I ask him to.”

“But you need to call him back. He was the only one other than me who had spent time with Ayaan, he is the prime witness in this case.”

“Madam, no one has seen Ayaan. Not even him. Inspector Vipin will tell us what to do. Please do not tell us what to do,” she said coldly.

I understood. The boundaries between host and guest were slowly dissipating. I had to remain firm — a step outside this property, and this case would be closed with me being labelled as a delusional guest.

“Is Mr Fernandez back?”

“No, he is not. If he is not back today, I will send Shyam or one of my husband’s friends to look around. We Dzongu women do not worry much if our husbands do not return for two to three days.” Her eyes judged me for worrying about my boyfriend.

“No wonder you are finding my concern invalid.” I stepped back, leaving the property, hoping to get a more accommodating *Lepcha* to offer me a ride to the police station.

In just a few moments, the mellifluous sound of the cooing birds had changed into a cacophony. The sun hid behind the sinister clouds, and I felt the light betray me.

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The police station reeked of incompetence, and the situation looked like any other government office. It seemed everything in the police station was just waking up—the chairs, the tables, the guy in the lockup, and the windows that had been opened only a few minutes back.

Some staff were about to leave the station, while those with the morning shift had just arrived. The men in uniform from earlier shifts yawned while the eyes of the ones who had just come in searched for an explanation for my presence that early in the day.

“Where is Inspector Vipin? Have you found out where Ayaan is?” I was on tenterhooks the moment that the first sentence came out of my

mouth. My question was aimed at no one in particular, so no one cared to answer it. The eyes did not leave me, but the mouths chose not to open.

“Where is Inspector Vipin?” I screamed.

“I am right here,” a voice replied. I turned around and noticed Vipin had entered the station. He was fresh but still looked old and unshaven and smelled of Old Spice, and he was upbeat but still walked like a drunk. I understood. He had too much alcohol last night. Maybe he was awake thinking about the missing Ayaan and his sultry girlfriend, or his damned luck that got him assigned to this case.

“Did you find Ayaan?”

“Do you see him?”

I scoffed. “You could be a stand-up comedian.”

“Thank you. After this job, I am thinking about taking that up. I think the stage would love me more than my stakeholders here.” He used his splendid gift of repartee.

“Would that be because you were fired for being incompetent at this job?”

“It’s been less than 24 hours since your boyfriend went missing, so technically, by starting the investigation yesterday, I have already exceeded expectations.” He walked around to his room as if he owned the station, almost simulating a mic drop.

I saw him vanishing inside his filthy hole in defiance, and I stomped inside to follow him. The swinging partition doors bore the brunt of my anger and creaked violently.

“You do realise that this could cost anything — maybe he is in danger, or maybe he is lost or in a terrible accident. Every minute is important now.”

“Or maybe he ran away. Maybe he was cheating on you. Did you ever think that might be the case?” Vipin asked, point blank.

I would be fooling myself had I denied that possibility. The last few months had often made me wonder about this, and I nodded in concurrence.

“Listen, I know that you are disturbed, and rightfully so. I am not here to defend the capabilities of the system. But the answers will come in when they will, and there is nothing more that you, I, or the force can do about it.”

I sensed genuineness triumphing over his debauchery from last night and let him continue.

“We notified all railway stations, bus terminals, and the airport last night. Some dedicated cab agencies work for inter-state transport, and we have also contacted them. The SOS messages were sent last night. It’s only been eight hours since the broadcast, and we will need to wait an equal amount of time to arrive at anything concrete,” Vipin clarified.

“And what happens if we don’t hear back from them?”

Vipin went quiet, and I understood—the probability of finding Ayaan reduced with every single minute. I shivered at the thought that he may never be seen again, but Vipin had a reassuring expression on his otherwise stolid face.

“That means he is around. Or what you said — he is missing because something bad has happened. But do not worry. I do not see any motive yet. Is there anything that you forgot to share earlier and remember now? Anything that may help us?” He enquired.

I sat down on a nearby bench. I noticed my mobile was getting network – and while there were no messages from Ayaan, I found a couple of notifications from our house help. We were supposed to leave today, and they wanted to check when we were due to arrive.

“I will call his colleagues, friends, and family today,” I said. There was no point in just sitting around and waiting for a miracle to happen. I wanted to contribute.

Vipin shared his plan. “You may please do so. We would do that too, in any case, as part of the routine process, but only after a few hours, once 24 hours have passed since the time he is known to be missing. We are yet to cover a few family members of the owner, Shyam and Mr Fernandez. I will also call Shikha, another guest who stayed in the hotel while you were at the resort.”

The name sounded familiar even though I couldn’t recall where I had heard it before.

Searching Vipin

As Rati left the station, I sighed and looked around. My head spun from incessant drinking last night, which left my liver sore and grumpy. The headache was back, worsened by the zooming trucks on the highway, the pile of files yet to be sorted, and the photo of Gandhiji judging me as the father of the nation was disappointed that I was not the ideal citizen-son.

The chaos I felt inside was because my heart ached for Rati. I had an unflinching urge to hold her. To comfort her and tell her it would be alright. To let her know that I felt her pain and to say to her that Ayaan was not the right guy for her. No one was, if truth be told. Her pure soul needed no connections with us unholy humans.

I realised I was falling head over heels for my stakeholder, client, customer, or whatever you could call her. I did not care how inappropriate it was. I did not care what the rules of moral conduct said. I was drawn to her like a moth to the flame. Aware of my impending death, I wanted to dive right into her burning embrace.

“Sir, I think we found something.” Jimmy interrupted my thoughts, wiping a smug smile off my face.

“I hope it’s better than another open thread. Tell me you spotted the guy somewhere.” I wished.

“We did not, but we have found evidence conclusively proving that Ayaan was here.” Jimmy had a smile on his face, just like the one a kid displays at the end of finding candy after the treasure hunt.

My eyes followed his excitement to his desk, where he opened a folder containing CCTV footage on his computer. Sami and Dipen joined in as well.

“What do you see here? This footage is from four days ago. And... that’s Ayaan!” Dipen paused and continued, “But who is that girl with him?”

Tracing back a shrewd mammal who hides his tracks can be complicated. Ayaan could be a naive person or a clever one, the type who leaves out some breadcrumbs for those who might pick on his scent. Even if this was merely a deception, we had no choice but to follow the lead. But I had another breakthrough: I recognised the lady in the picture, whilst others were exhilarated by having spotted Ayaan. I had seen her ID copy at Shine Resort.

I dialled the number of the girl in the footage, and she picked up after three rings.

“Hello? This is Shikha,” said the voice from the other side.

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Monogamy as a concept was beyond my understanding. Or it may have been because I had never been in love. I have had my share of affairs, infatuations, and misunderstandings. With my first girlfriend, whom I thought I was connected to beyond multiple rebirths, it took only three short flings to get over our broken promises. There was a time when I thought I could be the knight in shining armour of a lady of the night, and another time, I believed I could be the lifetime patient of a nurse who treated a grazing bullet on my shoulder. I had been a die-hard romantic, and I know that how quickly I fell in love had a direct connection with how soon I got over it.

Rati could be different, though. My senses had never been enamoured this way before. My manhood had never been titillated this way either, but a man’s character, especially like mine, would never change. I might get over her, too; it might take just a few more flings than usual.

I wasn’t surprised at Ayaan cheating on Rati. He never deserved her in the first place, as he wasn’t worthy to be a beast to that beauty. Also, who brings in another girl to the party during a romantic getaway? No one, unless you have evil intentions in mind. I thought of the three of them together, and Ayaan making a mess of it all and giggled.

“What were you saying?” Shikha asked. She grappled with the uncomfortable silence when I asked if she knew Ayaan.

I repeated myself.

“Yes, what about that?” she scoffed.

“How?”

“He was a good friend.”

“Was?”

“Yes, we don’t talk anymore.”

“Hmmm....” I wondered what question I should ask her next. I have footage of them from a few days back, but she chose to pick up a line from the famous Charlie Puth song. I wondered how soon people relegated their lovers to the past these days.

“When did you last speak to him?”

“I don’t remember,” she said.

I clenched my teeth. She wasn’t a jellyfish but pretended as though her memory was surely that of one. “Do you remember coming with Ayaan to Dzongu and checking into the Shine Resort?”

She cut the call. I was frustrated at her unabashed reaction. What a rookie — cutting ties at the first sign of trouble. I tried again, and her mobile was switched off. I sighed and asked Jimmy to locate her mobile’s tower. She’d probably be curled up in the corner of one of her friend’s houses in Gurgaon when we found her, and I could bet all my assets on it.

But reaching her was imperative, given she would have clues on his whereabouts. She would not have cut the call if Ayaan had been with her.

Sami and Dipen looked at other footage found by Jimmy, one of them showing that Shikha left Dzongu yesterday alone. None of the footage confirmed if Ayaan had left that goddamn town.

I asked Sami to leave right away after Jimmy confirmed the location. Shikha may be the panacea we were looking for. I also asked him to track down any other mobiles active near the resort. It was possible that even though Ayaan destroyed his earlier SIM, he might have been using some other mobile number.

Dipen and I decided to go around Shine Resort and the nearby marketplaces to check if anyone recognised Ayaan. Rati sent me his picture last night on WhatsApp when she got the network, and I looked at her ravishing profile picture for the zillionth time as I left the police station.

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They should have written that one should judge a book by its cover when one visited the town of Dzongu. Hidden somewhere in the lap of the Himalayas, which marked its periphery, one could not help falling in love

with that town if they ever crossed it by road. Or the ones more used to a lavish lifestyle might spot this place from the window seats of their low-altitude planes and promise to visit at least once in their lifetime.

I was eager to be part of it when they told me I was getting transferred here. The fun may still last for visitors or the ones who had no choice because they were born there, but for outsiders like me, that was a place I felt I had to stay at because of my bad karma.

I looked disdainfully at the roads, judging the small shops adorning its sides, all of which remained closed. It was 9 a.m., according to my watch, the sun still playing hide and seek in the clouds, and the Himalayas' peaks added to the picturesque view. Many tourists who were early risers like me would have gone out for a walk and given business to the small-time vendors. Most of the vendors, however, were snuggled back in their homes, drinking *Temí Tea* and shitting on their uninspiring lives.

"Where do you want to go first, Sir?" Dipen asked earnestly, and I pitied him for being a misfit in the otherwise laidback local population. He was a good kid – eager to prove the worth of his government salary and passionate about this job.

"Let's go to the houses at the bottom of the hill where the Shine Resort is. We will start from there and then take the shops nearby. Hopefully, someone would have spotted him." I lit a cigarette as Dipen rolled down the windows of the jeep.

"If he was a smoker, I doubt he would have carried enough stock for three days. We may want to try the paan shops near the resort, which are within a ten-minute walk." Dipen said.

I looked at him and had an epiphany. The kid was brilliant, too, and I nodded at his brilliance.

The Big Reveal

Rati

All that binge-watching of crime documentaries on OTT was not coming in handy. You might think you have become smarter after every episode, but the learning does not transfer to real life. The moment something happens to you, you fall into an abyss and keep falling, waiting for your lifeless soul and your convoluted thoughts to hit rock bottom. I missed my pills; I missed Gurgaon. I missed the love of my life, and I missed that he was not here to guide me on what I should do next. I was lost, and my soul wandered the hills, searching for my soulmate.

The auto from the police station dropped me at the bottom of the hill, where the walk to Shine Resort would have taken close to fifteen more minutes. The auto guy said the road ahead was too steep for his auto's dying engine, and I had no energy left to curse him or my fate at that moment. I paid him and faced the incline leading to the hell hole named Shine Resort.

As my feet advanced, my brain realised I couldn't be waiting any longer for Vipin and his incapable team to bring me some updates. I would have to take the matter into my own hands, even if that put me in the same kind of danger that Ayaan may have gotten into.

I tried to think of places outside the resort where Ayaan and I had spent hours, where someone may have spotted us. I needed conclusive proof that Ayaan existed and that someone else confirming his presence would benefit my case. Hopefully, the police would believe me then.

Ayaan and I had visited a couple of places. We had been to a bike rental guy, a street hawker selling woollen caps, and a coffee shop in the shopping district. We had spent less than five minutes in the first two places, and the conversations that followed were purely perfunctory. But in the coffee shop, I remembered that we had spent over an hour as that was the only place where we had a good network and Wi-Fi, and we both had gone on a calling spree, connecting with many of our contacts.

Many heads turned, and eyebrows arched whenever we strolled around in any public place. We were a striking couple. At the coffee shop, too, a server may have spotted us, or somebody else may have noticed us. Many couples like us visited this town, but I was sure that as a couple, we were extra memorable.

I opened the door, and the wind chimes tinkled as the cold breeze swept through the otherwise warm cafe. Customers were yet to arrive, but the housekeeping staff had already made the place sparkling clean. The owner-manager in the woollen cap was waiting for his day to begin, going through this cash drawer again and ensuring his last day's earnings were good enough to power through the costs today.

The cafe's colour scheme was pristine white. The walls on two sides were glass partitions on a wooden frame that created smaller square boxes. The sun's rays poured through the framed boxes and into the cafe, bathing the porcelain crockery and the granite tabletops in light. The servers also wore white. The marble floors completed the ensemble, and the jazz music piping through the speakers was a nod to famous musicians from the last century, whose pictures adorned the creamy walls.

The millennials of Dzongu were embracing all kinds of contemporary art to entice tourists. My resort, along with the coffee shop, was at the pinnacle of this change.

I went straight to the manager, who greeted me with a *Namaste*. He seemed pleasantly surprised to see me.

"How are you doing, madam? I thought you shared that you were about to leave today. Have you checked out already?" he asked.

It was now my turn to be pleasantly surprised at his memory. I hoped he remembered Ayaan as well.

"I have not. My friend, the one that I came with... has gone missing," I told the elderly manager.

"What? Where has he gone?"

"I don't know. The police are now involved as well." I stopped myself from getting emotional. "You had seen him, right?"

"Of course, I had! We don't get many generous customers like you, and having you with us, even for one meal, was a pleasure," he smiled.

So now I have conclusive proof that Ayaan has been with me in Dzongu. However, the manager continued.

“Apart from the tips, I was happy you could connect with friends and relatives. Speaking of which, has your cousin checked out?” he asked.

“My cousin?” I confirmed if I had heard it right.

“Yes, your cousin. The one your friend had come with later, almost half an hour after you left. They were in an animated discussion, and your friend told the server that the lady with him was your cousin, and they were planning a surprise for you.”

The manager’s words were like a blow to me. Ayaan had told me that he was out of cigarettes the day we came to this cafe, and hence, after we went up to the resort, he left for a while while I took a shower and a much-needed nap.

I decided to get a cappuccino and gather my thoughts. Some other information may come in to clear Ayaan. Since this was where I got a network, I decided to call and check with everyone who might know where he could be.

It took me over an hour to send SOS messages to everyone — one, two, three, and a million. No one had a clue where Ayaan was. The other surprise was that his office colleague told me he never planned to return today; he had given the return date from his vacation a week later. This was news to me, as we had planned to return to Delhi by now. What was he planning to do this entire time, for a whole extra week?

The angle of another person involved in his life worried me, and it occurred to me that our mobile numbers were under a family plan. I downloaded his mobile bills from previous months to check. One number stood out, having been called multiple times in these two months, and I used Truecaller to find out who that number was registered to. The name that showed up was making its appearance for the second time today. I rushed out of the cafe to learn more about ‘Shikha.’

I was panting throughout the climb up to the resort. I was sure Shikha would have had a role to play in Ayaan’s disappearance. Was Vipin correct? Were they having an affair? What was he doing in the cafés with her?

It was then that I recalled that one night in Gurgaon, I had seen multiple calls from her to Ayaan on his mobile. I asked him then who she was, and he said it was for a possible business meet-up between them. He told me then that she was a client with good news for his start-up.

Thinking back, this explanation could not justify the many calls. Her presence in the resort when Ayaan and I were planning for a baby also could

not be explained. I took the support of a boulder to catch my breath and saw that the mobile tower bars on my mobile were reduced to one. I immediately dialled Vipin before I went out of range.

He told me he was going to the resort because he had discovered some crucial information about Ayaan. I mentioned Shikha, and he kept mum. I understood—something had transpired between the love of my life and that witch. My body started shaking, and I started running toward the resort. I was ready to discover whatever secrets would come out of the closet.

Investigation Again

Vipin

A couple of shopkeepers said they saw someone resembling Ayaan, but only the cigarette shop vendor conclusively identified him. He shared that Ayaan was a heavy smoker and took packets of a brand called 'Ice-burst,' which was not readily available at Dzongu. The vendor had to procure the same from Gangtok; hence, even as a fleeting customer, Ayaan could not be forgotten easily.

As we made our way to the resort to discover more about Shikha, Rati called and shared that Shikha and Ayaan had been in touch for the last few months. I wasn't surprised, given that their pictures from the Gangtok and Gurgaon airports would make one believe they were in a relationship. I tried to imagine why Ayaan would be so brazen when it came to Shikha and their not-so-discreet relationship. The possibilities could be two — he was either at the end of his relationship with Rati, or maybe he did not care enough as he thought Rati would never find out. One would never know.

Dipen steered the jeep through the hairpin-filled road towards the resort, as only Shine Resort could now give us much-needed answers.

The mist had vanished, and the land was slowly regaining its dryness. The shadows cast by the long-stemmed trees were slowly becoming shorter, and the wheels of our jeep raced on the unmetalled road, holding up bravely against the wind and the errant stones.

Shine Resort was now in view — like a bit of cherry on the top of the hill. It would have the last word.

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Ms Fernandez shared with us that Shikha had checked in alone. She hadn't seen anyone with Shikha when she came out a few times to the dining area where food was served. However, Ms Fernandez shared that Shikha always

looked tense — checking her mobile and looking at the entrance as if expecting someone.

Ms Fernandez encouraged Dipen and me to speak to the staff again, showing pictures of Ayaan the second time. My script would be convoluted now, to the point of being funny. What would I ask the staff now? “You may not have seen this guy with the earlier ma’am Rati, but with another madam Shikha.... She stayed at the resort during the same period. Can you please jog your memory again?”

I wondered how Ayaan managed two-timing when I was still single and shagging my brains out every night after getting high. True love has no takers.

Dipen looked at my sullen face and shared that two housekeepers had seen a man with Shikha on one of the days she was staying at the resort. Though his face was hidden by a woollen cap, a mask, and shades, his body description matched Ayaan’s.

Rati was hovering around with her factoid from the cafe below on Ayaan and Shikha’s rendezvous. However, the next stage of the investigation could have begun only when Shikha returned to Dzongu, as we had almost exhausted our information sources. A scan through the remaining hotels and homestays continued, and I decided to do the same to get rid of Rati and her angelic redolence. Even when she was panicking, her halo engulfed me. It was driving me crazy.

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Dipen did not switch on the engine as the jeep rolled down the incline; he was excited about all the petrol he was able to save. I smiled at his antics and wondered if I would have done the same. As we reached the market and the day progressed, the town was bustling with energy. The vendors who had not opened shop yet would now do so only in the evening; they had gotten ‘so happy’ with *Chang* that they gulped down last night.

Since Ayaan wanted to keep his presence a secret, he may have shortlisted another hideout in Dzongu. He would have done this research back in Gurgaon, which meant there was a high probability that this hotel would have been listed on the internet. This logic helped us zero in on twelve properties within a five-mile radius. We decided to visit each of them in the next couple of hours. The jeep came to life as the slope ended, and

Dipen switched on the engine; adrenaline rushed into my body, and the taste of steel filled my mouth. My mobile pinged; there was a text notification from Sami — he had landed in Delhi to hunt Shikha down.

Dzongu wasn't seeing many illegitimate relationships nor a steady stream of family tourists, making it easy for anyone to recall a chary individual. All eleven property managers we met shared details of all guests, but none matched the description of 'Ayaan' or 'Ayaan and Shikha.' Even though it was listed online, one property was permanently closed. The owners said they would be using the space to open a restaurant. To each his will.

Dipen and I were frustrated that there was nothing more to be done, and we were stuck till we got some news from Sami. My mobile rang again, and without looking at the screen, I picked up and said, "Tell me you have some good news, Sami."

"Sir, it's me, Jimmy."

"Go on," my tone remained the same, and my hopes rested on Jimmy's brilliance. Sami could get in line and delight me later.

"The Pioneer Corps from the Indian Army called. While touring roads built by the Indian Border Organisation, they happened to be stopped by some locals, who were panicking. They went ahead to help them, only to spot a dead body a hundred feet down in the valley. It looks like the rider's bike skid, as the bike was found in a shattered condition on the road ahead."

"Any more details? Is it Ayaan?" I asked, my heart getting the better of my breath.

"We do not know it right now, sir. The officer who called has asked us to report to the spot. Something about a minister visiting Gangtok next week and that we need to clean the mess ASAP." I could sense the urgency in Jimmy's voice.

"Assholes" is all I could muster.

Sikkim, the state of which Dzongu was a part, was surrounded by three countries. Nepal, Bhutan, and China. The Indian Army frequented this place, and their current involvement would complicate things further. My Dzongu stint wasn't a peaceful retreat from Kerala.

Since Rati was the only person who had filed a missing person's complaint, we had to take her to identify the body as part of the process. My thoughts were laden with anticipation over how Rati would react if that

dead body were that of Ayaan. Our jeep now zoomed through the town's roads, the residents turning to be dark horses for me.

I shuddered at the thought of what would happen if that dead body was not of Ayaan. We would have two open cases, then.

I sighed.

Dead Body

Rati

When you come to know that your loved one may have been unfaithful to you, the mind alters your emotions instantly.

I wondered how that happened, but the answer was simple. A human doesn't love another human. We love being in love with that perfect one, but in reality, we are in love with the perfect frame. Someone may fit that frame, and our desperation decides the accuracy with which that person fits.

For me, Ayaan had fit that frame perfectly. However, the evidence of his treachery, offered to me by the cafe owner, the mobile bill, and the snapshots I saw on Vipin's phone of Ayaan and Shikha with their bodies entangled at the Delhi and Gangtok airport opened my eyes. Ayaan did not fit that frame anymore. He was everything I had wanted until a few hours back. But at this moment and from now on, he was everything that I did not want — an asshole who was faking it. An impostor.

When I had finally accepted the truth late last night, I had hurried into a restroom near the small canteen at the resort. I thought I would howl, but my cries were hollow. There were no tears, just this feeling of helplessness consuming me from inside. I thought my bones would break and turn into ashes. I thought my lungs would suck every ounce of oxygen in that restroom, creating a vacuum, just like Ayaan had done to my soul. His truth made me empty. I thought of screaming against the noise of the faulty flush, but the presence of people outside made me shush. I settled by taking support of my palms on the brink of the stained washbasin and stared into the mirror. I splashed water on my face, telling myself that my life was more than just Ayaan.

The inquisitiveness does not die, though. You want to be avenged for the betrayal, and you want to know the answer to why he did what he did. I then wished for that person to die a slow death, and I wanted to applaud in advance whosoever would burn the filthy soul of that infidel.

Dipen and Vipin remained quiet, and I hid my anticipation as I sat in the comfortable back seat of the jeep. The breeze calmed me down, but my legs shook nervously as I wondered if the dead body would be that of Ayaan. I wanted to know the answer to ‘why’ before deciding how I felt about the mortal who promised me eternity for the last few years of my life.

“Are you tense?” I asked Vipin to distract myself from my vengeful thoughts. He seemed empathetic to my fear, but his mind was clearly preoccupied.

“Isn’t this the question I should be asking you?” Vipin looked back, his expression remaining stoic. His hand stretched across the seat, almost touching Dipen’s shoulder. I was sitting behind Vipin, his pheromones distracting me for the last few minutes. I could see his upcoming bald patch, but his unshaven face made up for most of his once well-built body. His top two shirt buttons were open, his chest hair peeking through, and he noticed that I was noticing him. He had no idea that I was comparing him to Ayaan, who took care of his physique despite his hectic schedule. Where there is a will, there is a way.

He blushed and became conscious, and I understood. He may be a wealthy man with witty repartees, but he was deprived of female attention. I got a hint of this last night, but now, I was sure. I now knew how to always be on top of him, and get my work done on finding Ayaan. My eyes could get him in line. He had a loose zip.

Our eyes met, and he turned his head towards the road in front. The sun shone against the tar, and he put on his shades. After a while, he started tapping his fingers, probably syncing them with a song in his head.

Dipen looked at his boss as he pressed the brakes, and the jeep came to a screeching halt. I noticed a few army men approaching our jeep, and my thoughts returned to Ayaan again.

“By the way, Shikha is on her way to Gangtok as we speak,” Dipen added as we descended into the valley.

I nodded and zeroed in on my feelings for Ayaan. I so wanted that dead body to be that of Ayaan.

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My heartbeat rose as we made the slippery descent, with the occasional *Kattus* trees helping us recover our balance. Soon, the flora became denser,

making the sunlight struggle to reach the ground and enabling the insects to create all the mating sounds they wanted. The dry leaves crepitated in defiance as my Nike stepped on them. They probably assumed I was out rambling, while my eyes wondered how long I had to endure this adventure before I could see the body.

A few soldiers from the Indian Army, a photographer, staff from the police station, and an ageing team belonging to the forensic department circled an area. I assumed their focus of attention was the body, and my fingers went cold.

“Relax, I am with you,” Vipin said. I felt relieved at that moment.

“Go ahead,” he said. My feet went forward to peep through the circle as I saw Jimmy rushing towards Vipin and whispering into his ears. He knew who the body belonged to before I validated it.

I recognised the dead body as soon as the people around gave way. It wasn't Ayaan. It was someone else I had seen three days back.

The body was battered, and even a fool would know this wasn't just a hit-and-run case. The other minute possibility was that a bear let itself loose on Mr Fernandez, who now had flies feeding on his splattered blood.

I looked at Vipin, who did not need me to tell him who this sociable person was. Everyone in Dzongu knew him. He was one of the more affable people in the town and, hopefully, a better man than Ayaan.

I signalled to Vipin that I was returning to the jeep, and he nodded. “Dipen, drop her back carefully and bring Ms Fernandez.” He managed to smile a little, and I acknowledged the same.

I was not sure if I was feeling happy or sad. I understood it was probably the universe's way of telling me that I deserved to know the answers through Ayaan's filthy mouth as and when I could lay hands on him.

Another Open Case

Vipin

Until two days ago, the posting at Dzongu was a bland affair—boring, if I could be less diplomatic—and I was counting the months until this stint ended.

But in the last 36 hours, I was trying to trace out an invisible cheater, had developed a love interest, and was then standing in front of the dead body of the owner of the resort where that cheater had stayed. Maybe Shikha would help; she had landed in Gangtok sometime back and was on the way to the police station. Somehow, my gut told me, all this was interconnected.

Ms Fernandez walked down the shallow valley through the grass; she was sure that activity was a waste of her time. Her expression conveyed that she had gone through the trauma already and did not care about it anymore. I wondered if she had more pressing matters back at the resort to take care of rather than identifying the body of the person who resembled her husband. I would be more worried if my significant other were unreachable for the last two days. Like Rati, maybe?

“It...it is... It’s him,” Ms Fernandez said as her knees fell. Her mouth opened, and no sound came from it as tears made their way from her eyes to her cheeks and fell on the grass, which was dark red with her husband’s blood.

The paramedics took her aside, and I signalled the team to take the body, given the identification was complete. He asked his team to seal the area, at least 20 feet wide from the body, ensuring that evidence, if any, was not tampered with. I asked Dipen to take her to the station while I tried to look around for evidence – a locket, a mobile, or something that could help me get started on confirming that it was not a hit-and-miss accident.

No crash and no fall from the valley could be responsible for how his head was badgered. There were no valuables left on his body. It was possible that he had an accident and fell down the valley. And instead of

saving him, a local thief decided to make the best out of a vulnerable man and killed him to steal his petty belongings.

I smoked my Marlboro hard as I sighed and walked on the trodden path leading towards the road. An anxious Shikha and a troubled Ms Fernandez were waiting for me at the police station.

Visions

Rati

The room was dark, with a window near the ceiling bringing in limited hope. I felt trapped because of the chain around my feet. My hands were tied with identical loops from a battling rope. I could taste blood as the tight duct tape charred my lips. I tried to stand up, but the iron hook I was chained to in the corner was sturdy. I did not recognise that place, and with my limited vision, I could gather that the room did not remember me either.

The monster was nowhere to be seen. Paranoia hit my senses again, making me feel like peeing in my jeans. I tried to cry, but the tears refused to come out. I felt dirty, alone, thirsty, and itchy all over. However, more than anything, I felt that my end was near. The sweat wet my hair, and I could feel it dripping down my chin to my navel.

Where was I? What was happening? I heard footsteps and turned around, only to see no one. I must have been hallucinating.

I noticed it then — the room housed a few rodents, the most prominent amongst them being rats, whose squeaks pierced my ears. They rushed through the corners, from one end to another. From one bunch of dead leaves to another. From the minimal broken furniture in one corner to another. The cobwebs and dust shielded them, but their eyes shimmered in the dim light, sending chills down my spine. It felt like they were evaluating me, waiting for my breath to give up before my flesh could become their feast.

I heard a different sound then — the one a snake makes as it slithers on the ground. I saw the black reptile approaching my feet, and I felt my heart pump a lot of blood in the next few seconds.

My vision blurred, and tinnitus took over as my eyelids blocked sight of whatever was about to follow.

The afternoon wine wore off, thanks to the dreaded nightmare that ended my short nap. I had earlier finished the last bottle of wine Ayaan and I brought from Gurgaon to calm my nerves, but my anxiety got the better of me. I drank the whole bottle in half an hour, waiting for someone from the resort staff to come and update me on what was happening with Ms Fernandez.

I paced up and down the cottage, trying to pack everything. Somehow, I wanted to get the hell out of that place. I did not feel safe there and felt that my privacy might be intruded upon. My silent screams would echo before I finally got lost in the valleys.

After I was done packing, I called reception. A hassled lady picked up, asking what I wanted. I wasn't sure if any more guests were staying in the cottage, so I wondered why they had to ask which room I stayed in before answering my request to send a busser. Part of the induction training, I guess.

"Ma'am, we have been asked not to allow you to check out until Ms Fernandez returns."

"What? Why?" I asked.

The hassled staff repeated her statement.

"I got it the first time. Why this rule? Why can't I check out? I am ready to clear all my dues immediately."

"I don't know, mam. Something to do with the police. Please wait until further notice." She cut the call after passing on the summon.

I was getting fidgety, and the answer to all my queries rested with Ms Fernandez. And then some with Shikha, some with Ayaan and the remaining with Vipin.

I dragged my belongings to the reception in any case. I would not be staying in this cottage and this resort, where my boyfriend had vanished, where I learned about his affair, and where the resort's owner is dead.

The receptionist lady was petrified to see me with my bag, as I asked to keep the same in the safe room. "I am not checking out. But as you are unwilling to give me any answers, I am going to the place where I can get those from."

She nodded, "You can get an auto from downhill...."

I scuttled out of her sight before she could finish her sentence.

The vibe of the police station had taken a U-turn from the morning's indolence. From meandering insomniacs to headless chickens, from the smell of petrichor to the smell of sweat, from laidback attitude to genuine earnestness, from no leads to a lead and a new murder case, Dzongu station was buzzing with action.

My eyes searched for Vipin, and he was trying to console and get whatever he could out of Ms Fernandez. The creepy Shyam was lurking in the background, and in another room, I noticed Sami talking to a girl, apparently from Delhi, because of how she dressed and how her bangles from Karol Bagh jingled. My instincts told me to slap her, but my mind took control, and I made peace with observing things from a distance, sitting on a creaking wooden bench. The wood had cracks all over, just like the scars now etched on my life forever.

Ms Fernandez stood up from her seat, Shyam holding his aunt's hand, trying to wipe her non-existent tears. For some reason, she wasn't as perturbed as I had expected, but then, one never knows what happens in a relationship between two people, just like mine.

My gaze was fixated on Shikha, who did not seem rattled by the experience. I had to admit that she was gorgeous. The journey from Gurgaon to Dzongu for an illicit relationship had not budged her makeup. Even the stench from the files in the police station had not suppressed her cheap perfume, and even the grilling since the last few hours by the tired middle-aged man that was Sami had not weakened her spirit. She turned her head and noticed me, our eyes meeting momentarily. She looked back in front, and I sauntered towards her.

"Sami Sir, I need to speak to her," my plea came in like an order, and Sami's eyebrows rose and met his forehead.

"I am not done with my questions, ma'am," he politely refused.

"Where is Ayaan?" I asked Shikha directly.

"In my pocket. Wanna see?" Shikha scoffed.

"You bitch! You slut!" I lost it and was seconds away from grabbing her ponytail and smacking her forehead on the table.

She stood up and looked me in the eyes.

"He was right. You are a psycho."

I clenched my fists, and my arm swayed with the desire to hurt her wisdom tooth. Before I could attack her cheeks, a sweaty but sturdy palm

held my fist. I looked into Vipin's eyes, and his eyes told me he expected better from me. His gesture immediately cooled me down, and I gave up.

"Can I please be informed if she gave any details about Ayaan?" my tone changed, accompanied by my drooping shoulders. I kept hoping Vipin would have all the answers. But he shook his head, and his eyes looked toward Shikha.

Shikha looked at me and laughed. This wasn't a laugh for me. She was laughing at herself.

"Oh! I am so stupid. Throughout this whole time, I thought that you would know where he was and that all this was a ploy to extract money. Ayaan's actions confirmed this when he abandoned me at the resort. I now understand I have been tricked as much as you, and it is a shame that I gave in to my bodily urges and let my heart control my mind. How could I do this?" Shikha now seemed rattled, and it brought me relief. She deserved more and more of this pain.

"Ma'am, can you please tell us exactly what happened between you and Ayaan?" Vipin said, taking Shikha, Sami, and me into his room. Through my eyes, I spotted Shyam and Ms Fernandez stepping into the police jeep. None of them seemed sad.

Indifferent was the right word to describe their expression.

Lost Shikha

Small-town girl, feminist, pretty princess of my parents. Protected, intelligent, and fiercely independent.

My bio on Bumble encapsulated my life's journey perfectly. I wasn't any different from many out there. But it wasn't common for a girl to have all her pictures in Salwar Kurta on Bumble looking for a 'Fuck-And-Forget' encounter. Let's go on a date and see if we want to take it to bed. Let's see if your sex drive matches mine. In the game of who climaxes last, I will let you win. The taste of the sweat after sex and the early morning rush to never see each other again will follow, and life will go on as usual.

My life had been so boring in my hometown that I craved adventures like these. I hated patriarchy, its customs, and how society had tampered with it enough for its convenience. We were raised to remain virgins, with our arranged husbands helping us finally break our vow of celibacy.

Somewhere, I wanted to have control over men. Ultimately, they were all fools, slaves of their short-term epiphanies, and even a simplistic manoeuvre from our end could help a woman like me win a lottery in the long run.

So there I was on Bumble, living my parallel life. A hard-working IT engineer who called her mother after dinner and then went out on a date to be pampered. By a new guy every day. And that was the best part of Bumble. I chose what I wanted. Married or Single. Old or Young. Rich or Poor. Service or Business. Nothing else mattered to me if you got my motor running.

And then I met Ayaan.

— —

When you meet your equal, the battle of senses is exciting — his wit versus mine, his moves versus mine. When we used to hang around, an equal

number of guys looked at me, and an equal number of girls noticed him. In his mind, he was a stud. And in my mind, I was a diva.

There was nothing that I had to prove to him. Neither did he have anything to prove to me. But it was new, very different, and somehow, I felt he was too nice a guy to be a prey to my ghosting tendencies. When he told me he stayed with his psycho girlfriend, I believed in him. I pitied him and felt the need to help him through the ordeal. His charm worked upon me, mainly because of his zeal and attitude towards life, bolstered by his scorching looks. He was intelligent, just like I liked them.

When a girl like me finds someone precious who is already committed, jealousy takes over. The zeal to prove I was better than her current girlfriend drove my decisions, and I made it a personal goal to make him mine. I may not have wanted him earlier, but clearly, I wanted what that psycho had.

I shredded my recently adopted chic pretensions and returned to my comfort zone. The gullible geek who had to please her anchor. Ayaan had my complete trust, and I would have done anything to make him mine.

Maybe he realised that. Perhaps I was a pawn amongst many others he had placed on the chessboard. Maybe that was what he wanted.

— —

He told me he wanted some time off from his girlfriend and only time with his soulmate; apparently, that was me. We were in my apartment, our usual place when we wanted to be alone and have peace and tea away from the chaos.

Our bodies were entwined on the bed after a passionate session. My head was on his chest, and I could feel the thumping heartbeat through his sturdy chest. His beard ruffled against my forehead, and he kissed me — a wet kiss — while his palms pulled my body closer. I had never wanted that embrace to end.

“But why Dzongu of all places?”

“Away from the hustle of the cities, low networks, picturesque and romantic — what more do we want to get lost in each other? I just want some ‘you and me’ time.” Ayaan clarified. “Also, this colleague of mine went there and gave me such raving reviews that I kept thinking about the things we would do there the whole time,” he smiled again.

I got lost in his warmth and felt my eyes closing as he said, “You, please take care of flight bookings. Book everything non-refundable – you’ll get a heavy discount. Also, book Shine Resort, but please book it only for single occupancy.”

“Why single occupancy?” I asked, still fighting sleep.

“If I cannot make it that day for any reason, I still want you to go. A key client account may come and meet us then. I will join you once I get free,” he said.

“Why can’t we do it some other time?”

“This window looks good. Let’s utilise it. I will get busier during the coming months,” he asserted.

I complied. I did not feel there was any malice in his request. He seemed genuinely interested in taking this relationship forward, and it seemed he loved me.

As he got up, covering his lower body with my white comforter, he said he would shower quickly before leaving. I nodded. Before he closed the door, he looked at me again and reconfirmed — “Don’t forget, it’s Shine Resort.”

I nodded, too.

This was all before, and then I came to Dzongu.

— —

“What happened once you landed here in Gangtok?” Vipin, the Inspector of that dingy police station back at Dzongu, asked me. I had narrated everything about my journey with Ayaan so far to them.

“The flight was fine, but something was not right. He said his mobile got stolen, and he was fidgety throughout our trip to Dzongu. Once here, he became even more on edge, often vanishing for long hours. I remember he was gone for a long time at night and returned only a few hours before dawn. Ayaan said that there was an important client presentation he had to work on, and hence, he needed to go to a cafe down the hill to get WI-FI or work on whatever mobile network he could catch,” I shared.

“Must have been a dampener. Did that piss you off?” Sami asked, his eyes trying to zero in on a motive I may have had leading to his disappearance.

“That did not piss me off,” I smiled and continued. “What pissed me off was when I saw him in the plantation behind our cottage, hand in hand with Rati. I had not met her before, but once I saw her picture on his mobile. I confronted him as soon as he entered the room.”

“And what did he say?” This time, Rati wanted to know the answer. She sat behind me on the *Neelkamal* chair, intently gauging the purpose of my presence in her life.

I did not feel like hiding anything from her. She was not the psycho. She was not the creep. It was possible that we both were pawns.

“He said that when you learned he was in Dzongu, you created a scene and flew down to Gangtok to be with him. And that he was pacifying you. And that he was helpless.” I said this in one breath, finding it difficult to share all his lies.

Vipin gave me a glass of water. I continued to look at Rati while gulping down the water. One, two, three. I wiped my face clean, sighing before I carried on.

“So, I gave him an ultimatum. To break up with you, now or never. I asked him to decide at any cost, or I would break up with him. I pushed him out of the room and said he could return only when he had finished things with you.” I did not realise that my eyes had watered and my vision had gotten blurry.

Rati kept her hands on mine. Vipin gave me his handkerchief, which smelled musky, and I gave it back to him after a quick wipe.

“He never came, and I assumed he had chosen you. I checked out the next day, but I saw you panicking at the reception as I was checking out. I was so exasperated that I left town. I never would have guessed that he was missing,” I explained.

“You know what this means, ladies, I hope?” Vipin asked.

“What?” We both asked in unison.

“He is not missing. He has run away. Probably, he has gone incognito and may resurface in a couple of days or weeks.” Sami answered Vipin’s question.

I looked at Rati, and she looked back at me.

At that moment, that seemed the only logical conclusion.

Mr Fernandez Vipin

The ladies were escorted back to Shine Resort, as I was unsure if staying elsewhere would be a good idea. I had sent two constables to guard their cottages, and they had shifted to cottages adjacent to each other. Their situation seemed amicable now—betrayal by the same man had brought a weird geniality between them during this trying time.

My shift timing was over, but the rosters were invalid now. The other sub-inspector on the different shifts had conveniently fallen sick. Sami, Dipen, and I were working round the clock, as it was after a long time that the Dzongu police station was seeing some action. It did not match our crime rate record, but getting the men at the station out of their hibernation was good. Finally, they were getting to do what they were supposed to do—solve crimes and maintain law and order.

The newly infused energy made me ask Sami to accompany me to Gangtok. I asked Dipen to head to the resort. Just in case the runaway lover decided to come back and meet any of his princesses.

Once Sami and I reached the NH310 for the three-hour ride, we stopped at the snack bar to grab something.

“What do you think is happening, sir?” Sami asked me earnestly.

“Ayaan ran away, leaving the bickering ladies who have now become friends after being foes for a matter of minutes. Mr Fernandez met with an accident and was then mauled by someone for his valuables,” I said as I ate my bread omelette and sipped on coffee.

“I think it is all interconnected,” said Sami. “A person as smart as Ayaan would not just let his dick do the thinking and run behind two pretty women. There must be some angle. Money, revenge, something,” he wondered out loud as I gobbled my food.

“Whatever be his motive, I think he would have achieved it. The financial angle is a good spin, and we should ask Rati more about it. I don’t know why Shikha is in the picture,” I thought out loud.

“Exactly – imagine if you were two-timing, sir.” I raised my eyebrows as Sami sent me to my fantasies.

“Just imagine, sir – if you were Ayaan. Why would you bring both your girlfriends to one city and one resort, for that matter? He purposely asked both to book Shine Resort. Why would he want to be a ghost to most of the staff? Until he was seen with Shikha and not with Rati, he planned to make anyone investigating this later feel that he never was in Dzongu with Rati.” Sami’s grey cells were working hard, and everything he said seemed logical.

I kept thinking of what the motive for him could be to be seen only with Shikha and not with Rati during this time. The only information we had was that he was trying to prove to the world that Rati had mental issues.

Sami pressed the accelerator of the jeep, as we had requested the forensic lab at Gangtok to keep open today. We needed Mr Fernandez’s autopsy report to be completed to gather more leads. Jimmy had gathered a few pieces of evidence and was already at the lab to analyse them.

The stars shimmered in the sky, and no vehicles were on the road. The crescent-shaped moon illuminated the road along with the lights from the jeep. If the jeep were turned off, there would only be an eerie silence around us, making one wonder if it was the calm before the storm.

I asked Sami if he was comfortable with me dozing off for a while, and he guffawed. I closed my eyes, nonetheless. It was going to be a long night.

— —

“He was killed over 36 hours ago. In all probability, during the nighttime. I cannot verify if he had an accident, but I am sure the accident did not kill him. A human did.” Dr Rai, the HOD of the forensics department at Sikkim Institute of Medical Sciences, and his two assistants had completed their investigation. They shared their results with us in the examination room.

A lifeless Mr Fernandez lay in front of us. He was cleaned, and there was horror on his face, or whatever remained of it; the killer had targeted the right side of the skull.

“He fell on his upper body first. We were able to conclude that. Whether someone pushed him or this was an accident, I wouldn’t know. If he had jumped, his lower body would have touched the ground first, but this part is unharmed. Bruised because of the body roll, but nothing else.” Dr

Rai continued. "There is a time difference between him rolling down and being hit on the head. He was probably hit on the head four to five times with a piece of wood or bark. That means the killer did not anticipate killing Mr Fernandez with their own hands. He was probably found breathing, and the killer got upset that he was not dead and killed him with tree bark. Mr Fernandez was too weak to defend himself and gave in almost immediately."

"So only two options remain. First, he meets with an accident, rolls down the valley, and then a petty thief kills him to make some bucks. Second, someone pushed him, and he rolled down the valley. The killer walked down the alley to check if Mr Fernandez was dead, and when he was not, he was killed with a bark. Correct?" Sami asked, and I nodded.

"Plausible, I think." Mr Rai concurred, and his assistants nodded, too.

"Jimmy is in the next room with evidence. We may have to track the footsteps. The killer would have left some traces behind. The skull mauling was unplanned, so I doubt the killer wore gloves. If we could trace the murder weapon, we may be able to find traces of the killer's skin on it. Call the K-9s, or the bloodhounds, whoever is available. We will need to trace the footsteps. Those footsteps may be lost due to a lot of movement between where the body lay in the valley and the road. But the killer may have taken an alternate route out of panic. Let's count on that." I was still hopeful.

Sami went out to make calls, and I thanked Dr Rai and his team. I moved on to the adjacent department room, where Jimmy was waiting for me. He had a childish grin on his face.

"What are you so happy about?" I asked him, and he said he had almost solved the case.

This is the thing with Jimmy. He would try to do his work quickly, like an overly enthusiastic student, and then share his preliminary results with me like a running commentary. He would do this only to be embarrassed when he would point out that there were several angles he did not explore.

"I know you must be thinking that I have come to you like a toddler rushing to show his parent his amateur painting, but this time, I assure you that I have narrowed down many aspects of the case, even to some suspects you may consider interviewing."

I liked his confidence. "I am all ears," I said.

“It wasn’t a robbery.” He was running out of breath, and I smiled, asking him to calm down before continuing. “We found his wallet full of cash a few hundred feet away from the point where the body was found. Mr Fernandez’s bike did not skid; otherwise, there would have been marks on the road. He had stopped there, apparently to take a call, as we even found his mobile with its screen broken. The call came in late at night, and after that, there were no calls, and the mobile was switched off and thrown, implying that the killer was in a rush. The wallet was found in the same direction, too.”

Jimmy continued, “We found blood spattered across. I asked the lab to test various samples of the blood we got. One sample was interesting, as it was away from the body, and it seemed some struggle happened there. Now, wait for this. The blood found near Mr Fernandez’s body is his own, but the one found away from his body, which also seemed fresh, is not his.” His eyes gleamed, and I knew he was onto something. “That means, apart from Mr Fernandez, another person witnessed the whole thing.”

“... Or it could be the blood of the killer itself. We will need to track the mobile towers of those in the vicinity when Mr Fernandez was there. Who was the last person he spoke to? K-9 will do the rest of the work.” I concluded.

“Already on it, sir. I didn’t even have to search, as his mobile threw up all the information we wanted when it connected to my laptop. He last spoke to Shyam. I also confirmed this from the mobile network company. Shyam was in the same area for at least two-three hours, two nights back.” He sighed, signalling that was all he had to share.

I took a moment to absorb the information. It was all going too much, too fast. I wish I had a peg to gulp. A deep breath marked the beginning of my next steps.

“Let us bring in Shyam for questioning,” I looked at Sami, who was back in the room. “The boy is slimy. Somehow, I cannot seem to trust him. He may be going through late puberty, but something about his eyes makes me feel that there is more to him than what meets the eye.

Sami nodded. Dr Rai also walked in.

“You should search for that tree bark too. I doubt someone that unprepared could have taken it that far. He may have dumped it somewhere nearby.” Dr Rai said.

“Unless he has burnt it or dug it in the forest nearby,” I spoke like a true detective, and everyone in the room laughed.

As the unit left with me back to Dzongu, I kept wondering who had the blood of Mr Fernandez on his hands. And who was the person who also shed blood along with Mr Fernandez at the murder site?

The moon peeped in through the dark flora and hung up in an even darker night sky, forming patterns on my face, matching the vehicle’s speed. My eyelids shut, this time taking me to deep slumber.

Day 3

Police Shyam

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

The song she sang while preparing momo filled my heart. It was my happy place. Every morning, when Uncle was not around, she would kiss me on my forehead. I would squeeze my eyes, asking her to pamper me even when he was around, but she would look wistful.

“Later,” is what she used to say while singing the lullaby I had grown up hearing. *Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.*

I would whine, and she would laugh.

I would sit with him, all six feet of ugly patriarchy who would be constantly ordering her to get more momo. I heard him complaining about the tea and advising me to be very careful when I choose a wife. Asshole, he did not deserve her. He hated that I was a ‘burden’ to their finances, but he never understood that a woman’s maternal instincts are not restricted to blood. The woman who practically raised me like a mother, Ms Fernandez, was everything to me.

Even though Ms Fernandez, or *Ammu* as I called her, was 25 years older, she was like my best friend. She taught me to love and be compassionate. She taught me to be ambitious and chase my dreams—dreams that she could never chase because she was impeded by an egotist whom she called her husband.

She never asked me to be a party to her plans. But I was not only obliged to her for all she had done for me; I loved her and would have done anything for my mother to lead her life the way she wanted.

If I could have it my way, I would not have let him touch her again. But she asked me to wait as things fell into place. “Right time,” is all she would say. So, I waited.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

There was no investigation room. I fancied being in one. After the boring life I led, it would have given me a chance to be in the spotlight. But then, I would have to be interrogated at this dingy police station by this bored older man, who I am sure was a twin soul of Mr Fernandez, my ungrateful uncle.

“So, what were you doing next to Mr Fernandez’s dead body?” Sami (the name mentioned on his name tag) was sitting with me in the wee hours of the early morning.

My daily ritual of thinking about the hot guests at the resort concluded at 11 p.m. last night. I had completed my REM Cycle. They had pulled me out of bed at 3 a.m. When I asked them what they were taking me to the police station for, ‘routine questioning’ was all they said.

“You were the guys who called me to identify the body, didn’t you?” I replied, annoyed at the clueless officer wasting my time with trivial questions.

A fly kept bothering me and eventually rested on Sami’s face. I wished I could thwart it by giving Sami a tight slap, and my lack of sleep overtook my equanimity. It flew before I could do so, buzzing away to someplace where it could be heard but not seen. Like the truth — everyone knew about it, but no one was ready to admit it.

The tinnitus returned to my sore ear, and I put a finger inside it, shaking it vigorously to make sense of the words spouting from the ASI’s mouth.

“...not that time, you know, when I am talking about,” I heard him concluding.

I scoffed—at the investigator’s emotional immaturity, the method of questioning, the loopholes in the system, and the ride I was about to take this gentleman on.

“That was the only time I was there,” I replied.

“You know that is not true. You were there before. Your footprints from the same shoes you are wearing now were found a few feet away from the body.” He was desperate to give out the information.

I laughed. The old man was shooting in the dark. He had no solid evidence. He should have retired and watched breaking news on television instead.

“I wish you had a smarter team who had better observational skills. I roamed around the body while *Ammu* was crying. I was disturbed beyond

control and wandered away because I thought the killer would be hiding in some bush witnessing the hullabaloo. That is why you have my footprints,” I clarified with a hint of condescension, getting comfortable in the chair. It creaked as my legs rose, and the smile did not leave my face.

“How did you know Mr Fernandez was killed?” Sami asked.

The colour left my face, and I searched for words. “From the way his face was badgered, but other body parts were seemingly unhurt, I guessed someone had done that deliberately. Also, I wouldn’t be pulled out at 3 am from my bed if it were an accident.” My face remained as impassive as possible.

Surprisingly, he bought it. He knew I was lying but could not catch me on that point. He would have to try harder.

“Great. Considering your proximity to Mr Fernandez and the presence of your footprints near the dead body, we wanted to clear your name from the list of suspects. Can you tell me where you were three nights before, possibly late at night,” Sami asked me, coming finally to the point.

“What time?”

“Why don’t you take me through how and where you spent that entire night? Starting at 6 pm?” Sami was fishing in the dark. Tch tch.

What a mockery of the whole system. I felt like these nincompoops would do better selling vegetables on the roadside.

I sighed and thought of reciting my well-rehearsed script. The one that omitted my conversation with uncle. The one where I pushed him down the valley. The one where he opened his eyes, asking me to save him.

I remembered how I searched for the bark in frustration. I remembered how I badgered his head. One, two, three, four, five, and six. His eyes remained open, and he died of guilt, fear, and the wound, in that order. Sami did not need to know that. Instead, these words just rolled out of my mouth.

“My *Ammu*, Ms Fernandez, needed help back at the resort as my uncle was not around. I returned home from the resort. On the way back, I lost my mobile. I am unsure if someone stole it from my pocket or if it fell. I had stopped at a place or two for household chores; I am trying to remember it all. The next morning, I went to the mobile operator outlet and got a new sim for my spare mobile.” I remained as calm as the sea. My poise disrupted his line of questioning, and inwardly, I derided his unease. He knew I was lying but couldn’t find the loophole in my otherwise perfect narrative.

“Did you file an FIR to claim the sim? I believe all mobile operators ask for one.” This was the lame comeback he could muster after keeping quiet for at least 30 seconds, which felt like an eternity to me.

“I did not, given I wasn’t sure if I had lost the mobile or someone had stolen it. I do not like innocent people getting punished for things they haven’t done.” I tried to be sarcastic so that Sami would realise he was troubling me.

Sami kept shifting in his seat, struggling to come up with his next approach for that interrogation. He scratched his head, then his chest, putting his palm completely inside his armpit, itching in anxiety, as I somehow subdued my grin.

He then banged the table, finally bringing an end to the pointless life of that fly. On that, he had my concurrence. I nodded my head to show him my support. He looked at me, still figuring out his next statement.

“It’s just a matter of time before we find the murder weapon. I will not remain so nice then. If there is anything that you want to tell me, do it now. Otherwise, you will be behind those iron bars if we meet again the next time and if I have proof against you.” His tone changed to contempt mixed with aggression, and his attempt to threaten me would have worked well had I been weak-hearted.

“Sure, and what happens when you keep pulling innocent civilians out of bed based on your hunch? Can they go somewhere and complain, too? My beloved uncle has been dead for the last few days. *Ammu* is distraught, and instead of finding the killer, you are busy interrogating the family members. What a misuse of power! Also, what heights of incompetency!” I raised my voice to counter his insinuation.

Sami babbled, and another ASI, Dipen, came in. He must have heard the argument and come forward to support his incompetent colleague. He looked at me angrily and then stared into my eyes, reciting every word as slowly as possible. “A human being has been murdered. He was your uncle. If you cooperate, we will find the killer soon. If you do not, we know of multiple ways to make you. After all, in the end, we only want the killer to get punished. So, if we are working on this round the clock, we want your cooperation round the clock. Is that understood?”

I knew he was serious, and a chill ran down my spine. I nodded my head. His gaze fixated on me as I slowly walked out of the police station. I wished I’d never have to face Dipen if I got caught.

The chances of that happening were low. I had burnt the murder weapon on a bonfire around which a drunk tourist camp slept to protect themselves from the cold. It wasn't my uncle that I was worried about. I had planned that murder for months.

It was the other guy I had stumbled upon three nights before; that was the one I was worried about and had to take care of—the one called Ayaan, the one who was with that chick, Rati. I started taking deep breaths to calm my nerves.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

Shikha

Rati

Shikha had come to my cottage late after midnight, sleep eluding her eyes. We stood on the balcony, finding reasons to talk. While the ice was broken – thanks to our encounter at the police station – our acquaintance was lukewarm at best. One never knows how dirty another's linens were.

She had ordered a bottle of wine, and we sipped it slowly, staring at the stars and admiring the beauty of Dzongu and the Himalayas. Even though it was dark, the valley glowed, thanks to the perpetually snow-covered peaks. Moonlight spread its calmness, and the mellifluous breeze did its magic. It was chilly, but we needed to find warmth in each other's pain by giving it an outlet.

"I just want him to be found and be done with it." I broke the silence. "I don't know why he cheated on me, and I wonder why he has not contacted you."

"One thing that you and I can be sure of is that he was an incorrigible liar. He lied to me, and you and I would not be surprised if he changed his identity and moved to another city. He was vague about his past, which I think was for a reason," Shikha said.

"We get that he was cheating for reasons best known to him. But why would he bring both of us to the same place? What could be the motive there? I am sure he did not plan for both his girlfriends to be sipping wine on a starry balcony!" Shikha smiled faintly as she heard this and nodded.

"Do you think he had another girlfriend apart from us?" she asked, and we both smiled in unison. We were both smiling at ourselves for being so naive and stupid. Shikha continued to wonder and ask questions.

"Did he steal any money, any valuables from you? Knowing him now, I doubt he was two-timing just for fun," she said.

"No. But he insisted I get term life insurance, and I signed the papers before we came to Dzongu. We were planning to get pregnant, and he kept saying that while he was okay with us not getting married, he wanted to

secure our child's future financially. He had a similar policy," I shared, appreciating Shikha's point.

"He told me all these stories of leaving you because you had mental health issues...." Shikha shared, her voice heavy. She continued, "In any case, did he insist on insurance out of concern or some other motive?"

"It's difficult to say now. I want to say that he did it out of concern, but a person planning kids with his girlfriend will not be two-timing. I guess there was a motive. He probably planned to kill me sooner than later." I shuddered at that thought, and Shikha's hand pressed mine for comfort.

"And maybe he planned to do that here, in Dzongu. Think about it; that is why he never wanted to be seen with you. He planned to do that here, somehow, and then use me as a backup if anybody questioned him. His presence in Dzongu was quintessential for this plan to come through, and I was just a pawn in the whole scheme of things. What do they call it... Oh yes! I was an alibi." Shikha came up with a perfectly laid-out hypothesis. It seemed the only logical explanation for an otherwise convoluted turn of events.

I had a sudden urge to find Ayaan and butcher him. Kill them before they kill you, as they say. But where was he?

As I looked down the valley, *déjà vu* hit me: similar night, similar view. I wasn't sure if I had imagined it, but I saw Ayaan running into the woods as I followed him. It felt real, as if it had happened.

Shikha called out my name to bring me back to reality -- but somewhere, I felt that the hallucination was real.

All of it — the pursuit, the witness, the face-off, and all my nightmares, had a story to tell me. I wondered what it was.

K-9

Vipin

The police station and its team had been devoid of challenges for the last decade. The last episode that caused some ripples was the suicide of Mr Shaolin, who left the world as his wife left him since he could not leave alcohol. He had committed suicide by shooting himself with a gun, and the staff had a tough time finding out how and where he procured a weapon, and if he left a suicide note and all the paraphernalia. Later, it turned out that the recluse had committed suicide, and there was no trace of anyone else being involved, and the station had gone back to its coma.

Everyone gets rusty with time, but the real investigators never stay silent. They need a chance; even a tiny event could bring them back into action. A simple drug peddler, once caught, could make them feel they are about to bust an international drug racket, and a missing dog could make them think they are about to crack an animal trafficking racket. I had underestimated the brilliance and agility of my staff members, who were observing, waiting for that perfect opportunity to rise and shine.

The involvement of the K-9 team from Gangtok and Kolkata brought life into the silent hills of Dzongu. A day had passed since we discovered Mr Fernandez's body and met the Forensics team, and late in the night, the K-9 team was ready for action. Surprisingly, Dzongu had risen. Overnight, the roadside vendors appeared to serve the hundred-plus men in uniform and the two hundred other insomniacs fond of neighbourhood adventures. The smell of tea, cigarette smoke, and battered eggs filled the air and mixed with the buzz of the anticipating crowd.

I followed the team to the point where the dead body was found. The canines from the K-9 were breathing hard, eager to start their job. Each pack had picked up multiple scents, and I asked my team to divide and go ahead with each pack to follow the trail. Numerous trails were going inside the forest, which could be handy if the multiple robbers' theory were true.

Or if there were innumerable killers involved in this murder. Or if there were numerous witnesses to this gruesome act.

Dipen, Sami, and I nodded at each other as we entered the forest from different directions.

Day 4

3 am
Vipin

Nights could be creepy. Especially around the Devil's Hour, when all the supernatural powers feel their potential is at the pinnacle. You could light the forests with headlights from the jeeps, multiple battery-powered spotlights, or tiny torches, but the shadows still speak to each other. One could imagine the unholy souls of the aggrieved jumping between the shadows, murmuring the sins they committed when they had a human body and the evils they will commit when they take over a human next. You could hear the whispers and act unruffled, but your pounding heart and sweaty forehead would tell a different story. One had to remind themselves that there was no bigger evil than humans, and the afterlife staring at a human right now may be afraid of that human, too.

The canines with me were relatively subdued. They were the ones who would peacefully do their job and go back to their abode. No fuss, no crying, no rejoicing over small treats. Just 'do-your-work' types. The ones who did not need a master's degree. The ones who were not bothered by a supernatural presence. Just follow the smell, and in this case, as I would like to think, the scent of the witness. The scent felt familiar, like I was behind someone I did not want to discover.

It was bright, and we did not need torches, courtesy of the deciduous trees. I felt nauseous, cursing the last 48 hours for my deplorable health. I thought I could drop any time, but the canines kept me going. One of them looked at me as if it judged me, eventually motivating me to go on — Do your job and then go home? Its looks said it all, and I pushed my legs forward on the soft trek.

The sound of a nearby stream calmed me as the dogs took me toward it. As soon as my heartbeat returned to normal, our soft trek continuing on a downward slope, my thoughts moved towards the constant ache in my heart — Rati. I felt my heartbeat rising again as I thought of her being in my arms while I brushed away the hair strands that fell on her glowing cheeks. I

wondered how the touch of her lips would make me feel and how the brush of my stubble would titillate her. I wondered how soft her waist would feel when I pressed it against my thighs and how tears would fall from her eyes as I made her climax.

The crackling of the walkie-talkie brought me out of my reverie. I was connected to Sami and Dipen, and their fragmented updates kept me grounded in the present. There was a sense of being everywhere at once, as if their voice carried not merely information but also their emotions, creating a shared consciousness of the chase.

Sami's voice came through, low and tense, breaking the silence like a distance echo in a hollow room.

"Moving further in," he said. "Dogs are pulling hard."

I didn't need to see him to pick up on the hint of frustration in his tone. Uncertainty freaked Sami out, and I knew he wished hard for Shyam to be the killer. There had been very few convicts in Dzongu that 'Smart Sami,' as he was known, could not crack, and he was still unable to digest that he was outsmarted. I also sensed a hesitation in his voice, the kind I had heard before – as if he were questioning his own abilities. Dzongu never presented him with challenges, and he was only fit for solving novice drug peddler cases.

I steadied my voice and pressed the button on my walkie-talkie. "Keep up with the dogs, Sami. You'll find something."

A moment of quiet passed before I heard a snake slithering between the dead leaves and the moonlight, trying its best to warn Sami of the croaking frogs. Or the crickets. Or the spirits, in that order. Then Sami's response came, abrupt and clumsy. "Yeah."

I pictured him pushing through the underbush, his jaw tight with resolve as the dogs yanked at their leashes. The winds told him to bow to Mother Nature as the moon gazed at the investigators' trail. The troupe was infused with the hope of discovering a clue that might illuminate the otherwise grim case.

After a soft trek of about twenty minutes, Sami's team came to a halt as the canines' ears perked up. They faced a dark forest that grew denser, with some low-lying bushes forming a circle. Over the walkie-talkie, I heard Sami and the other folks in uniform bracing themselves for whatever was behind those bushes. The canines began whimpering, their barks restrained in anticipation of the command to charge forward.

“Sami here. We might be on to something. Advancing cautiously.” Sami reported.

He commanded the two other police officers to go around, trying to encircle the formation. If there were convicts behind, they better not escape. I pictured his hand tightening on his revolver, and he shouted to announce his presence, urging any miscreants to come out of the bushes. There was no movement. The canines continued to act cautious, insinuating that some sinister energy had followed them, leaving Sami with only one option: To step forward and discover what lay ahead.

He did, and the whimpers turned to low growls, rising high in volume, till they reached a cacophony of restless barks filling the entire valley. The echoes reverberated across the mountains, failing to be absorbed by the forest, and the ground shook. Sami must have known that even his colleagues a distance away would have understood that he and his group had stumbled upon something.

I gripped the device tightly as Sami described the scene: a formation cleared into a circular shape of levelled grass almost 50 feet wide in radius, littered with trash – an empty Lay’s packet and a discarded beer bottle that he inadvertently kicked. He spoke about the remnants of a bonfire at the centre – a bunch of sticks scattered on the ground, amidst which one stood out. It looked like a tree’s bark and stood out. As per Sami’s account, some parts of the bark were unburnt and remained green.

“This doesn’t belong in a fire.” His voice was grave as he examined the piece keenly.

Before I had the chance to put two and two together, Sami declared, “We have the murder weapon.” His voice was heavy with the weight of discovery.

— —

I felt relieved that there was progress, and I felt glad that Sami was the one who had made it. He needed this.

The sudden barks from the pack were an aberration in an otherwise bland adventure so far my trail was on, and the master of one of the canines jolted me back to reality. I apologised for my distraction and accepted the call to return to my duties.

The reality was depressing as I found myself in front of a stream, the rocks beside the bank glistening from the water and bright moonlight. The trail ended up before the stream, and the canines would turn catatonic if pushed any further.

The witness, the killer, or whoever the dogs were tracking would now be lost in oblivion.

I was disappointed, and I asked my team to turn around and return to the base. Before I could sigh at the wasted effort of my trail, I heard my walkie-talkie return to life. It was Dipen.

— —

Dipen had faith that he would crack the case. His voice came through the walkie-talkie, breathless and uneven, not because his young organs were giving up on the treacherous trek, but probably because he hoped he would be the panacea to soothe our fix. The canines moved fast, making Dipen and his companion scamper. At one point, he reported that the dogs had halted. They must have realised that the scent was now diverging in multiple directions.

“They seem confused,” he said, his voice raspy. “It’s like whoever came this way might have walked here more than once.”

He chose the straightforward path, as the wet leaves looked like someone had recently trampled them. From the crunch of their hurried steps, I could tell that the canines followed the trail, validating Dipen’s guess. Dipen mentioned that his torch’s battery was slowly giving up, but the moonlight was just enough to guide their steps.

Not long after, the canines began barking furiously. The static on the device carried their agitation, and Dipen’s voice returned, this time quieter. “It looks like they are losing the trail. Too many scents.” I suggested that he keep moving and pictured him steadying himself, a quiet determination evident in his expressions.

The crickets chirped, and the owl hooted as Dipen and his entourage made their way through the temporary path amongst the trees. He conveyed his frustration over the lack of proper lighting, and I heard him mutter something about how he was missing vital clues and would have to return in the morning to retrace the trail.

The incline steepened, and their breaths grew heavier as the trees stood tall around them. The wild grasses became level with the ground. Dipen informed me they had reached a clearing, and that the men in uniform took out their mobiles to use them as flashlights, realising they were on a trail that the canines were sceptical about following. A triumphant exclamation followed the sound of rummaging as one of the men found spare batteries in his back.

Two torchlights went on, and then the static crackled with muffled voices. I heard a few deliberate steps, after which Dipen's voice came back, shaken. "There's a smell...bad. It's horrid, like something's dead and has begun to decay." I imagined it driving the canines hysterical and the humans nauseous. The dogs were tied to a trunk, barking frantically now as three men stepped forward. I sensed an unmistakable tension in Dipen's voice. "There's an old wooden cabin. Would have probably housed tourists years back." He was surprised, as the Block Forest Officials had shared that there was no human habitation within a two-mile radius from where Mr Fernandez's body was found.

Dipen shouted to fathom if anyone was present inside the cabin, but apart from the heavy breaths of his team members and those of the canines, he could not hear anything. I pictured all the journalists stationed, along with street hawkers and police vans, just near the spot where they had found Mr Fernandez's body.

Dipen stepped into the cottage as the floor creaked, two men following his steps and giving him cover. I heard the sound of his measured breaths, followed by a sharp exhale. "It's worse inside," said Dipen, almost to himself. A moment later, there was a faint thud – he felt something slip by his thick gum boots that would have protected him from even a snake bite.

"I hear them," Dipen muttered, "There are rats all over the place."

"Ignore the rats, Dipen. Just clear the area and report what you see." I told him.

Dipen asked one man to take the torchlight towards the corner where the squeaking noise came from. The next time was a frantic retching, quickly followed by the shuffle of hurried footsteps. Dipen ran out of the cabin to puke.

You could be a man of valour, but when you observe another dead human in disgust, your natural instincts kick in. The other two men remained inside, probably shocked at their discovery.

I had barely deciphered his broken words when the sound cut off, leaving me gripping the device tightly. Dipen was hysterical, and I asked him to take deep breaths before I could understand what he was saying.

When Dipen's voice returned, it was strained. "Dead body...Ayaan," he managed to utter with much difficulty.

I paused for a moment to absorb the words that shook my soul, the news that marks the end of another living life, and the findings of the mystery of the missing man. Then, as if they had a will of their own, my legs picked up pace.

Found Vipin

The ghouls laughed at me as I ran through the valley. My soul tried hard to keep up with my body as I bobbed across the bushes, my foot missing the ground multiple times. The canines were left far behind as the walkie-talkie guided me toward Dipen.

Dawn had broken the stubborn night, bringing a tinge of orange to the sky, and the snow-capped mountains seemed ready to welcome the first rays of the sun. The moon acted innocent, stating it had nothing to do with gleaming the valley the night before, and acted laidback somewhere between the transitions. The valley let light seep in through the thick trees as the sound of the search party grew louder and caught the attention of the growing multitude of onlookers.

A hundred feet from Dipen's whereabouts, I saw the cabin, which now housed one of the biggest secrets Dzongu had ever seen or may ever see. The wind rustled through the leaves, which swayed to keep up with the sinister ambience. I thought that if there were life on Earth, it would not find its way into that hell.

Sami and a few other team members had already arrived, and I locked my eyes with Dipen as he stood at the door, waiting for my arrival. His eyes conveyed the horror he had seen, and he rushed outside the cabin to puke his last meal out on the dead leaves again.

I entered the cabin, hesitant to move forward. The stench was stronger than the cheap perfume-filled handkerchief I had covered my nose with, and I was wrong about life being absent at that nook of the valley. The cabin housed many vermin, rodents, and possibly reptiles, but the buzzing flies took me to the subject we had been searching for the last few days.

Ayaan sat with the support of a wall, his eyes open, half-eaten, and it looked like a half-fried egg. His mouth was open, and just as it had made way for his last breath a while back, it had also made way for rats and worms. His skin was just beginning to decompose, which made sense as he

had been lying there for a few days, probably since the same time he went missing. His legs were broken, and I saw a femur jutting out. It must have taken extreme strength and hatred for that to happen. Given the karma he had created for himself, I wasn't surprised. Maybe it was the tip of the iceberg, and more would follow.

I asked very few people to stay inside the cabin. The rest were asked to step outside. So many people inside could destroy the evidence, if any, that was ready to be discovered, like footsteps or the marks left when a body is dragged.

It seemed somebody had dragged Ayaan inside the cabin, and once the sun came out, I was sure we could find more footprints outside the cabin.

Sami looked at me blankly and asked me for the next steps. Dipen was wiping his mouth as he stepped inside. "Let's call the forensic team again and seal the entire area. I am sure we can get a lot from the cabin and outside. Sami, you get this. Dipen, can you please trace how the K-9 team and the dogs came across this scent from Mr Fernandez's murder site? Let's explore the trail again, given it's sufficiently light outside. And third, I will call Jimmy."

Sami asked me what the call to Jimmy would do.

"It's for us to find out who owns the cabin. I don't see a broken lock at the door, and I don't think the owner would keep it unlocked. There is a probability that the person who owns the cabin may be involved," I replied.

Dipen had another question lingering in his eyes. I nodded at him to get him to speak.

"Who will inform Rati?" He asked as I clenched my teeth.

— —

A missing person was a big deal for Dzongu. A dead man would be a big deal for Gangtok. I was expecting the state DGP to get involved when the news would spread that we had a double murder case, probably interlinked.

I sat at my desk, mustering the courage to talk to the DGP. A powerful man once shook hands with me while visiting Dzongu two months ago. He said only thirteen words to me, "Don't screw it up like your last case. I should not hear any complaints." He smiled and moved ahead, making me relive that trauma. His hirsute chest hair peeping out of his top button made me realise he wasn't a local, and I wondered what penance he was

undergoing to clear his karma by being based in Gangtok, out of his home state. Like me.

I played with the pen between my fingers, tapping it against the tabletop as the landline rang for the headquarters. “Mr Sharma’s office. Who is this?” Asked a lady on the other side.

Of course, he had a secretary. I assumed he was a commoner like me and would answer his number. I cleared my throat before answering the secretary, “This is Vipin Nair, the Inspector at Dzongu. I wanted to update Mr Sharma on two recent murders in the town.”

I could sense the turbulence this information caused on the other side, as her “hold on” seemed panicked. Irritating music played in the background as I held on to the receiver, waiting for the Supremo to reprimand me.

“Sir is in a meeting but will call you back in two minutes.” The secretary did her job.

I thanked her and rubbed my palms on my balding head. We had found the murder weapon used to end Mr Fernandez’s uneventful life. We solved the missing case of Ayaan by finding his dead body. But the killers were still on the loose, which was never good news. This update, even though significant, was not going to be sufficient.

A convoy of trucks passed through the highway, shaking up the police station again as I murmured obscenities in the air. Everyone in the station was too busy accomplishing some tasks to solve the double murders, and I couldn’t even complain that there was no tea on my table yet. Just like me, most of them had not had any sleep in the last 30 hours.

My eyes went to the steel almirah in front of me, beneath the smiling Gandhiji’s photo. The almirah had piles of files on top, and the critical case files rested inside. Because of the trucks, it shook longer than anything else in the station, and there was darkness beside it in the corner. The light betrayed that side of the room, and the area felt forbidden.

Something moved in the dark, and I rubbed my alms to avoid hallucinating. Maybe my mind played tricks on me, but the movement became more visible. It took the shape of a slender creature, and I could sense that the air was suddenly putrid, just like it was in the cabin.

The lights in the room went gloomy, and it felt as if the world had come to a halt. I was shocked and sensed I had stopped breathing because of the paranoia. The figure was a sinister formation without a face or an

unmistakable body structure. It approached me and seemed in pain as it whimpered in unearthly tones. The shadow lurched towards me and raised its hand to grab me.

My breath was back, only to make me realise that my lungs were about to burst. I tried to shout but could not, just as I noticed the shadow had red eyes focused only on me.

‘Trin-Trin’! The sound of the landline on my desk brought me out of my reverie, and I looked around. The sounds outside my room were of a busy police station, and the dark corner beside the almirah seemed as obscure as ever. There was no figure, and I sighed out of relief, all sweaty, as I picked up the phone.

“Hello, this is Inspector Vipin from Dzongu police station. How can I help?” I reiterated the script, hiding the apprehension in my voice because of the horror I had experienced a few seconds back.

“DGP Sharma here. What update do you have on the double murder case?” Straight to the point. Even though it had happened less than two hours ago, he was already briefed on it.

“I called to update you on the findings, Sir. I wasn’t aware that you were already aware of them.”

“Oh yes, I even got a call from the media to give a statement. Tell me you have got something useful.” He was in the mood to bicker.

“In the first case, we found the murder weapon, and there is a strong lead we are pursuing. In the second case, the forensics team and the investigators are doing their best; they started a few hours back. The man had been missing for the last three days, and we should have an update by the end of the day.” I tried to display urgency and vulnerability. Men in power have fragile egos.

“I need an update twice every day. You have 48 hours to solve this murder case. I will organise a press conference tomorrow morning, so you better get me something substantial to report. The civilians cannot be made to feel their Inspector is just a trophy. I hope you are not one. Another case gone wrong would send you to a tribal posting.” So, it was a threat meant to nudge me to exceed any expectations he might have of me.

He did not know one thing about Malayalis. We can be friendly employees, but only till the time you respect us.

“Oh, I will happily follow wherever you go, Sir. I followed you to Sikkim and will continue doing so that I can work under your guidance.”

And just like that, I told him he was also serving a punishment posting.

He paused briefly before finally saying, “Let me know if you need help.” He did not slam the receiver as I expected him to, and even showed a hint of respect.

I smiled at my repartee as I kept the receiver down, too. I called for Dipen, Jimmy, and Sami, but the constables who sent out the message returned and told me the three musketeers were not at the station—they were searching for clues.

I had no other option but to think about my plan to let Rati and Shikha know about Ayaan.

The Intruder

Shyam

A puny soul does not have the power to determine my destiny. My uncle was a bigot, so *Ammu's* hatred towards him was justified. He was worthless, but his grandfather had left him property worth crores in and around Gangtok.

When *Ammu* told me about it and how the imbecile was planning to squander it away gambling, I asked her if we could do anything to stop it. She told me the only way out was his death, making her the legal heir to the inheritance.

“Mother and son will open resorts and be super rich. And when the opportune time comes, I will get you married to a deserving bride,” her eyes gleamed as she showed me the dream, and I was determined to make her dream come true. Anything for my mother. Anything for the woman who adopted me when her sister and brother-in-law died in a fatal accident. Anything for the woman who protected me from the wrath of a hateful man.

So, when the time came to pay my dues and get what I deserved from destiny, I did not flinch. How could I? That was the day I had been waiting for an eternity.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

— —

The Lepcha brothers had invited my uncle out for a drinking night, and I overheard them saying he would be back late. I patiently estimated when he would return, as he was a man of routine. He always returned by 1 a.m. to wake *Ammu* for a Temi Tea. That also meant he would cross the valley around 12.30 a.m.

On that day, I was neither angry nor happy. I called him around 12.20 a.m. to tell him my scooter had broken down near hairpin 21 of the valley and that my mobile's battery was about to die. He came dutifully at 12.30

a.m., cursing me for how I was an inconvenience to him ever since I came into his life. I was impassive to his berating and saw around the road on both sides before I pushed him into an abyss. He was drunk, making my task easy, even though I was ready for a scuffle. And just like that, he was gone from *Ammu's* life and mine.

I was almost halfway home before I realised what *Ammu* would ask me when she saw me. "Did you check the pulse on him?"

I screamed in frustration at my callousness and turned my bike around to ensure that the asshole was dead.

The descent to the bottom of the valley was treacherous, but I did not feel fear. I felt tired of all the years of waiting for this man to die and then waiting some more minutes to ensure his pulse was flat. I felt angry about bottling up my emotions, to the point of not even whimpering when he hit me black and blue with his belt, making me bleed. I was frustrated that *Ammu's* holy body was ravaged every once in a while by this abuser. I wished I could have killed him sooner. I wished I could have killed him better.

My legs missed grass and ground every once in a while, and I slipped too many times that night, leaving more marks than I would have liked. I trampled on the shrubs a bit, and I think my shirt tore, the thorns and a small, sharp stone leaving a trail of blood on my back and the ground. Disgusting. And shabby.

I stopped beside him, right beside his filthy body. He may have also slipped the last few meters, as the steep slope from the valley ended a hundred feet ahead of where I had slipped.

I checked if he was breathing but could not feel it. I then checked his pulse and realised that the motherfucker had a faint pulse left. The darkness made it difficult for me to examine him thoroughly, but when I looked carefully, I saw his eyes were open. And he was looking at me.

At first, I thought I was delusional, but realised later that he was observing me, trying to understand why his nephew would go to such great lengths to kill him. I scoffed in derision at his naivety. I was angry at him for being a fool, and I decided to kill him with whatever would come into my hands next.

I hastily searched for a tree bark nearby, dragging it on the ground as I approached him, killing him with the blows. For all the times he had wronged *Ammu* and me. For all the times he thought he was a good human

being when he deserved only misery. I badgered him six times till I heard his skull crack, and I spit on him as he gasped his last breath.

I used his handkerchief to take out his belongings and throw them as far as possible so that tracing him would take longer. I thought of what the line of investigation for the men in uniform could be and subsequently thought of throwing away the murder weapon, the tree bark.

And that was when I sensed someone was behind the trees. I looked around, but there was no one. I went a few steps inside the forest but couldn't spot anyone. I dismissed the thought with the assumption that an animal had passed by, which wasn't uncommon in the lands here.

I started walking away to throw the tree bark and walked for over twenty minutes until I spotted a bonfire amongst some meandering hippies. I waited for one of those stoned people to give me a chance. It came in ten minutes when all the men in the gathering wanted to pee simultaneously, a little away from the bonfire.

I took that opportunity to throw the bark into the bonfire but did not wait for it to become ash, as I did not want to get spotted. I rushed back, the route to the body appearing like a maze. Before climbing back to the main road, I planned to check on his body one last time.

As I got closer, I noticed something in the darkness which petrified me.

The most recent check-in guest, Ayaan, stood near my uncle, horrified. He tried to scream, but panic had gotten the better of him. He was transfixed at that place, drenched in sweat.

I picked up a rock, and he turned back. I rushed to hit him in the head.

News

Rati

Shikha returned to her cottage after a couple of rounds of drinks. I tossed and turned in the bed through the night. It was an awful night, just four nights away from the last time I was with the one I thought was the love of my life.

Ayaan was not found yet, and I longed for closure. After how he ended things, my search to find the answer to ‘why’ would remain, and I wish he could answer that and then die. Shikha’s idea of linking it to my prosperity made sense, but I wanted to validate the truth.

As and when I closed my eyes, I saw him in searing pain; his every scream helped give much-needed respite to my hurt soul. As I opened my eyes in the morning, I wished my dreams would come true and that, somehow, Ayaan would meet a tragic and deserving end. But more than anything, I needed closure. Closure from this wrenching pain that made me want to smear my mascara last night to make my face turn black in shame, filled with the embarrassment of trusting a human again.

I left the bed, quickly showered, and wore new clothes. I realised that just being here and waiting would not make any sense and that, towards the end of the day, I should use the police’s connections to leave this place forever. My bags were already packed and ready to board a plane.

I wanted to move on. If only I could find answers and close this chapter forever. I knocked on Shikha’s door, and she was ready, too.

“Want to have a quick bite and head to the police station? I have packed and can’t wait to leave this shithole. There is no point sitting here and crying for a faux relationship,” she said, and I smiled at how we thought alike.

I wondered if she had similar nightmares as me.

The ride in the taxi was in silence. Now sober, I did not have any topic to discuss with Shikha. Yes, it was true that she was misled about my mental issues, but in the end, she was the person Ayaan cheated on me with. In any other situation, if I had come to know about them cheating or seen them lying in bed, naked, making love to each other, I would not have waited for them to get dressed. I would not have waited for them to share the context with me. I would have pulled the trigger — multiple times. Or I would have strangled her neck until I heard the crack.

I was suddenly urged to do so now, but then I reminded myself I had context. She broke up with Ayaan because she realised, he would want to continue two-timing. She tolerated it for a while as Ayaan told her I was psychotic, but then walked out of the relationship when she thought he had chosen me over her. She had refused to be the other woman, gaining my respect.

My thoughts were brought to a screeching halt as Shikha motioned me to enter the bustling police station. I sighed and entered the poor structure, and I wish it had crumbled under the weight of people's and the department's expectations and the curses of every complainant who filed a case but never got justice.

All eyes were on me as I sauntered inside; some looks expressed sympathy, some concern. Some eyes cried, and some reassured that good times would follow. I was a known face in the Dzongu police station, and everyone looked at me as if they had the answer and now wanted me to know it, too.

"I guess they know the answers to our questions," I said, looking at Shikha and clasping her hand.

She did the same, too, and we entered Vipin's cabin together. "I guess it's time for us to know them too," she said as we pushed the wooden half doors aside.

Vipin looked at us, his eyes communicating everything we wanted to know. He smiled, a smile full of sympathy, care, pity, and acknowledgement of one's nonexistence.

News

Shikha

I did not feel anything anymore.

I felt I was a bad actor in this poorly inspired play. I had to be physically present to get my pay, but then my soul was elsewhere. Somewhere, in the lap of my protective parents, in the warmth of the home where I was still to discover the reality of life. On my sofa, watching the TV, answering questions about my mom's dire need to force me to eat fruits. But then, there I was, in this police station, wondering if my ex was alive and why he was cheating and why men are such assholes.

Inspector Vipin looked at us as if he were searching for the right words to come out of his mouth. He looked like someone who hated this part of his job, where he had to share the news. I noticed Rati, and she looked at me, and we both wondered the same thing. We both guessed he had an update about Ayaan, which did not seem pleasant.

"This morning, while tracing the path of the possible killer of Mr Fernandez, we found two things," he paused for effect, observed us, and continued. "First, we found the murder weapon," he looked at us again but quickly understood that this news had no significance in our lives. He cleared his throat and said the second news, saving the worst for the last.

"Secondly, we found Ayaan's dead body. His body was badly decomposed and disfigured because of the location it was found in. The forensics team in Gangtok had taken it for post-mortem, and I will request both of you to confirm that it is him, and you can go along with Sami to Gangtok to get this and more details about his time of death." He shared in a rushed tone, trying to get done with the uncomfortable part as soon as possible.

He pushed his chair back, signalling his job was done.

Rati let out a deep sigh. I could sense the tears in her eyes, the silent crying of her deep wounds. I took the chair. The news was anticipated and accepted— we each had our own reaction.

“How did he die?” Rati asked him after a while, her eyes transfixed on the floor, her voice broke, and her breathing shortened.

“We are trying to determine if his murder was a planned crime or an unplanned one. I am sorry to share this, but he had a tragic end. Whoever did this is a psychotic person and probably a danger to society.” He said, expressing his disapproval of the beast unleashed outside.

I had no pain in my heart left to feel for Ayaan. He was dead, and that was an answer to most of my questions. I did not care how it happened and who did it. I did not care about why too – I knew it was because of his karma.

I looked at Rati, who stared at a fly circling a broken cookie. She observed it for some time and then abruptly grunted before squashing it with her sneakers. Given what was going on, it was an odd move.

I understood her, though. She was in a long and serious relationship with Ayaan, and I knew what she wished for then. She believed it was an apt end for the monstrous soul. I thought the same.

Somehow, a tear trickled down my cheeks, and I felt embarrassed and sad. Was I sorry that Ayaan was no more? Was I sad because I could never tell Ayaan how his lies were caught? Or was I sad because I was harrowed by a false relationship and felt helpless to recover from it? Rati was overwhelmed, too, water breaking free from her eyes without any sound coming from her pharynx.

One of the station’s staff rushed inside, talking in hushed tones with Vipin, who seemed exhilarated by the information shared with him. At least, the shouts of joy told us as much as Rati and I were leaving the station.

We both looked relieved, as we wondered if this was what escape looked like—escape from a con artist whose tactics had finally brought him to a deserving tragic end.

Sami rushed us to Gangtok silently; we were back on an arduous journey. This time, we were not seeking any answers. We were already looking forward to our lives that had changed forever.

Him Rati

As the white sheet came off the body in the mortuary, I had a flinching pain in my heart. It wasn't that I wished Ayaan was not dead. He deserved this, but his condition made me feel sad for him. And at that moment, as a human, I wished no one deserved that end.

My mind told me his end was apt, but my heart felt that a person who had been with me for all those years, for whatever motive, would not be easily forgotten. The memories would remain, even if they caused me pain.

However, you'd learn to live with the memories, as that was what people meant when they said they had 'moved on.' However nonchalant you'd want to act or pretend, there would be a few of these old moments that your soul would crave. You'd wish to live with them again. You'd want to be loved again, even though it was a lie. You'd want to be touched again, even though it would be only for a moment. You'd want to be hurt again if that would mean he could come close to you for one last time.

Tears went down my otherwise dry eyes, and Shikha noticed me. She came close to me, holding my hands. I excused myself, getting embarrassed as people had seen my vulnerability, and I rushed out of the morgue, out of the facility, away from that smell. Away from the people who saw me crying, away from Ayaan, who hurt me deeply once again with his death.

A truck was passing by, and I felt like going ahead and jumping in front of it. Something stopped me, and I wondered what the point of my living was, just to repeat the cycle – of loving and losing. As the truck came close, it blared the horn loudly, and I screamed too in cohesion. The scream lasted long after the horn had ended and the truck had vanished into the horizon.

Vipin had asked us not to leave Dzongu till Ayaan's case was solved. Everyone was a suspect. The investigation would take a whole new turn, and all our statements will be recorded again, they said.

"Are you okay?" Shikha asked me as we sat in the police jeep to go back to Dzongu.

"I am fine, thank you. Seeing him brought a lot of emotions, and I felt helpless with all those eyes watching me. Sorry I ran out like that," I said, admitting my feelings this time.

Sami was in an animated conversation with Dr Rai, the head of the Forensics department, and seemed content while he made some calls back to the police station to Dzongu. Shikha and I patiently waited for him to join us in the jeep, and we returned to our conversation.

"Do you have nightmares too?" I asked her, hoping we had more similarities apart from being Ayaan's lovers.

"Yes, but they are all about me being in an accident, or drowning, or being jailed, those kinds of things, you know." She looked at me, sad that she knew she was falling short of my expectations.

I smiled. Ayaan had probably told her more about me, and she was aware my nightmares were ghastly. "I had to undergo therapy earlier because they wouldn't let me sleep. Some nightmares reflected my abandonment during childhood, and some reflected my helplessness when I am under attack." I felt the need to continue. "After Ayaan came into my life, these nightmares reduced to the point that they stopped coming altogether. My therapist told me it was because I felt secure, finally in a serious, stable, and loving relationship." I scoffed at the irony.

Shikha held my hand, comforting me with her warm touch.

"For the past few days, I have been haunted again, feeling like I am running in the valley, being haunted, being gagged by a creature, almost an overpowering beast, as I run and beg for my life. When I saw Ayaan today, it felt like he almost lived my nightmare, and I suddenly felt empathetic. I cursed myself for feeling like a human, and even though he deserves all this, I wish all this had not happened." I felt like crying again, but no more tears were left inside me. My voice went hollow as Shikha patted my hands with her slender fingers.

Sami stepped into the jeep, bringing it back to life with the ignition key. He looked back at us, and we nodded, encouraging him to go ahead and step on the pedal.

“What if I feel this way for the rest of my life?” I asked Shikha.

“Seems like your therapist is not losing you anytime soon,” she casually said; we smirked in unison at the hard truth of that statement.

Murderer Vipin

Jimmy had been the most helpful person on the team, as always. I couldn't help but wonder if this boy was wasting his life in Dzongu. He should have been in the cyber cell or CBI, which could have tapped his true potential.

I wasn't surprised at the information he shared with me, and I wondered why I had not thought of that link earlier, especially since there was a high chance the double murders were connected.

As the ladies, Rati and Shikha, left my cabin, Jimmy, with his skinny, animated hands, narrated how he tracked down the owner of the cabin. The property belonged to one Mr Sherpa, who had long gone. Jimmy went to the local office to find out if the same Mr Sherpa owned any other properties and realised he owned Shine Resort before Mr Fernandez bought it from him a couple of years back.

That rang a bell, and Jimmy asked locals near the cabin alongside the highway if they knew anything about it. The locals shared that Mr Fernandez and Mr Sherpa were dear friends, and when the latter passed away, Mr Fernandez often used to frequent the cabin with his friends.

So, the existence of the cabin and how to access it was common knowledge for Mr Fernandez and his relatives, the creepy Shyam and his vixen aunt.

I asked Dipen to join me as we rushed out of the station. I fisted my right palm with a similar energy that I displayed the last time on the case that defined my recent years — the time had come to redeem myself. To recover my tarnished image. To let that DGP know that even though I was serving my punishment posting, I would still come out stronger than ever. To show up to everyone who doubted me. Solving a double murder quickly would bring me laurels and take me to a better posting.

I asked Dipen to take me to the cabin again, and with members from Mr Rai's team there still, we were sure to get some more clues before we arrested that bastard Shyam and put him behind bars for good.

The cabin still reeked of decomposition, but this time, I could notice a few broken chairs and a table. In the past, this would have been a great spot to meet some good old friends and drink the night away. Or for the ghostbusters to come here and share exciting stories. Or for witches to discuss new spells and potions. Or simply for lost tourists to rest in a cosy spot.

But today, the cabin looked and felt haunted, a place where a man was left to die or was murdered and left to decay; either way, it housed a dead body for quite some time. The vermin and the pained spirits in the vicinity would remember it. The mountains would not let it go, and the trees would sing the song of the death the valley had witnessed.

Even during the daytime, the place felt spooky, and I stepped outside to speak to one of the senior members of Mr Rai's team as my head stopped spinning.

"Did you find anything?" I asked, desperate to distract my mind from the uneasy feelings.

"Oh, yes! His body was moved from quite some distance, perhaps from the murder site. It was dragged, picked up, dropped, and everything. We found Ayaan's blood samples near where we had found Mr Fernandez's body, and there were marks of dragging and traces of blood on the trail to this place. But that is not all; after the killer tracked him down, probably since he had seen Mr Fernandez being murdered, Ayaan tried to escape later on; we found his footprints near the cabin going in some other direction. Moreover, I can guarantee that there is a high possibility that another person came near the cabin or wandered outside," the official finished, finally taking a deep breath.

"What? Is there more than one killer? Damn!" I facepalmed.

"I cannot be sure, as Ayaan's and the killer's footprints are everywhere. The third person's footprints are inconsistent and could very well be that of a local who came near the cabin a day before or so and got scared. It could also be from our teams, as multiple other footprints were found inside the cabin before we sealed the trail and the cabin."

"But Sir had also got one more trail that ended near the stream," Dipen added to my perplexion.

“That’s true, but in all probability, since there was no definitive trail, we could rule it out as an inquisitive passerby who just happened to pass by in the last few days. Could be one of those stoned tourists as well; as you know, they are in plenty,” the official reassured me.

“Probably we should go ahead and catch the killer first,” Dipen’s eyes gleamed as he continued. “... he could confirm if he had an accomplice.”

I nodded.

— —

We started our jeep to go ahead and bring Shyam in for questioning again. I just hoped that the constables I had stationed near the resort had done a good job of keeping an eye on the property.

We were mid-way when we got the call from an overjoyed Sami.

“Sir, they confirmed it... the murder weapon wasn’t fully burnt, and there was still a lot of unburnt material to help us narrow down the fingerprints.” I could feel Sami jumping into the driving seat. “Who was it?” I asked and got the answer.

I smiled as Dipen leaned closer to hear the name we were sure about. It was good that we had our suspect in the first place. It avoided the hassle of revisiting the whole thing again with a magnifying glass.

“Shyam,” I said as Dipen pushed the pedal to zoom into the night.

So Happy Shyam

I owed my life to *Ammu*. My mother, my caretaker, my angel. When she hinted earlier that she wondered how her life would have been if her husband was not around, I could not restrain myself from helping her fulfil that dream.

They did not have kids; if uncle had wanted, we would have been one happy family. But he did not. He did nothing to be a father figure, an uncle, the man of the house, or even a husband. He was just surviving, between his alcohol, home food, bad company, and gambling boards.

I knew there was a devil inside me waiting to be unleashed. I was the weird kid in the class, the recluse at any birthday party, and the uncomfortable teenager whom everyone avoided. I knew I was different, probably because I received unconditional love only from one person in the world.

When I walloped my uncle, and he plummeted to his death, I did not feel guilty. As I thrashed Ayaan's head when he was lurching around unnecessarily, trying to spoil my plans, I did not feel guilty.

I had not planned on managing an intruder's presence, so I was perturbed by it. I had not even prepared to come down the valley and check whether my uncle was alive. I never expected that his eyes would ask me to spare him. That Ayaan's eyes would ask for forgiveness, too, just before the sharp stone met his head.

I wondered if I could drop him down another valley, but we had come a little further away from the next ravine. I thought of repeatedly badgering his head with the same stone, but I had not discussed killing him with *Ammu*. I wasn't sure what he was doing there, so keeping him alive would be best. Somewhere, hidden away from habitation, where his cries could not be heard.

Mr Sherpa's cabin immediately came to my mind.

I dragged an unconscious Ayaan for some distance, after which I thought about how the blood and clothes were leaving a trail. I carried him on my broad shoulders, laughing in the dark; even though he looked bulky, I hardly felt any weight on my shoulders.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

Ammu used to sing this song when I was a little kid. I was homeschooled in my initial years, as my uncle never gave *Ammu* money to spend on me. The song was a rhyme, 'I am a little star,' which became our favourite, as I was a star in her eyes. I felt like a star, and when it was my time to shine, I would sing this song to let the world know.

I sang the lullaby before entering the cabin. I had taken the spare keys from my uncle's pocket, the jingling of which I hated all my life. That clinking sound used to remind me that he was around, and I used to abhor his presence. I threw the lock along with the keys as far as possible.

The cabin opened, and the smell of closed space mixed with termites, wood, and stale air hit my nose. It reminded me of when I hid in a closet to escape the wrath of my uncle's belt; hence, decrepit structures gave me solace.

I lowered Ayaan from my shoulders; he was still unconscious from the shock. He was breathing, and his bleeding had almost stopped. I wondered what to do next. The cabin had some equipment from the trekking expeditions Mr Sherpa used to conduct with his friends, and I used the rope to tie his hands and feet tight. Doing so made me feel powerful as I could control someone's life. I had just ended one person's life, and this other person's heartbeats were at my mercy, too.

I left the cabin, bolting it from outside, thinking that Ayaan would now meet whatever fate my *Ammu* wished for him.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

— —

Ammu embraced me with open arms. She was impressed at the flawlessness of my execution. I told her how I pushed him down the valley, went down again to ensure he was dead, used the tree branch, and then burnt it to destroy any evidence. She raised her hands and cried joyfully, simulating the small dance move of a prisoner who finally gets freedom from years of captivity.

Before I could tell her about Ayaan, she told me how proud she was of me. How I was her saviour, and how her husband had met the death he deserved. She told me how now we both would have the life of a queen and a prince, rolling in luxuries and money. She patted my back, kissed my forehead, and asked me to clean up so she could get me chocolate milk before I slept.

“You are my little star, *Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala...*” she hummed as she went into the kitchen.

As the blood washed away from my body, *Ammu* took away my clothes to burn them.

“We should not leave any trace,” she had told me earlier. She had also asked me to break my mobile after doing the job and throw it somewhere on the way, so I did the same. Nothing could be traced back to Shine Resort. To her and me.

Except for that intruder, Ayaan.

As the warm water from the bucket brought respite to my sore shoulders, so I wondered if I should share this part of the truth with the happy woman. I sipped the hot chocolate and wondered what she would say when she found out about Ayaan. Would she still be proud of me? Would she ask me to go ahead and kill Ayaan, too? Or would she be angry that I could not do even one job correctly? Thoughts wandered through my mind until my eyes closed, and I began to dream of *Ammu* and me running the biggest resort chain in Sikkim.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

— —

A hysterical *Ammu* woke me up, saying that one of the guests, Rati, complained that her person, Ayaan, was missing. I knew where he was, and before Aunt could goof up anything, I advised her to repeat one thing — that she had never seen Ayaan. She asked me why, even though she didn’t distinctly remember his presence anyway. But I had my reason: Ayaan was trying to hide his identity. I knew this as I had seen him in two rooms at once, and he had given me sufficient cash to keep mum about it.

It was none of my business.

It became my business only when he saw me near Mr Fernandez’s body, and I had no other option but to hit him.

Except for me, no one in the resort had seen him with Rati. They had seen him with the other guest, Shikha. I knew two people would look for him now, and I would need to continue to derail the search process. If someone asked, I would also tell them I had never seen him with Rati.

When the police arrived, *Ammu* panicked, and I had never seen her so fragile. I had no other option but to come clean in front of her. If she knew the truth, she might better control herself. And she did when I told her what had happened. Some people operate better when there is no ambiguity, and everything is clear, so they know what steps must be taken.

And she took the most brazen step then. It had been over 18 hours, and Ayaan had not surfaced from the cabin.

“Let him rot there. His being alive will be detrimental to our plans, and it’s better that he gets discovered by himself instead of you going there again and checking on him. The police in Dzongu are incompetent, and it will take ages to discover my dead husband and then Ayaan, and it would take them even longer to narrow it down to you and me,” she told me the night police left the resort.

— —

There is a sadistic pleasure in watching investigators bob around like headless chickens. *Ammu* was right, and even after 36 hours of him lying in the valley, they had not discovered my uncle’s body. We knew it would happen sooner or later, and our scripts were ready. We were prepared to be the grief-stricken family who could not come to terms with the head of the family passing away. After all, he had just stepped out to meet friends and have drinks. Was it an accident? Would someone kill him? But why? He had no enemies. We had to be the innocent rabbits, helpless souls who had to make peace so that their patriarch was called by God sooner, as he was a good man.

I saw the men scrambling around, that hot guest, Rati, playing with her hair and acting like the perfect damsel in distress (I hated bimbettes), and a middle-aged policeman, Sami, eager to prove his worth. The guest, Shikha, checked out, and half of my problems disappeared.

Ammu and I sat back and enjoyed the spectacle while the buffoons kept at it.

The first time we were called, we put up quite a show. *Ammu* had perfected the act of a grieving widow, and I acted as the composed nephew who would now need to be the man of the house. When we were in front of the dead body, *Ammu* started howling, but it was with incredible difficulty. I shed a tear or two, but little did they know they were tears of pure bliss.

When we were called to the police station, our stories had to be straight. We knew nothing after my uncle left to meet his friends. It was nothing unusual. We remembered when he vanished for more than two nights because he was in a drunken stupor at an illegal betting place near West Bengal. So, we did not panic when he did not show up for the past two nights again. We knew nothing — and so, the police officers did not bother us as we looked grief-stricken from losing our beloved Mr Fernandez.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

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It was fine until I was pulled out of bed at 3 a.m. Even *Ammu* was taken aback. We had planned multiple scenarios, but the way I was brought up to the police station felt like the police had solid evidence, like CCTV footage of me while in the act. Another possibility could have been that they had found a witness.

Later, I knew it was based on scenarios like ‘your mobile connection was nearby,’ ‘you are shady,’ and ‘do you have an alibi?’, but still, they would never be able to narrow down on the motive, the murder weapon, and me in the end, as I had left no loose ends.

A mastermind who thought ahead of the curve, significantly ahead of the mediocre populace, would never be caught. Also, when the interrogating officer is someone like the ageing man ‘Sami,’ you would sit back and relax while the man in the uniform goofs it up and kills any chance the police ever had of catching me. You would laugh at his pointless questions and act thoughtfully to boost his insecurities. You would massage his ego and act like you are on the fence while you let him think he is in the lead. You would provoke him by challenging his intelligence with your eyes but also making your words sound like you are cooperating completely.

When he’d let you go, exasperated, you would know he would return or send his men, who would come with a vengeance on their minds. But you wouldn’t mind, as you would have achieved your life’s purpose: to

bring happiness to your aunt. And to get the monster in her life out of the way.

The police station, even though mediocre, was at it slowly. *Ammu* and I underestimated their rigour and teamwork. Also, when the experts lie idle for a long time, they thrive at any opportunity, which I understood during my interrogation with Sami. The forensic team based in Gangtok was one of the best in this part of the country.

I waited for them to bounce back slowly. I looked at that door, day and night, while *Ammu* wondered what was wrong with me. I knew it would happen, one day or the other, but the chase between the cat and the mouse was thrilling, and I was fine playing it while hiding in my hole.

And then, on the fourth day after I kidnapped Ayaan and left him to die, the damned hour came to life to wipe out my palace of bliss. The knock told me who was on the other side of the door, and even before *Ammu* could open it, I hugged her, knowing very well that it could be the last time I did.

Shalala, Shalala, Shalala, Shalala.

The Wit Game

Vipin

The DGP had ensured that we got an interrogation room in the headquarters in Gangtok, the only one in Sikkim. The state with a low crime rate did not require any corner where we would need to get a confession from a criminal. Of course, it had witnessed murders, but the media had amped up the double murder and made it the talk of the northeast.

DGP Sharma had turned around since I pushed him back, and he probably considered milking this situation for his benefit. In the end, he had higher-ups, and I was under his reporting line. If I did well, his record would look good, too.

My staff had arrested Shyam a few hours back, and he walked into the Gangtok police station with a smug smile. The media clicked his photos as Dipen, and I walked him from the corridor toward the interrogation room. A few journalists shouted his name, and he looked back at each of them, displaying the shrewdness of a shark. He raised his handcuffed hands, trying to wave at all those looking at him through the camera. It was almost like that was all he ever wanted: attention.

The interrogation room was 8 feet by 12 feet of ample space, good enough for a camera to be hinged on the front to record the accused's expressions, and another one on the top corner, giving a 360 view of the room. The ceiling, about 10 feet high, made it feel slightly less cramped, and the blue colour on the walls added to a grim vibe. Three feet above the ground, a six-inch-thick wooden panel ran through the room. Below the panel was a cream wallpaper, which had been hand-painted flowers by an amateur artist.

The ceiling was painted white, and I noticed that there was no ventilation in the room at all. No window, fan, no AC, no heater. Just the room and the door. And a table should have been in a chipper ten years ago. I reminded myself not to bang my fist on it, as I doubted the table could

bear any weights other than the paperweight. The old steel chairs seemed happy, like somebody had removed the rust on them just before we arrived. The stench from an overused and dirty dusting cloth filled the room, mixed with the phenyl from the mop, an uncomfortable combination.

Dipen noticed me rolling my eyes at the pathetic state of the room and my helplessness to do anything about it. “I think Shyam will confess even without us asking a question,” Dipen said, and we laughed.

Shyam was held outside for a routine security check, and the door remained half open. My eyes locked into his, and he did not flinch. He seemed prepared for what would come next, and his look challenged me to reveal all the cards up my sleeve.

As he entered the room, I rolled up my sleeves and adjusted myself in the seat.

— —

“Can I have some water?” Shyam asked.

I looked at Dipen, who nodded and pushed his chair back to get some water, preferably a jug. I took out my little pad and a pen as his eyes pierced through my every move. Shyam had a negative aura accompanying him. Some people make you uncomfortable just with their presence. I took a deep breath to calm myself.

“Hope this room does not fall off before we begin the conversation. Hope that seepage in the ceiling is the only problem the cobweb is hiding?” He sat back as he spoke, gauging my reaction. Even in distress, the bastard wanted to be treated like a king.

I noticed the marks of a chewed-up betel leaf in the corner. I wondered who ate that in this confinement. I looked at Shyam, who was still looking at me, waiting for the answer to the irrelevant question he had asked me a few seconds back. I cleared my throat.

“Hope we get answers to all our questions from you before that. Also, one more thing: in this room, we are the ones who ask questions, and you are the one who answers.” I tried to maintain my poise, being as nonchalant as possible while being assertive.

“Fair enough,” he said and leaned on his chair.

Dipen stepped back into the room with a glass of water and a steel jug, keeping them carefully on the tabletop. He sensed the tension in the room

and sat down while nodding at me. I had asked him to take the lead earlier.

He started recording audio and video. The red button, once pressed, brought all three men to action, albeit mentally.

“You know why you are here, right, Shyam?” Dipen asked him.

“No,” he said.

“No?” Dipen reacted like a rookie, and I gave him a look of disapproval. He needed to better anticipate the mind of that not-so-ordinary criminal.

“No,” Shyam repeated, his eyes fixed on me. He wanted me to react and ask questions. He wanted the alpha in the room to respond. I couldn’t give him that. The game is on, fucker. I had no expressions, and my gaze returned to his.

“Well, what can you tell us about the last time you saw Mr Fernandez?” Dipen went back a few steps to keep pace with Shyam.

“My dead uncle or someone else with the same name?” He asked.

“The former,” Dipen continued. “You are here because we believe you have some details about his death.”

“Did your colleague not share his notes with you? Or did he forget to take them at all!” He laughed boisterously at his joke while Dipen and I gave him a look that we give a toddler throwing tantrums. He stopped after a while, unconcerned by the fact that we did not join his revelry.

“I don’t think you shared all the details with my colleague the last time, right? To refresh our memory, please run us through the night when your uncle went missing?” Dipen asked.

“Be specific, please. He did not come back for a couple of nights, and we only came to know he wouldn’t ever once you guys discovered his body. Are you a rookie? You don’t seem to be asking the right questions,” Shyam replied.

“The first night when your uncle did not return home,” Dipen said. I knew Dipen was trained not to let any expression come on his face, but his ears turned red after the derogatory remark from Shyam.

“As I had told you before, I was sleeping in my home after returning from the resort. Wait, you were there that day at the station, too, and you gave me that look. You told me I would be back only if you had additional proof. So, do you have it? Otherwise, as I had warned you, I will complain about harassment and the heights of incompetency of this entire team!” He stood up, trying to be dramatic, and I spoke after a long time.

“Sit down,” is all I said. And he did.

“Have you told us everything about that night? Because we have proof that you have not. I will give you one more chance to come clean, as we know you are hiding more than you are sharing,” I asserted.

“Go ahead. I don’t have anything more to share,” Shyam replied.

Dipen took a deep breath. “We believe that you were at the murder spot multiple times during or after when the murder took place. The only time you were there, as you told us, was when we called you to identify your uncle’s body. But that is not true, and we have proof against it.

Shyam just raised his eyebrows, encouraging Dipen to go on.

“You were in the cabin where we found another dead body. Your footprints are all over the place. Your fingerprints are all over the place. The person died after Mr Fernandez’s death, and we could trace your footprints in the trail between both dead bodies,” Dipen said calmly.

Dipen was bluffing, as the footprints could not be traced all the way. The dogs traced the scent and blood, and we connected the dots. But Shyam does not need to know that.

For the first time, Shyam’s smug look wore down, and he took the first sip of water. I understood that he had not anticipated this question. He was unaware that we had found Ayaan. He needed time to think.

“Which cabin are you talking about?” He asked Dipen.

“There is only one cabin in the area. The one that Mr Sherpa owned. Your uncle’s friend,” Dipen replied.

“Oh, that! Yes, I go there frequently to gather my thoughts. That may explain all the footprints and fingerprints. It’s like you questioning why I have footprints and fingerprints in the resort or my house. I went there a week or two back when everyone was alive. There was no dead body then.” Shyam said as he sipped water again, the second time. It was apparent that he felt that he had given a satisfactory answer.

Dipen got a call and excused himself from the room. I sat there observing Shyam, who was not looking at me now. He wasn’t as comfortable and confident as before. I could sense we were onto something. Dipen did not return for a few minutes, and no one spoke. I kept looking at Shyam with a stolid expression, and he kept sipping water, playing with the pen, fidgeting on his chair, shaking his legs, and occasionally looking at me and passing a nervous smile.

Sami came inside the room instead of Dipen, and Shyam immediately adjusted himself into the seat. His smug smile came back, and I saw his chin going up. "How are you doing, uncle?" Shyam asked him as if they were relatives.

Sami chose not to respond. He seemed like a man on a mission who did not want to pay any heed to the stray dogs barking in the background. He opened a file and breathed hard, even though he seemed poised. I know he was out to get Shyam, especially since it happened the other way around the last time.

Shyam did not flinch because of Sami's indifference; he kept smiling.

"So, apart from the cabin, you were never near the murder site in the last few weeks?" Sami asked, right to the point.

"No, I wasn't. The cabin was also some two weeks back." Shyam replied, acting as if he was a little hurt by Sami's indifference earlier.

"So, you wouldn't be touching any trees while you walk, I assume... or branches. After all, you are not a monkey." Shyam huffed with derision but did not answer anything.

It then did strike him that Sami may have come upon something, as his aura was different today.

"We are expecting an answer," I said.

"No comments," Shyam replied.

"You choose to say, 'no comments' now?" I said, deepening the knife into the butter. "Okay, how about this? What if we say we found a tree bark with your fingerprints all over it."

"No comments," Shyam said.

"What if that tree bark had Mr Fernandez's blood on it?" I went deeper with the knife.

He quickly said 'no comments' again, but his tone had changed this time. He seemed rushed and hassled. In his mind, it was evident that he was trying to determine if we had found the murder weapon, even though he had put the same in a bonfire. He shifted in his seat and looked at Sami.

Sami laughed and said, "Did I not tell you, kid? That you could tell me more if you wanted to last time? See, you could have admitted killing your uncle, and then no one would have searched for the murder weapon and bumped into Ayaan's body. So, you alone are to be blamed for your situation."

"No comments," Shyam replied.

We kept mum for close to fifteen seconds, and then I spoke.

“I will tell you what happened, Shyam. You killed Mr Fernandez and threw out the murder weapon, thinking it would burn. Ayaan was either involved in this crime with you, or he saw you doing this, and hence, you wanted him to get out of the picture, too. Since we could not trace any records between you and him connecting on the phone, we assume he wasn’t an accomplice but a witness. You kidnapped him because you were unsure if you wanted to kill him then and there. You wondered whether to go back, thought better of it, and never went back to rescue him, letting him rot.” I said it all in one breath. It was a convincing story. I was unsure of the real one, but this was most plausible given the circumstances.

Shyam’s expressions changed, and I knew there was more truth in that story than I had imagined. His eyes seemed to panic now, even though he feigned calm. He picked up the pen again and played a bit, tapping it on the table rigorously. “No comments,” he said again.

“Really? Do you want me not to say anything about that? Or do you want us to use other techniques for you to come out and tell the truth?” I tried to provoke him through a threat, and it worked.

“What are you guys, bullies? I will complain about this to the media, which is right outside. You are forcing me to give a false confession. Do you think I am that naive? I am not speaking any other word till you get me a lawyer.” Shyam said. He knew his rights and was playing smartly.

Sami wasn’t. He kept breathing hard, tapping his foot, and fidgeting his legs in quick motion on that steel chair. “Lawyer, eh? Media, eh?” He warned. Something in his voice was terrifying, and Shyam and I sank into our seats.

“No comments,” Shyam said.

Sami banged the table. He came forward, almost leaning into Shyam and looking into his eyes. Shyam stared back with a tinge of fear in his eyes. He never expected the old man to scare him that much.

“Let me see if you have no comments about the fact that you killed him for her, eh?” Sami said. Shyam did not reply, but the atmosphere in the room told me that Sami had struck the right chord.

“That, that is your motive, isn’t it? We did a cross-check, and Ms Fernandez will now be the nominee to receive multiple land assets across the state. So, you guys got rid of him itself,” he said. Shyam did not reply but started looking at his foot.

“Or is there some other reason why you killed him? Were you jealous of him or something?” Sami said, with Shyam raising his eyebrows as if Sami had asked a stupid question.

But Sami continued, “Oh, I get it now. Not only was Mr Fernandez a horrible husband to your Aunt, but you are also in love with her. Isn’t it? Isn’t it true that you make love to her when the uncle is not around? Do you like to have old wine in the sack? You filthy, disgusting, perverted rat!”

Shyam jumped from his seat, leaned himself, and caught Sami’s collar. His eyes were red, and he was shaking in anger. He was agitated that words could not come out of his mouth, and his mental state triggered vigorous bruxism.

I stayed still, my fingers stuck to my revolver. We were seconds away from a confession, and I noticed Sami was on alert, too.

Sami went even more forward, the distance between their faces less than an inch. He said the following sentence very slowly, enunciating each word very clearly — “Oh! So that is what you want. To make love to your aunt. You couldn’t let that old man touch her anymore. Is she a cougar, or is she a whore like you?”

In a quick motion, Shyam picked up the pen from the table and brought it next to Sami’s neck. “Ssshhh! Careful, old man,” he said in a heavy whisper... “One more word against my mother, and I will stab this pen into your neck and bring you the sweet release of death. Just like I did to that old man who disrespected my *Ammu*, his wife. One, two, three, four, five, and six. Those are all the stabs it would take me to remove your soul from your worthless body.” With that, he pushed Sami back to his chair while he remained in the same position.

Sami and I burst out laughing, and after a few seconds, Shyam came out of his paranoia. He dropped the pen on the table and fell back into the chair as Dipen entered the interrogation room.

We continued to laugh as Shyam rested his head on his hand, and Dipen made himself comfortable on the seat.

“Carry on with his confession. Focus on the Ayaan part,” I said, and Dipen nodded.

Shyam looked at Sami, petrified. As we left the room, Sami smiled and said to Dipen, “Don’t underestimate an old cookie, kiddo.”

I felt relief as we submitted a five-page confession report to DGP Mr Sharma. He had organised a press conference in an hour to inform the media and people of the state that the double murder case had been solved. In five days, we had arrested the killer. His team was the best, and the Dzongu team was the one he was the proudest of. He was also appreciative of the forensic department. And yes, people could now go home and rest in peace.

He patted my back and said, “Your next posting will be to a place that deserves you and the one you want.” I acknowledged his compliment with an ‘I am grateful’ nod.

“Will you be around, sir?” I asked. He smiled.

Goodbye Dzongu Rati

We were at the Gangtok airport, and for some reason, many police officers came to drop off Shikha and me.

Ayaan was dead, and his killer was Shyam. There was no reason behind his death except that he was in the wrong place at the wrong time. Shikha and I wondered what he was doing there at that time of the night. As far as I remember, Ayaan and I were drinking that night, and he may have slipped out after I slept. Probably to meet Shikha. But he did not go to meet her. He was probably too drunk, and he lost his way through the resort and went down to the valley. It was a long shot, but the police said it was the most plausible explanation. Shikha and my statements were taken along with others and the case was closed. The killer was behind the bars.

Shikha and I came to a consensus. It was his karma, and it was his destiny to die that day. We had decided to dig into his life deeper once we were back, as there were many others he may have conned in his worthless years of living, and they all needed to know that the asshole had met his end.

At the airport, Sami, Dipen, and Jimmy hugged me. It is unfathomable how strangers become close to you once you have gone through life-altering experiences with them. I asked them to buzz me if they came to NCR, and they asked me to revisit Sikkim, albeit this time for hopefully a more relaxing vacation. Vipin, for some reason, stayed aloof and kept talking to Shikha. He was embarrassed, or overwhelmed, or both. I looked at him looking at me for a moment, but then his eyes immediately returned to Shikha.

I noticed it was boarding time and wished goodbye to the three guys. I walked a few steps and asked Shikha to join me. She wished Vipin goodbye, and we both moved towards the boarding gate. As we pushed the trollies, Vipin called out my name. I heard it the first time, but I waited for him to repeat it before I stopped.

He came running towards me and struggled with words. I gave him time, along with an affectionate smile.

“I, I... I will miss you,” he said. And my smile widened.

During these days, I learned that good men are still around. They may be stoic, not flamboyant, and they may have their flaws, but God has not stopped making them. Chivalry was not dead. Honesty and loyalty were not dead. Love was not dead. Hope was not dead.

Something overpowered me, and I went ahead and kissed his unshaven cheek. I could feel his hand coming closer to my waist, but he pulled it back immediately. He stood there, cherishing the biggest moment of his life.

The others around us giggled, and I kept smiling at Vipin.

As I waved him goodbye and pushed my trolley forward, he smiled, too. This was something I had seen for the first time in the last six days I had known this stranger.

When we reached the airport gate, after verification from the security, I heard him shout, “I will come to Gurgaon to see you, Rati.”

I shouted back – “I hope you do.”

— —

Shikha had asked me what my plans were after I reached Gurgaon.

“Hopefully, I will resume work and relocate to a new place, as my current apartment has many memories of Ayaan. And yes, maybe consult my therapist.” I laughed.

Shikha joined too.

“What have been the reasons you have had so many nightmares all your life?” She asked.

“Many,” I replied. “The therapist told me I was highly intuitive and could sense things as they would or were about to happen. Also, since my childhood had been traumatic, growing up in hostels and with abusive parents, I tend to forget incidents that have been excruciating for me. They remain in my subconscious and later haunt me as nightmares. Some nightmares are because of innate fear, and some insecurities get picked up along the way, so the list is long...” I took a deep breath.

Shikha rubbed my shoulder and said that I could call her anytime I needed something. I told her the same as we both closed our eyes. Our flight soared in the sky, and I wished goodbye to Dzongu.

Loose Ends

Vipin

The case was closed, and the accused was behind bars. I knew Shyam was guilty, and we had our perfect confession and documentation, and everything else was in place. Months passed, and I officially submitted the last documentation to the authorities for record keeping.

I still wondered if Ayaan had died any other way. Shyam had said he had hit Ayaan once on the head, probably one more time after that, but that was all. Dr Rai shared that while that was enough to drive him unconscious, it seemed that there was one blow from a heavy object on his groin. It was not severe, but recent. Almost like when a wooden chair crashes against you when you are drunk, he had been hit in the skull with something apart from the rock, something sturdy like a boot. I wondered if all that belonged to the third person, whose trail we lost in the stream. Others asked me not to worry about this, as Shyam had already confessed, but I still wondered. There was a minuscule chance that Shyam had not murdered Ayaan, but I told myself I had to learn to live with this self-doubt. There was no point overthinking something that was already done and dusted.

My worries were forgotten as laurels poured in for my team and me. After we solved the case, people used to come forward and click selfies with me whenever I walked in the streets. Locals would occasionally pour in with homemade food, and we were invited to every celebration, big or small, at a house, venue, or religious place. We were the stars of Dzongu.

The silver lining in the dark cloud after the double murder case in Dzongu was that multiple CCTV cameras and numerous mobile towers were installed in the town. Better connectivity, and a lower chance of crime, hopefully.

Ms Fernandez had sold the resort and all other assets in her husband's name. Last I heard, she had shifted her base outside India. They may have said she was grieving, but I had a strong hunch that she was the mastermind behind all this. And while Shyam was writing 'Ammu' on the prison walls,

‘Ammu’ was off to a foreign land, vacationing and probably sipping wine with a young steward.

Rati and I had been in touch, and our relationship had strengthened. We had not met after that, but we had practically been texting and WhatsApping throughout the day and night. After a point in time, it had become a routine. Almost like how your heart pumps blood into your veins. Almost like how air filled your lungs. It was just a habit, and it was there.

I wondered if Rati would be the one, or was already my one? This was unusual, as I used to quickly move on in my past relationships. This one was carrying on.

I had accepted that my feelings for her were not merely physical attraction, or a fleeting infatuation. This was something more, and I wanted to explore it. If I met her now, I would not let her go. Maybe she would become my seraph, and the answer to my questions. The Juliet to my Romeo.

I was about to complete a year in Dzongu, and the officials had asked me where I wanted to get transferred to next. Given my exemplary performance, they were ready to cut the ‘three-year’ period short to one, as the recommendation had come from the state ministry itself. The choice was mine, and I was the star of Sikkim Police — the blue-eyed boy. I could have decided to stay in Sikkim or return to Kerala, but I put my number one preference as the place where my heart had permanently shifted. Where I could finally unite with the love of my life.

Gurgaon.

A New Beginning

Rati's therapist helped her understand that her nightmares from Dzongu were visualisations of monsters like Shyam and some other folklore she had picked up while in Sikkim. She was advised not to travel near any mountain places for a few years because there was a chance, she would relive the trauma she had gone through because of Ayaan's betrayal and his mysterious death. She promised her therapist to look forward to life.

She told the therapist all about Vipin, who was on his way to Delhi to meet her. They had been talking incessantly for the last few months and were now inseparable. Her therapist said she should take this as a new beginning and give her 100% to this relationship, as men like Vipin were rare.

Vipin had got the posting he wanted, and his plane from Gangtok had landed in Delhi a short while ago. He could not wait for the 'unlock-your-seat-belt' announcement and rushed past some passengers to get out of the plane.

Rati stood at the arrivals gate, waiting to spot Vipin. He saw her first and gave her a wave. He noticed she was wearing the same co-ord set in which he had seen her for the first time. She looked even more beautiful that day, if that was possible. However, unlike the last time, she was not wearing sneakers. She was wearing boots. A thought crossed Vipin's mind, but he brushed it off and walked towards his seraph.

Rati could not take her eyes off Vipin. Now, in a casual outfit, he looked even more handsome.

A butterfly flew in front of her eyes once, twice, thrice. Rati tried shooing it away through her hands, but it would not go, almost like a stubborn bee. It finally sat at a railing, where one of Rati's hands was perched on the horizontal bars.

The last time she saw a butterfly of that kind was in Dzongu, and she remembered that Ayaan had told her it was the mountain tiger butterfly. The thought of Ayaan disturbed her, and a sudden rage flew through her veins.

Vipin was a few feet away when he called her name. She looked up, smiled, and waved with one hand.

Her other hand that clenched the railing had a smashed butterfly underneath the fingers.

Epilogue

The Night Of The Murder

The cottage reverberated with sounds of laughter, the beats thumping in the background, and the tea plantation tried its best to subsume the echo. The lights shimmered in the background, bringing life at an odd hour, the time when humans went to sleep and the devils woke up.

Only the moon knew what it was about to witness, and it hid behind the clouds as the sight would be too painful.

Now tipsy on tequila shots, Ayaan wondered how he would end things with Rati that night. He planned to kill her and make it look like a suicide or an accident. Rati had signed the insurance papers yesterday and had not noticed the dates on the document, which Ayaan had back-dated to a date three months before. That was the benefit of taking advantage of people who trust another person immensely — they are blinded by love, almost always.

During his multiple smoke outings, Ayaan had zeroed in at the hairpin point. It was also where Ayaan took pictures of Rati with the backdrop of the Himalayas, one of the many gorgeous views in Sikkim. A mountain gap formed an inchoate valley, separating the highway and the mountain where Shine Resort was situated. By foot, it was an easy trek of an hour. It was a place where Rati would be considered missing for a few days and would then be eventually “found”, unlike some of the deeper ravines, where anything that fell vanished in the melancholy of its existence.

Rati drank too much and was unable to move. Ayaan had mistakenly called her Shikha before they began the game of who would drink more, but she was too happy to give it a second thought. As she lay down for a while, Ayaan thought of going and checking out the place of her death, nonetheless. He planned to have an early morning trek with her before the dawn broke so that he could still come back and meet Shikha for breakfast. Shikha would be his alibi if anyone questioned him later on. She wasn't aware that Rati was in the resort, too. And Ayaan had not left any trace in Rati's room that would have validated his presence.

Except for Shyam, whom he had stuffed with money to keep his mouth shut. He had questioned Ayaan if he had met Rati in her room, and without

answering, Ayaan had denied it and given him money not to ask any more questions. Shyam smiled and stopped.

— —

As the clouds cleared later that night, Ayaan removed his belongings and threw them in the ravine beside the cottage, ensuring no human would ever reach there. As he had to go and check out the point where he planned to kill Rati, he left a short note - 'Be right back.' In case Rati woke up before he came back, she would not create any scene to spoil his plans.

Ayaan's trek down the resort was dreamy, with the moon shining bright. He was already on cloud nine thinking about how his life would change a couple of hours later, and the adrenaline rush had worn down the effects of the alcohol. He felt proud of how patient he had been. Of how he was able to double-time so efficiently. Of how he had planned it all so well. Of how he was a wise man in choosing the most gullible person one could ever find. Also, Rati's mental health and history had been an excellent aid to Ayaan. He felt that he was not afraid of animals, ghosts, or the darkness in general, as there could be no spirit more horrible than the one he was living with.

His incoherent thoughts were interrupted when he saw a man a few feet away at the bottom of the valley under that hairpin point. He appeared all of a sudden, as the moon was playing hide and seek with the clouds. It looked like this man was hitting something with a piece of wood, and Ayaan could only assume it was a dead animal. The man who had the weapon looked familiar, and Ayaan had to go closer to identify who he was. When the moonlight came out of the clouds again, and the wind stopped momentarily, he heard the man hurling abuses in the air. Ayaan then identified him, as the side face became apparent. It was Shyam.

Ayaan immediately hid himself behind the trees, quite close to where Shyam was standing. Ayaan's eyes enlarged as he realised Shyam was standing beside another human. He panicked to run, and his sudden movement rustled some leaves, and Shyam looked back to check who it was. Ayaan held his breath to give no indication that someone was watching him, as he was now sure that Shyam had killed someone. Ayaan heard Shyam go away before releasing his breath. He stood there for some more time, and when Shyam did not come back, he went to check who Shyam had killed.

As he went closer and looked, the person on the ground seemed familiar. He bled profusely, and many of the bones in his body seemed broken. Ayaan was terrified of what he had just seen and almost peed in my pants out of fear. "What a monster Shyam is!" he thought. Ayaan knew that the sight of Shyam hitting this poor man with a tree bark over and over again would give him nightmares in the years to come.

He thought of running away before someone spotted him and associated him with this gruesome murder, so he took a few steps back. Dead leaves crackled under his feet, and he missed the sound of someone approaching him. Ayaan turned around only to be hit by a heavy object, courtesy of Shyam.

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Ayaan woke up to a faintly lit candle — his hands and legs were tied together with a rope. His mouth was not taped, though, and he screamed loudly as soon as he came to his senses, "HELP!!!" He regretted it instantly, as Shyam may have come to know that he had woken up. Ayaan wondered if Shyam was planning to kill two people in one night, like a psycho.

His head spun because of the blood loss, but he was determined to free myself. He was in Dzongu to kill Rati and not be fodder for a frustrated man. The way Shyam butchered that other man lying in the valley showed he had some scores to settle.

An idea struck him.

Ayaan used the candle to slowly burn the rope tying his hands. As soon as his hands got free, he immediately untied his legs. He used the candle to look around where he was, and it seemed like a cabin that had not been used for some months. He couldn't sit there waiting for Shyam to decide what to do with him. Ayaan looked through the wooden cracks in the wall and couldn't spot anyone near the cabin, and he had good visibility with the moon shining bright outside. It was going to be dawn soon. The place housed some rodents, too, and he could hear their creepy squeaks and decided to leave the cabin immediately.

Ayaan blew the candle out, the smoke being the only white in the dark. He threw it to the side, and slowly opened the creaking cabin door. As he

took a few steps outside, he saw someone rushing towards him, and it was not Shyam.

At that moment, Ayaan's heart skipped a beat.

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“Rati!” he shouted. Ayaan was happy to see her. Her presence made him feel safe. He guessed that she had come to save him following his scream from earlier. However, the euphoria got over quickly, as she seemed distant.

“What are you doing here?” he asked.

She seemed angry. Ayaan got a bit worried. She seemed like a person who was holding on to a lot. And she did not seem happy that Ayaan had just escaped from the hands of a kidnapper.

“What are you doing here?” he asked again.

“I saw you sneaking out of the bed, the cottage, and then going into the forest. I followed you down but lost you in between. Then I heard a scream near the end of the valley, and I was looking for you, I heard another cry for help a few minutes ago. I could see a dim light in the cabin, and I assumed this is where you would be.” Her voice was dry and mechanical.

“Thank God you came. Let's quickly walk away from here before that psycho Shyam comes back. He hit me on the head with something. A rock, I guess. Can you believe it? Let's go, let's get out of here,” he said.

She did not reply. She stood still, her eyes trying to gauge Ayaan. She seemed different, and Ayaan thought he would need to devise another plan to kill her. Push her down some other cliff, maybe. Anyway, that was for later; he had to focus on saving his life first.

“Let's go, Rati,” he said, but she did not move. She seemed transfixed, looking at the ground, then raised her head. Ayaan imagined her eyes turning red in the dark, and her lips quivered. Very slowly and quietly, she said, “I thought you went out to meet Shikha.”

The air vanished between them, creating a vacuum as the crickets stopped chirping. The clouds dissolved in the night as the moon turned dark. Ayaan felt his body smothered by the burden of his lie, which Rati had just caught.

He laughed nervously. “Who, Shikha? Oh, the name I said before we started shots? I was thinking about this big project back in the office, and

she is part of the client team and a pain in the ass. Don't worry about it," he replied with another nervous chuckle at the end.

"I saw her name in the register earlier, and I saw you sneaking into her room, fucking her behind those curtain cracks. I am not a fool, and I know that you made me sign the insurance dated back three months as part of the plan to kill me. I may seem gullible, but I am not. Tell me," she paused for a second and then screamed, "How were you planning to kill me, asshole?"

The ground beneath his feet slipped away as she pushed him hard with a sinister force. He could not fathom how she came to know about his plans, but she was not the fawn he had imagined her to be. It was all changing, too quickly for him to think in that state. At that moment, Rati seemed like a fierce, mad woman out to get vengeance. She picked up the axe she had brought with her and then clenched her teeth, her face seemingly possessed by the devil. She swayed the axe at him, laughing eerily, and Ayaan shivered. He managed to run towards the forest, but she caught up with him and got hold of his legs.

She came on top of him, and he was weak, given the blood loss from the concussion some time ago. He tried to punch her hard, but ended up with a soft blow to her face. Ayaan's head was reeling with pain, and she used the wooden side of the axe to hit his thigh. He felt one of his bones crack, and instantly, delirium set in. He slowly resigned himself to his inevitable fate.

As the moon shone bright, he noticed the blood from his head had made its way onto her body, especially on her face and head. He saw her taking a few steps towards him, and then she spat on his face. His ego got hurt, and when he tried to stand up to retaliate, revolting now with abuse, she kicked his face and then his groin with her boots.

The world blacked out for Ayaan.

— —

She sat before Ayaan, her hands and face resting on her knees as her eyes stared at him. Her face was impassive, and the candle was lit again. His hands and legs were tied as well, this time tighter. His leg was writhing in pain, and so was his head, and Ayaan implored her to set him free.

She smiled eerily again. “You know, the mountain rats are three times larger than the house rats. The snakes are more venomous as well. The death they bring once they bite you is slow and more painful. But patience is your virtue, as you went behind me, planning to kill me from day one of our meeting a few years ago. I am not that cruel, though. I am leaving you here, ensuring you can’t escape and will die this painful death eventually. Within a few hours, these rodents will find you.”

Ayaan begged her to free him. And she clapped. She clapped so hard that the candle blew out.

He heard her opening the door, and then saw her face lit by the moonlight. Her smile had her mandibular teeth mocking at Ayaan, and her eyes were blackened out by the shadows to look like those of a ghoul. Ayaan refused to believe that his dreams were shattered, even as she walked out that door.

He tried to move but could not. Within a few minutes, the blood coming out of multiple wounds on his body attracted a loud squeak and a bite in the dark. The bite turned to many bites quickly, and he screamed in pain as it increased every moment. He tried to think about how to escape, but when he heard a hiss and felt something slither under his calves, he screamed and blacked out.

Only his soul watched in horror as his heart stopped pumping blood through his body at the fifth hour of the night.

— —

Rati dawdled along the path back to the resort like a body without a soul, her feet crushing the leaves, kicking the stones, and getting wet in the stream. She reached her cottage, her eyes blank with expression, and her mind shunned the trauma as she went under the blankets and fell asleep. The dawn broke the sky’s stubbornness, even though the sun struggled to peep through the clouds. It started to rain, a drop falling before the others followed.

After a while, the lightning struck, and the clock turned 6.30 am.

The End

More Books by Rahul Jain

Rahul's first work was *The Fleeting Emotions*, an anthology of seven short stories narrating tales around ephemeral emotions that profoundly impact our lives. The second work was a novel titled *The Other Angle*, centred around LGBTQIA+ experiences. It intertwined the lives of three protagonists caught in a myriad of less-spoken societal issues related to sexual orientation and mental awareness. His third work, *Equals*, another anthology of seven short stories, explores the theme of equality in society, and how individuals strive to achieve it in their social stature and relationships. Rahul's fourth work, *Wayanad*, is a dedication to his love for Kerala. It is a coming-of-age story that follows the journey of a boy with a turbulent childhood amidst the beauty of Wayanad, who ultimately discovers peace in his chaotic world through the outsider perspective of his non-Keralite soulmate.